Shattered Trust, Fragile Hope

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/81024091.

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Explicit

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Shattered Trust, Fragile Hope

by weedcatra420

Summary

A year ago, Catra D'riluth walked out, leaving behind the beautiful home, the life she'd built, and the woman she loved. Now, every other Friday at 5:30 PM, she stands on the porch for the custody exchange, choking on the hollow echo of the future that shattered. She's just trying to survive the ache of being a visitor in her own past, determined to never let Adora Gray break her heart again.

Adora Gray is drowning in the silence of the house she designed for their family. She's haunted by the ghost of Catra's laughter and the devastating, unanswered question: How did I not see it?

But the most painful silence is their child Finn's—a quiet confusion that echoes louder than any argument.

Is the chasm between them too wide to bridge, or can two broken people find a way to stop hurting each other—and their child—long enough to listen?

(A story about the architecture of a broken home, the erosion of trust, and the terrifying risk of a second chance.)

Notes

Hi friends!

Excited to share this one with you all. Are we ready to watch Catra and Adora have a bad time for a while? I know I am.

<3

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: The Hollow Echo of Friday

The late afternoon sun, thick and golden like spilled honey, gilded the leaves of the maple tree Adora had planted the summer Finn was born.

Catra leaned against the worn door of her sensible, second-hand sedan, parked across the street from the house she hadn't called home for a year.

Their house. Ten years of her life echoed within its walls–laughter, Finn's first steps, movie nights, the rhythm of shared existence.

Now, it was just Adora's house. A monument to what was shattered.

Her tail, thick and expressive with dark fur, lashed once behind her, a sharp counterpoint to her stillness. Her ears, sensitive and mobile atop her head, twitched slightly, hidden mostly by the messy cascade of her dark brown hair.

The key fob for her cramped, sunless apartment dug into her palm as she clenched her fist.

Breathe, she commanded herself. *In. Out. For Finn.*

It was Friday. 5:30 PM. Custody exchange. Her week.

The walk across the street felt like wading through molasses. Every step vibrated with ghosts. Now, she was a visitor. The perfectly tended flower beds Adora always managed to find time for seemed accusatory in their vibrancy.

Look what you left behind.

She pressed the doorbell, the familiar chime sending a jolt through her. A beat of silence stretched, thick and suffocating. Then, footsteps. Heavy, hesitant. The door swung open.

Adora stood there, backlit by the hallway light.

Her blonde hair was pulled back in its usual practical ponytail, but strands had escaped, framing a face etched with a weariness no amount of sleep could fix. She wore clean jeans and a soft-looking grey sweater, Finn’s favorite, Catra noted absently.

Her blue eyes, usually bright with determination or warm affection, were red-rimmed and fixed on a point just past Catra’s shoulder, as if looking directly at her was too painful to bear.

"Hey," Adora said, her voice hoarse, like she hadn’t used it all day. She forced a smile, brittle as glass. It didn’t reach her eyes. "Right on time."

"Mom!" A blur of energy shot past Adora’s legs. Finn, all gangly limbs and boundless energy at eight years old, crashed into Catra’s midsection. Their small arms wrapped tightly around her waist, their face buried in her shirt.

Finn’s dark blonde fur shimmered in the light, their golden hair a messy halo around ears that were perked forward with pure excitement. Their blue eyes sparkled when they looked up, a happy twitch running down the length of their fluffy tail as it wrapped briefly around Catra’s leg.

"Hey, kiddo," Catra murmured, the genuine warmth in her voice surprising even herself as she ruffled Finn’s hair, her fingers briefly brushing the soft fur at the base of one pointed ear. The familiar scent of her child—a unique blend of sunshine, crayons, and clean fur—was as beloved and known to her as her own. For a moment, the suffocating tension lifted. "Missed you."

"I missed you too, Mom!" Finn beamed, their tail giving another enthusiastic flick behind them. "Mama helped me finish my space diorama!"

"That sounds awesome, Finny!" Catra said, her gaze flicking back to Adora, who was hovering just inside the doorway, her posture unnaturally stiff.

The warmth evaporated, replaced by the familiar, icy politeness. "Ready to go? Did you pack your bag?"

Finn nodded vigorously, darting back inside. "Yep! Got my comics and my pajamas with the stars and my sketchbook!" Their voice echoed down the hall.

Silence descended again, heavier than before.

Catra kept her gaze fixed on the empty hallway beyond Adora, focusing on a framed photo of the three of them, laughing, soaked after a picnic.

In it, Adora's hand rested casually on Catra's shoulder; Catra's tail had been playfully hooked around Adora's ankle. Finn, tiny, beamed between them, their small kitten ears barely visible under damp fluff, their tiny tail a blur of motion. Oblivious.

Seven years ago.

Catra's left hand, resting on her hip, felt conspicuously bare. The pale band of thinned fur where her ring had sat for a decade was almost faded now, six months gone.

Adora cleared her throat. "They had a good week. Aced their spelling test. Glimmer took them to the park yesterday."

Her voice was carefully neutral, a report delivered by a stranger. Catra's gaze, against her will, dropped to Adora's left hand.

The simple platinum band still gleamed on her finger. A fresh, sharp pain lanced through her chest, so sudden and acute it stole her breath.

"That's good," Catra replied, equally flat. Her tail betrayed her with a single, sharp flick behind her. She shoved her hands into her jacket pockets. "School pickup Monday is still at 4:15, right? The art club thing?"

"Yes. 4:15." Adora shifted her weight. "I... packed their allergy meds. Just in case."

"Thanks." One word, devoid of warmth. Catra's jaw ached from clenching it against the scream building in her throat. Every word about allergy meds and pickup times was a shard of glass.

This was their life now: a polite, logistical checklist laid over the crater of their marriage.

She could feel Adora's gaze on her, heavy with questions and a desperate, unspoken plea. It took every ounce of willpower not to meet it. Seeing the devastation meant feeling it, and feeling it meant drowning.

Finn bounded back, dragging a slightly-too-large backpack, their tail held high like a banner. "Got it! Bye, Mama!" They launched themselves at Adora, who caught them instinctively, bending down.

Adora's brave facade wobbled. She hugged Finn fiercely, burying her face for a second in their hair. When she pulled back, the forced smile was back, wider this time, but the pain in her eyes was a physical thing.

"Bye, sweetheart. Have an amazing week with Mom. Be good. Draw me lots of pictures, okay?"

Finn chirped, seemingly oblivious to the thick atmosphere, though their ears gave a subtle, uncertain flick as their gaze darted between their parents.

"Love you too, Finn. So much." Adora's voice cracked on the last word. She straightened up quickly, blinking hard. Her gaze finally locked with Catra's over Finn's head. It was a collision.

Catra saw the raw confusion, the lingering disbelief, the ocean of hurt. The naked anguish in Adora's eyes struck a visceral recoil deep within her. For a split second, the icy detachment threatened to melt.

Catra looked away first. Her heart hammered. "C'mon, Finny," she managed, her voice slightly strangled. "Let’s get going. Maybe we can grab pizza?"

She turned, placing a hand on Finn’s shoulder, guiding them towards the car. A retreat.

She didn’t look back. She heard the soft click of the front door closing behind them. The walk back to the car was a blur. Finn chattered about the diorama, about lunch, their voice bright against the heavy silence settling over Catra.

She buckled Finn in. "Seatbelt good?"

"Yep!" Finn beamed, already opening their sketchbook.

Catra slid into the driver’s seat, gripping the steering wheel until her knuckles turned white. She stared straight ahead, not trusting herself to glance back.

The scent of Adora’s lavender detergent clung faintly to Finn’s clothes. Agony.

She took a deep, shuddering breath that did nothing to fill the cavernous emptiness inside her. She pulled away from the curb, away from the house, away from the ghost of the life she’d destroyed by walking out.

The pain inside was a living thing, but she held it in, a tightly coiled spring.

For Finn. Always for Finn.

She drove towards her small apartment, carrying the weight of Adora’s broken heart and her own unspeakable grief, leaving behind a woman collapsing under the weight of a silence she couldn’t comprehend.

Adora watched the taillights of Catra's car disappear around the corner. The forced smile vanished instantly. The cheerful "Love you, Mama!" echoed in the sudden, crushing silence of the foyer.

The faint scents of Catra and Finn, warm as sunshine, lingered for a moment, then dissipated, leaving only lemon polish and dust.

The door clicked shut. She leaned her forehead against the cool wood, eyes squeezed shut. The brave face crumbled. She pushed off the door, legs unsteady.

The living room yawned before her, all clean lines and intentional negative space—a lesson in modernist minimalism that now felt like a beautiful, vacant shell.

She stumbled towards the familiar blue couch and sank onto the cushions in the fading twilight.

The silence pressed in, thick and suffocating. No Finn's chatter, no Catra's sardonic commentary, no quiet *thump* of tails against the couch cushions. Just the hollow tick of the grandfather clock against the wall.

How did this happen? The question screamed inside her skull. *We were happy. Weren't we*?

She'd worked so hard. Long hours clawing her way up at the architectural firm, taking on extra projects. For *them*.

For this house—a home she'd literally designed and drafted for them. For Finn's art classes—the expensive ones at the gallery school they loved so much. For the future she was determined to build, stone by stone.

And Catra had walked out. A year ago. Moved into her own apartment definitively six months ago. Just… left.

Adora's gaze drifted to the framed pictures on the mantelpiece. Finn's first birthday.

Their fifth anniversary. Finn's first day of kindergarten, clinging to both their hands.

Catra's eyes in that picture… had they already held that distance? Adora couldn't see it. She only saw the smile, the familiar tilt of the head.

Her hand lifted. Her thumb brushed against the cool metal band on her left ring finger. Her wedding ring. Simple platinum, worn smooth. Ten years of vows and hope worn into a single circle. She'd never taken it off.

Not even when Catra had slipped hers into a small velvet box—and silently left it on the dresser during a custody exchange. No note. Just absence.

Adora had stared at that box for a long time. Afraid to open it. Afraid not to.

Even now, half a year later, she could still feel the weight of it in her palm.

Had she already begun to lose her then?

No. It wasn't something that happened in a picture. Or a single text. Or even with that velvet box.

It happened in silence.

In the hum of a laptop. The cold glow of a screen.

In the blinking cursor she turned back to when the love of her life was standing in the doorway—trying, one last time.

That was the moment.

The moment Catra stopped waiting.

And the memory crashed in—brutal, inescapable.

One year ago.

The glow of the laptop screen was the only light in the den.

It was late. Finn was asleep. Spreadsheets blurred. Emails pinged.

The Bright Moon Heights project was a logistical death spiral. A last-minute change to the façade to appease the HOA had thrown the entire structural grid off, which now meant recalculating load-bearing points and, god help her, the property line setbacks.

Her shoulders ached. Just a few more replies.

"Adora?"

Adora's finger hovered over the delete key. The elevation lines on the site plan she was reviewing blurred into a gray mess. A voice, Catra's voice, filtered through the fog of fatigue.

"Hmm? Yeah, just a sec..." she mumbled, not lifting her eyes from the miscalculated property line she needed to trace. The client's angry email—*"Why is the setback wrong? This delays permits!"*—glowed accusingly from a second window on the screen.

Silence. Adora typed, deleted, tried again.

"Adora." Sharper. "We need to talk."

Adora glanced up, her eyes struggling to adjust from the screen's blue glow to the dark doorway.

The silhouette there wasn't moving. Arms crossed. And the tip of her tail, usually a faint, curious twitch, was frozen mid-air, utterly, unnaturally still.

"Okay, sure," Adora forced a tired smile. "Just… give me five minutes? Ten, tops." She gestured at the screen. "I'll be right there."

Catra didn’t move. Didn’t speak. Adora, mentally drafting the next email, turned back to the screen.

The email subject line grabbed her—'URGENT: Revisions Required'—and just like that, the tension in the doorway was drowned out by the pounding in her temples.

The CAD file demanded her focus, the flawed structural grid a puzzle she had to solve, and the world narrowed to the glow of the screen. The silent presence in the doorway faded into the background hum of the house.

Minutes bled away. Adora hit send, closed the laptop with a sigh. "Okay," she swiveled. "What did you—"

The words died.

Catra had not moved a muscle. But now, in the faint light from the hallway, Adora saw the silent tears cutting tracks through the tawny fur on her cheeks. Her fists were clenched so tight her claws were digging into her own palms. Her mismatched eyes burned in the shadows.

The coldness in her voice was glacial. "Oh. Do you have a moment for me *now*, Adora?"

Adora’s blood ran cold. Panic seized her. She surged to her feet. "Catra! What’s wrong?"

Catra flinched back. "What’s *wrong*?" she repeated, bitter scorn. "You. *You* are what’s wrong."

"Me? I… I’m sorry, it’s just work… I didn’t mean—"

"Just work," Catra spat. "Always *just work*. The next email, the next deadline. I’m *tired*, Adora. Tired of being an afterthought. Tired of being at the absolute *bottom* of your fucking list!"

Adora stared, pale. "That’s not true! You and Finn are everything! I do this *for* you!"

"DO YOU?" Catra roared, making Adora flinch. "Because it doesn't *feel* like it! I'm living with a ghost! I need to feel *important*! *Wanted*! And I haven't…" Her voice broke. "…for a very long time."

Adora's world tilted. "Catra, no… please. We can fix this. Let's talk. Now. Sit down." She stepped forward.

Catra scoffed, harsh, humorless. "Talk? I've been *trying* to talk! For *months*! You haven't heard! You haven't *seen* me!" She swiped at tears. "I'm done. I can't do this anymore."

"Can't do… what?" Adora whispered, terrified.

Catra took a shuddering breath. "I'm going to stay with Scorpia and Perfuma. Tonight."

The solid ground of her life gave way beneath her feet. She stumbled back a step, her hand flailing for the edge of her desk.

"No. Catra, no. This is your home! Please… don't go. I'll… cut back my hours at work! I Promise!"

"Promises," Catra murmured, disdainful. "Empty words." Her gaze flickered towards Finn's room.

Adora seized it. "What about Finn? You can't just… leave Finn!"

Catra flinched, pain flashing. "They're asleep," she said thickly. "Just… tell them I'm staying with Auntie Scorpia and Auntie Perfuma. For a little bit." She swallowed. "We'll… tell them everything soon."

She turned, heading to the foyer. Sitting by the door, neat and ready, was a packed duffel bag.

The air rushed from Adora's lungs. It wasn't hastily stuffed; it was zipped shut, positioned for a quick exit. Catra hadn't packed this while Adora was finishing her email. She'd packed it *before* she even came into the den. Before she'd issued her final,

unanswered plea to talk. She had already given up. This wasn't the beginning of a conversation; it was the end of one she'd been having alone for who knows how long.

"Catra, wait!" Adora lunged, grabbing her arm. "Please don't go!"

Catra whirled, wrenching free. Her eyes held finality. "I have to go, Adora. I can't breathe here." Flat, exhausted. "I'll text you to coordinate picking up Finn tomorrow."

She picked up the bag, slung it over her shoulder. Opened the door. Stepped out. She didn't look back.

Adora stood frozen. The door closing echoed like a gunshot. She stared at the wood. The world stopped spinning.

The scent of Catra–spices, fur, *home*–hung in the air for one more agonizing second.

Adora inhaled deeply, a futile attempt to keep it there, before it began its inevitable fade into the sterile smell of lemon polish and the cold, empty air of the entryway.

How? How could sixteen years, a family, a life… unravel because I couldn't look up from a screen?

The memory faded, leaving Adora gasping on the couch in the present darkness, tears streaming.

She'd thought it would be temporary. A week or two to cool off. Tearful reunion. She researched therapists the next morning. Vowed to change. Cut back. Make time.

But Catra hadn't cooled off. Texts were logistical. Pickup times. Appointments. Polite. Distant. The week at Scorpia's turned into a month.

Then, after six months of separation: *Found an apartment. My lawyer will contact yours about the separation papers*. A death

knell. The ring came off Catra's finger, left behind.

Adora had tried.

Flowers were returned. Voicemails, unanswered. A desperate visit met with hollow eyes and a whispered, *"Please don't."*

All of it, just throwing herself against a wall of ice. Cold. Unyielding. Silent.

Catra had moved on. Closed the book. Built a life that didn't include Adora Gray, except as Finn's other parent. The polite distance wasn't just pain; it was finality.

Adora stared down at her wedding ring, glinting dully. The symbol of a promise broken through ignorance. She'd built a future, neglecting its fragile heart. Assumed Catra understood the *why*. Assumed her love was evident in security. Catastrophically wrong.

The silence pressed down, heavier than ever. The absence of *Catra*. Her laugh, her wit, her warmth, her purr. Absence of their future–vacations, graduations, growing old watching the maple tree.

A ragged sob escaped Adora, followed by another. She curled in on herself on the too-empty couch. The tears came harder, silent rivers.

She grieved. For the lost marriage. For the woman who walked away, wounded by her blindness. For Finn, caught in the middle. For the sixteen years that felt like someone else's life. For the empty space beside her, the hollow echo where shared life resonated.

The grandfather clock ticked, measuring empty seconds. The house felt like a museum of broken dreams. Adora Gray sat in the deepening dark, the only sound her heartbroken tears and the relentless, unanswered question echoing in her broken heart:

How did I not see?

Outside, the first stars pierced the twilight, indifferent witnesses. Her week alone stretched before her, a week where Finn’s laughter would only underline the profound, aching silence awaiting their return.

The ring on her finger felt impossibly heavy, a cold reminder of a warmth forever lost.

Chapter 2: The Ache in the Silence

Chapter Notes

> I have a call with my attorney today to get ready for my disability hearing (that's in a WEEK). I've been fighting for 3 years to get these benefits, wish me luck, friends <3

Thursday morning sunlight, pale and thin, filtered through the blinds of Catra’s cramped apartment.

It illuminated dust motes dancing in the air and landed on the small, laminated kitchen table, currently occupied by a bowl of brightly colored cereal and a mug of strong, cheap coffee.

The air held the faint, lingering scent of toast and the underlying tang of cleaning products that never quite masked the building’s age.

Catra leaned against the counter, her tail twitching rhythmically against the lower cabinet door. Her dark brown hair was pulled back in a messy ponytail, a few strands escaping to frame her face.

She watched Finn, already dressed in rumpled jeans and a t-shirt featuring a cartoon spaceship, shovel cereal into their mouth with unbridled enthusiasm.

Their dark blonde fur was slightly rumpled from sleep, ears perked forward in alertness as they ate. Their blue eyes were bright, reflecting the morning light and their own inherent cheerfulness.

Under the table, Finn’s tail swished contentedly against the chair leg in time with their chewing.

Finn’s mood was a welcome, if slightly jarring, contrast to the low hum of anxiety and exhaustion that usually accompanied Catra’s mornings.

"Slow down, space ranger," Catra murmured, taking a sip of her coffee, the bitterness grounding her. "You're gonna choke. And remember, water bottle goes *outside* of the backpack, not inside where it leaks all over your homework."

Finn paused, milk dripping from their chin, and grinned, their ears rotating slightly towards Catra's voice. "I know, Mom! Promise!"

They wiped their chin with the back of their hand. "My homework's done too! Math worksheet. Easy peasy."

"Good job," Catra said, a genuine smile touching her lips. Finn's ease this morning was a small mercy. Some mornings were battles—misplaced shoes, forgotten permission slips, grumpy resistance to the very concept of school. Today felt… manageable.

"Did you double-check your lunch bag? I put those apple slices you like."

"Yep! And the cheese sticks!" Finn beamed, pushing the empty bowl away.

Their tail gave a single, satisfied thump against the chair. "Can I have five minutes on my tablet before we go? Just to check on my BlipBase colony?"

Catra glanced at the clock on the microwave. *7:35 AM. School drop-off at 8:15.* The data entry queue loomed large in her mind, a digital monster waiting to be fed.

"Five minutes. Exactly. Timer starts now." She pulled out her phone, setting the alarm. Finn scrambled off the chair, grabbing their tablet from the coffee table in the adjoining living area.

Catra used the moments of relative quiet to finish her coffee and quickly rinse Finn's bowl. Her gaze swept the small kitchen–functional, clean, but undeniably temporary. Sterile.

Nothing like the warm, slightly chaotic kitchen in the house, filled with plants, Finn's artwork plastered on the fridge, the lingering

aroma of Catra’s more ambitious cooking experiments on weekends.

Midweek mornings like this were strictly survival: cereal, toast, coffee. No time for the fluffy pancakes or elaborate omelets she used to enjoy making, the rituals that felt like pouring love directly onto plates.

Now, energy was a finite resource, and most of it was already earmarked for getting through the day.

The timer chirped. "Finn! Time’s up. Shoes on, backpack check."

Finn groaned dramatically, their ears flattening slightly against their head in protest, but powered down the tablet without argument.

They shoved their feet into sneakers, wrestled the backpack onto their shoulders, and stood by the door. "Ready!"

The drive to Finn’s elementary school was short, filled with Finn’s chatter about their BlipBase colony, a funny thing their friend said yesterday, and excitement about an upcoming field trip.

Catra half-listened, navigating the familiar streets on autopilot, her mind already drifting towards the eight-hour data entry slog awaiting her return.

She pulled up to the curb in the designated drop-off zone.

"Have a good day, kiddo," Catra said, reaching over to ruffle Finn’s hair, her fingers gently smoothing the fur behind one ear. "Learn lots of cool stuff. Love you."

"Love you too, Mom!" Finn unbuckled, leaned over to give Catra a quick, somehow sticky hug, their tail curling briefly around her forearm in affection, then scrambled out of the car. "Bye!"

They dashed towards the school entrance, joining the stream of children, a flash of golden hair and dark blonde fur disappearing

into the building.

Catra watched until Finn was safely inside, the familiar pang of separation hitting her, even though it was routine.

Then, the quiet of the car settled, thick and heavy.

She took a deep breath, the scent of Finn's cereal breath and cheap car upholstery filling her lungs, and turned the car back towards the apartment complex that still didn't feel like home.

Back inside the apartment, the silence felt louder. Oppressive.

Catra dumped her keys in the chipped ceramic bowl by the door—a far cry from the polished wood bowl Adora had always preferred.

She kicked off her sneakers and padded into the kitchen. She quickly cleared Finn's cereal bowl and mug from the small dining table, wiping the surface clean.

She retrieved her laptop from its case and set it up on the table, its screen a blank, accusatory gray. She pulled out one of the two utilitarian dining chairs and sank into it, its hard, unsupportive seat offering little comfort.

She logged in, the familiar company portal loading with its endless lists of tasks.

Data Entry Specialist. It sounded vaguely professional. It felt soul-crushingly monotonous. Rows upon rows of numbers, addresses, customer IDs, product codes.

Click, type, verify. Click, type, verify. For eight hours. Five days a week.

She used to work part-time. Twenty hours, tops. Enough to contribute a little, feel useful, but mostly because she *wanted* to, not because she *had* to.

Adora's salary—climbing steadily through the ranks at the architectural firm—had comfortably covered the mortgage, the bills, Finn's needs, and luxuries like vacations and summer camps.

Catra hadn't needed to work full-time. She'd had the freedom to focus more on Finn, on the house, on the life they were building.

Now? Rent for this small apartment, utilities, groceries just for her and Finn half the time, Finn's expenses, her own… Adora paid child support, of course, calculated precisely by lawyers and the state. It helped.

But it wasn't enough to maintain her previous level of financial ease, not without her own significant contribution. So, part-time became full-time. Freedom became necessity.

Catra cracked her knuckles, a habit she'd developed recently, and started. Click. Type. Verify. Click. Type. Verify. The rhythm was mechanical, mind-numbing. The first hour passed slowly. The second dragged. By the third hour, the familiar aches began to set in.

Her eyes started to burn, the relentless glare of the screen making her vision blur slightly at the edges. She blinked rapidly, reaching for the cheap drugstore reading glasses she now needed for prolonged screen time.

A dull throb started behind her right temple, promising to blossom into a full migraine if she wasn't careful.

She massaged the spot with her fingertips, wincing.

Worse was the tension coiling in her body. Her shoulders felt like solid blocks of concrete, knots forming along her neck and trapezius muscles. A deep ache settled into her lower back from sitting in the unsupportive chair.

And her hands… her wrists. A sharp, hot twinge shot through her right wrist as she reached for the mouse. Tendonitis? Carpal

tunnel? The internet offered terrifying possibilities.

She flexed her fingers, trying to ease the stiffness.

A memory surfaced, unbidden and sharp: Adora's hands, warm and strong, kneading the tension from Catra's shoulders after a long day.

Catra melting into the touch, a low purr rumbling in her chest without conscious thought, the scent of Adora's cedar-and-sage shampoo filling her senses as she relaxed.

Adora's voice, soft and concerned: "*You're all knotted up, babe. Let me help.*" The relief had been instant, profound.

No, Catra thought fiercely, shaking her head as if to dislodge the image. *She'd offer. She'd promise. "Let me give you a massage tonight," she'd say*. Catra could almost hear Adora's earnest voice.

And then… something would always come up. An urgent email that couldn't wait. A project deadline looming. A client call running late. Finn needing help with a last-minute assignment from school. The promise would evaporate, replaced by an apologetic, exhausted sigh and a distracted kiss on the forehead.

"Tomorrow, I promise."

The broken promises. Catra gritted her teeth, trying to force her attention back to the spreadsheet. *They were worse than if Adora hadn't offered at all.* Because the offer ignited *hope*.

The *promise* felt like care, like priority. And the *breaking* of it… that felt like confirmation of her deepest fear: that she *wasn't* important. That her needs were inconvenient, easily shuffled aside.

Catra had never wanted to be unreasonable. She understood ambition. She understood providing.

She'd grown up with *nothing*; the security Adora provided was something she'd never take for granted. She hadn't demanded grand gestures or constant attention.

She'd just wanted… presence. Reliability. To feel like she wasn't perpetually at the bottom of Adora's overflowing to-do list.

But Adora had been the one to make the grand promises. The ones that hooked Catra deep, right from the start. When she was twenty-four, Adora, with her relentless optimism and fierce loyalty, had been a revelation.

Catra had been closed off, defensive. Years bouncing between foster homes, learning early that trust got you hurt and needs were weaknesses to be hidden, had built walls thicker than concrete.

But Adora hadn't been deterred.

She'd shown up. Consistently. Reliably. If she said she'd call, she called. If she promised to fix Catra's perpetually leaky faucet in her shitty studio apartment, she showed up Saturday morning with a toolbox and determination.

If she said she'd be there for Catra when the nightmares came, she *was* there, holding her through the shaking, murmuring soft reassurances.

Adora promised things Catra hadn't even known she craved: love that wasn't conditional, tenderness that wasn't a prelude to pain, care that wasn't transactional.

Things she didn't have the vocabulary for, needs buried so deep she hadn't recognized their shape until Adora started filling them.

No one in Catra's life had ever been so *dependable*. So determined to prove she was worthy of Catra's trust.

That's what made Catra fall. Hard. That unwavering presence. That sense of being *chosen*, prioritized, seen. She'd never been

treated so well, so consistently.

She'd craved that feeling of safety, of being *worth* that level of care.

She'd wanted to spend her life building something safe and warm with this person who made her feel, against all her instincts, like she mattered.

They were in their forties now. Sixteen years since they met. Ten years married. And somewhere along the line, the gears had shifted.

Promotion by promotion, Adora climbed. Project by project, the demands increased. The architect who designed dreams for others started sacrificing the foundation of her own.

When Finn came into their lives eight years ago, a tiny, mewling bundle of need and wonder, Adora had redoubled her efforts. She tried to be *super-mom* and *super-architect*.

Catra saw the strain, the exhaustion etched deeper each year. Adora *was* present for Finn—soccer games, school plays, bedtime stories. She genuinely loved their child.

But the energy required for that, combined with the escalating demands of her career… it left little for anything, or anyone, else.

Catra wasn't jealous of Finn. Never. She would have been furious if Adora had neglected Finn to focus on her. Finn deserved that love, that attention.

But Catra needed love and attention too. She needed her *wife*. She needed to feel like she wasn't just the co-parent, the household manager, the person Adora collapsed next to at night, already half-asleep.

And Adora, bless her relentless heart, kept *saying* she understood. Kept making promises. Grand gestures planned then cancelled.

Weekends away postponed indefinitely. Date nights sacrificed for last-minute deadlines.

"Just this one project," she'd say, her eyes pleading for understanding. "Then things will calm down. We'll have more time. I promise."

Catra had believed her. At first. Then belief became hope. Then hope became a brittle, fragile thing. Then it shattered.

The more Adora's attention drifted, the more Catra felt herself changing. The softness Adora had coaxed out of her began to recede.

She felt herself becoming sharp-edged again, brittle. The warmth in her chest cooled, replaced by a simmering resentment she hated.

She snapped more easily. Sarcasm, once playful, became a shield laced with bitterness. Joy felt harder to grasp, fleeting.

She watched herself turn back into someone she didn't want to be —someone hard, joyless, perpetually braced for disappointment.

She missed the softer version of herself, the one who bloomed under Adora's consistent care. The more love she'd received, the more she'd had to give—to Adora, to Finn, to their friends.

Now, she just felt… empty. Drained.

Adora's neglect hadn't just been inconvenient; it struck at the deepest wound Catra carried. The wound of being unimportant. Unwanted. Unworthy of consistent care.

Adora had promised to heal that wound, and for a glorious while, she had.

To feel it being ripped open again, by the very person who swore to protect her… the pain was corrosive.

When Catra finally walked out a year ago, the promises started again. Desperate, tearful vows whispered through Scorpia's door, poured into unanswered texts and emails. Promises of therapy, of cutting back work, of *fixing* it.

But by then, Catra was hollowed out. The well of trust was dry. She'd heard the promises too many times, only to watch them crumble like ash.

She couldn't make herself believe another one. The risk of hoping, only to be disappointed *again*, felt like annihilation.

She didn't *want* a divorce.

The thought of it, of making that final severance, made her feel physically ill. She still loved Adora. Somewhere beneath the layers of hurt and resentment and exhaustion, that love remained, a stubborn, aching ember.

She loved the life they'd built, even the ghost of it that haunted her in this sterile apartment.

She loved their family, fractured as it was.

But love wasn't enough. Not without trust. Not without the fundamental belief that she mattered. That her needs wouldn't perpetually be sacrificed on the altar of Adora's ambition, no matter how nobly framed.

She couldn't go back to living on scraps of attention and broken vows. She couldn't subject herself, or Finn, to the slow erosion of her spirit.

She couldn't trust Adora not to break her heart all over again.

A particularly vicious throb behind her eye made Catra hiss, pressing the heel of her hand against her temple. The spreadsheet blurred. The numbers swam.

The ache in her wrist pulsed in time with her headache.

The silence of the apartment pressed in, heavy with absence and the relentless clicking of her mouse.

Suddenly, a shrill, insistent sound shattered the quiet. Her phone alarm, blaring from beside the laptop. Catra jumped, her heart hammering against her ribs.

She fumbled for the phone, silencing the noise. The screen read: 2:45 PM.

Time to pick up Finn from school.

Relief flooded her, sharp and immediate. An escape from the screen, the silence, the physical pain, the relentless loop of painful thoughts. She pushed back from the dining table, the chair groaning in protest.

Her body protested too as she stood—stiff back, aching shoulders, pounding head, throbbing wrist. She grabbed her keys, the mundane act a welcome anchor.

As she locked the apartment door behind her, heading back out into the afternoon light, the echo of Finn's cheerful morning chatter replaced the digital hum in her mind. She clung to it.

Finn was the tangible reality, the uncomplicated love, the reason to keep moving through the ache—both physical and emotional.

Finn was the present.

Adora, the promises, the broken dreams… they were the ghosts haunting the past she had chosen to leave behind.

The drive to school was a journey towards light, noise, and the simple, anchoring love of her child.

It was the only thing, right now, that didn't feel like it might break.

Chapter 3: The Weight of What Was Lost

Chapter Notes

> my final disability hearing is TOMORROW. please wish me luck, friends. And enjoy Adora's misery.

The shrill beep of the alarm sliced through the pre-dawn silence at 6:00 AM sharp.

Adora Gray’s eyes snapped open, instantly awake, instantly aware of the crushing emptiness beside her in the king-sized bed.

More than a decade of waking up to the warmth of Catra curled against her, the soft rhythm of her breathing, the faint, comforting scent of her fur… replaced by cold sheets and silence.

She swallowed hard, the familiar ache settling in her chest before her feet even hit the floor.

Move. Just move.

The mantra propelled her out of bed. The master bedroom felt cavernous now, haunted by the ghost of shared intimacy.

She dressed quickly in workout gear—shorts, tank top, high-performance sneakers—her movements efficient, almost robotic.

Downstairs, the house was still and dark. Finn’s room, down the hall, was empty and tidy, a painful reminder that it was Catra’s week. The quiet was oppressive.

Her home gym was her sanctuary now. Racks of weights, a treadmill, a heavy bag, resistance bands.

Adora flicked on the lights, the glare harsh against the pre-dawn gloom filtering through the high windows. The familiar scent of rubber mats and sweat grounded her.

She cranked up a high-energy playlist on the speakers, the driving beat an assault on the silence. *Loud enough to drown out the thoughts*.

Her workout was punishing. She pushed herself harder than necessary, muscles burning, lungs gasping. There was a ferocity to it, a physical venting of the emotional pressure cooker inside of her.

She'd played Division I lacrosse in college, a powerhouse midfielder known for her relentless drive and physicality. While the tailored suits and precise blueprints of her architectural career had smoothed some of the rough edges, the athlete was still there—in the powerful swing connecting her fist with the heavy bag, in the gritted teeth as she pushed through the last rep on the bench press, in the sweat plastering her blonde ponytail to her neck.

It was a part of her identity she'd clung to, a source of discipline and strength.

Now, it was a way to exhaust herself into numbness.

An hour later, dripping sweat and trembling slightly from exertion, she stood in the kitchen, blending a chalky protein shake.

The silence of the house pressed in again as the blender's whirring died down.

She leaned against the counter, gulping the shake, her gaze drifting over the kitchen. It was meticulously clean, unnervingly so. Before… there would have been evidence of life.

Finn's cereal bowl abandoned on the table, maybe Catra's favorite chipped mug ("World's Okayest Mom") left by the sink. The detritus of a shared morning.

Now, it was sterile. A museum exhibit titled "Family Life: After the Collapse."

She rinsed the blender cup quickly, the sound unnaturally loud. *Before Catra left*… The thought echoed as she showered and dressed in her professional armor—a crisp white shirt, tailored navy trousers, blazer.

She'd have stayed later at the office, back then. Known Catra was home, holding down the fort, managing Finn's evening routine, dinner, homework.

She'd tell herself she was doing it *for* them, building security, climbing the ladder to provide a better life.

The justification felt hollow now, scraped raw by hindsight.

She glanced at the clock. 7:45 AM. Plenty of time to get to the office by 8:00. On the weeks she had Finn, she was out the door by 7:30 AM sharp, determined to be home by 6:00 PM at the absolute latest.

Every minute spent working late when Finn was waiting felt like a theft, a betrayal of the precious, limited time she had with her child. She couldn't stand it.

And that understanding, that visceral need to *be* present for Finn… it was a brutal mirror held up to her past self.

It was like as long as Catra was there to hold everything up at home, I never had to change.

The realization hit her anew, a fresh wave of shame washing over her.

She'd taken Catra's steadfastness for granted. Assumed her love was an infinite, self-replenishing resource that didn't require active tending. She'd provided materially, yes, but she'd starved Catra emotionally.

Why hadn't Catra's *happiness* factored more heavily into her calculations? Why had security and achievement trumped the simple, vital need of her wife to feel cherished, prioritized, *seen*?

The drive to the architectural firm, Lumina Designs, was quiet. No Finn, chattering away from the backseat. Just the hum of the engine and the relentless churn of her own thoughts.

She'd had enough lonely nights in the past year—nights spent staring at the ceiling, nights pacing the too-quiet house, nights collapsing on the couch like she had after the last custody exchange—to finally start understanding the depth of her failure.

The loneliness she felt now was a fraction of what she'd inflicted on Catra for years. It was a harsh teacher.

I never consciously decided to de-prioritize her, she thought, pulling into her parking spot. *It just… happened. Project by project, promotion by promotion. Somewhere along the line… I stopped feeling like I had to prove anything to her.*

The admission, even just in her own mind, felt like swallowing glass.

I just never thought she'd leave me.

That was the core of it, the devastating arrogance beneath it all. She'd believed, with the unshakeable certainty of someone who'd never truly faced the consequence of their neglect, that their bond was unbreakable.

That Catra's love was a fixed point, a north star immune to the erosion of time and inattention. That no matter how many promises she broke, how many date nights she cancelled, how emotionally absent she became, Catra would always be there.

That belief, she saw now with agonizing clarity, had led her to treat Catra's feelings with a casualness bordering on contempt. She hadn't *meant* to be contemptuous, but the effect was the same.

If she'd truly understood there was a breaking point, a line Catra would eventually cross… wouldn't she have taken action? Wouldn't she have fought harder, sooner?

The answer, whispered from the depths of her shame, was a resounding *yes*. And that knowledge was the most painful of all. She hadn't acted because she hadn't believed it was necessary.

She'd gambled with Catra's heart and lost everything.

She rode the elevator up to the sleek, modern offices of Lumina, the polished chrome and glass reflecting a woman who looked composed, professional, in control.

Inside, she felt like shattered glass held together with scotch tape.

Her office was spacious, filled with light, blueprints pinned to large boards, models of current projects, shelves laden with architectural tomes. It spoke of success, expertise, respect.

She sat behind her desk, booting up her powerful workstation. This week, without Finn, the emptiness of the house was too much. She'd be here late. Every night. Filling the void with work, the very thing that had created the void in the first place.

But on Finn's weeks… she was trying. Really trying.

She'd gone to her boss, Hope Sterling—a sharp, experienced woman in her fifties who ran Lumina with a firm but fair hand—and explained the situation. Not in gory detail, but enough.

Separation. Shared custody. Needing to prioritize her child during her parenting time.

Hope had been… understanding. Surprisingly, almost uncomfortably so.

"Family comes first, Adora," she'd said, her gaze direct and kind. "We'll make it work. Flexible hours, remote days when needed. Just communicate your schedule."

It hadn't been hard. Hope hadn't balked, hadn't questioned Adora's commitment. She'd simply adjusted.

Which makes me feel even worse. Adora stared at her screen saver—a picture of Finn, grinning, holding up a messy painting.

*I'd been so afraid to hold boundaries at work. Terrified of losing the approval of the higher-ups, seeming less than 100% committed. I placed that fear—that stupid, selfish fear of professional disapproval—above my desire… No, my **duty**, to give Catra more love and attention.*

Above my responsibility to nurture my marriage.

She'd sacrificed her wife on the altar of her own ambition and insecurity. And it took Catra actually *leaving*, the nuclear option, for Adora to find the courage to ask Hope for what she could have asked for years ago.

For Finn. Not for Catra.

The self-loathing was a physical weight. Adora had always seen herself as a fundamentally good person. Virtuous. Hardworking. Kind. A person who rose to challenges, didn't make excuses, who *did the right thing*.

That self-image lay in ruins.

Who was she, really? She was the person who had smothered the love of the most precious woman in her world with a relentless stream of broken promises and neglected needs.

The person who made endless excuses to avoid the difficult but necessary act of changing her priorities.

The person who expected her wife to just… *understand*. To absorb the disappointment of a cancelled anniversary dinner, to swallow the hurt of a forgotten promise for an act of service, quality time.

To accept the constant deferral of intimacy and connection because "work is crazy right now, babe, but *next* week…"

She remembered offering to give Catra massages.

The earnest desire in the moment was real. She *loved* bringing Catra comfort. Loved the way Catra's tense muscles would gradually yield under her hands, the way her breathing would deepen, the way her whole body would eventually relax into the touch.

Seeing that fierce, guarded woman melt, trusting Adora enough to let go completely… it had been one of the most profoundly gratifying things in Adora's life.

And the purr… a low, rumbling vibration that started deep in Catra's chest when she was truly content, truly safe. Adora had treasured that sound, a physical manifestation of the peace and safety she could provide.

Catra's body held so much tension, a legacy of her brutal childhood. She was incredibly strong—resilient, fierce, physically capable—but there was a delicacy to her frame, especially in Adora's larger, more solid hands.

It had always evoked a powerful protective instinct in Adora. She'd wanted to shield Catra, to carry her burdens, to keep her safe from any harm.

That instinct felt like a cruel joke now. *She* had been the harm. Her neglect had been the injury.

Her mind drifted back to Catra at twenty-four.

A feral, beautiful creature, all sharp edges and defensive sarcasm. Guarded. Deeply distrustful. Bruised by a system that had failed her repeatedly.

Adora remembered the fierce, almost overwhelming *need* she'd felt to break through those walls. To prove to Catra that she was worthy of real love. Unconditional, patient, consistent love.

To show her that the world held good people, that it was safe to relax, safe to be soft.

It had felt like a mission, a sacred trust.

And seeing Catra blossom… it had been Adora's greatest joy. Witnessing the guardedness slowly give way to genuine smiles, the sarcasm soften into playful teasing, the cynicism replaced by a cautious but growing belief in goodness.

Seeing her become softer, more open, more loving—not just with Adora, but with their friends, and later, with Finn. Happy. Secure. Sincere. Adora had felt like she'd helped heal something broken. She'd been proud.

Her career, her ambition… it was all supposed to *contribute* to that happiness. To give Catra stability, security, nice things, experiences. She'd wanted to give Catra *everything*.

Instead, she'd deprived Catra of the most fundamental things: her love, her presence, the feeling of being a priority, the certainty that her feelings mattered. She'd traded intangible, irreplaceable treasures for tangible, ultimately hollow, success.

A flicker of anger sparked, brief and unwelcome, her jaw tightening. *Why didn't she tell me? **Really** tell me*?

Adora wished, sometimes desperately, that Catra could have found a way to communicate the sheer magnitude of her hurt, the depth of her despair, *before* it reached the point of no return.

Before she was packing a bag while Adora obliviously typed emails.

If Catra had screamed, thrown things, given some undeniable ultimatum… *maybe* Adora would have woken up sooner.

But the anger died as quickly as it flared, drowned in a wave of self-recrimination.

That's convenient. Blaming her for not communicating well enough so I don't have to face the full weight of my own failings.

She knew Catra *had* tried.

Coming from a childhood devoid of healthy emotional modeling, where vulnerability was punished and needs were ignored, Catra had made monumental strides. She'd learned to voice her needs, to express frustration, even anger.

But communicating the slow erosion of her spirit, the existential dread of feeling perpetually unimportant… that was a different language. One she wasn't fluent in. And Adora hadn't been listening for the subtler dialects of despair. And honestly, what would she have even said? Each individual slight—a forgotten massage, a cancelled dinner—felt too small, too pathetic to warrant a 'fix this or I'm gone' ultimatum. It was the death by a thousand paper cuts, and no single paper cut is worth ending a marriage over, until you've bled out.

When Catra became sarcastic or cold, when she'd push Adora away after a broken promise, Adora hadn't heard the raw hurt screaming underneath.

She'd heard criticism. Attack. Ingratitude. She'd felt defensive. "*Can't she see how hard I'm working? For US?*"

She'd felt misunderstood herself, and she'd reacted—argued, justified, explained—instead of pausing to listen, to truly empathize.

Sometimes, secretly, she'd even felt Catra was being… dramatic. Unreasonable. That *she*, Adora, was the one being patient, the bigger person, tolerating Catra's "moods."

Which was great for me, Adora thought, the shame scalding. *Because then the problem wasn't my neglect, it was Catra's reaction to it.* Catra became the problem to be managed, fixed, placated.

It absolved Adora of responsibility. If Catra was just being "difficult," then Adora didn’t have to confront the uncomfortable truth that she was failing as a partner.

She didn’t have to change. She just had to wait for Catra to "get over it."

The depth of that self-deception, that cowardice, made her physically nauseous. She’d pathologized Catra’s perfectly valid pain.

She’d dismissed her feelings as unreasonable because acknowledging them as reasonable would have forced her to confront her own unacceptable behavior.

She’d failed Catra on every possible level—as a lover, as a partner, and, in those moments of dismissal, as a friend.

A soft chime and a pop-up notification on her laptop screen shattered the spiral of self-flagellation.

REMINDER: Bright Moon Plaza Structural Review Docs - Deadline EOD.

Work. Concrete, demanding, blessedly mind-occupying work.

Adora took a deep, shuddering breath, pressing her fingertips against her closed eyelids for a moment. The familiar pressure behind them threatened a headache, but it was a different ache from the one in her heart.

This one had a solution: focus, analysis, action.

She shook her head sharply, a physical gesture to clear the emotional fog.

The image of Catra’s tear-streaked face the night she left, the agonizing politeness at the custody exchange, the empty side of the bed… they receded, forced back into the mental compartment

she reserved for things too painful to examine during working hours.

Compartmentalization—another skill honed to a sharp edge over the past year.

She double-clicked the project folder, blueprints and engineering reports filling the large monitor. Her architect's mind, trained to see structure, stability, and potential failure points, engaged.

The lines on the screen demanded precision, calculation, solutions. There were load-bearing walls to verify, stress points to analyze, materials to specify. Problems with clear parameters and defined resolutions.

Unlike the catastrophic structural failure of her marriage, this was a problem she knew how to fix.

Or at least, one she could lose herself in trying to fix.

Her fingers flew over the keyboard, pulling up calculations, cross-referencing codes. The analytical part of her brain, the part that had built a successful career, gratefully took the reins, pushing the raw, grieving, guilt-ridden part into temporary silence.

For the next several hours, the woman named Adora Gray would cease to exist. In her place would be The Architect: focused, capable, ruthlessly logical.

A persona that could solve anything, except the one problem that mattered.

The deeper, more devastating problems—the weight of lost love, the shards of her shattered self-image, the crushing regret—would wait.

They always did. Waiting in the silence, ready to ambush her the moment the work stopped and she walked back into the echoing emptiness of the house that was no longer a home.

But for now, the deadline was a lifeline, and she clung to it with the desperation of a woman drowning.

Chapter 4: The Apartment

Friday evening bled into twilight as Adora pulled her car up to the curb in front of the building.

It wasn't a bad building, exactly. Just… ordinary. Beige stucco facade, cheap aluminum-framed windows, neatly trimmed but uninspired hedges, a row of identical mailboxes by the entrance. Perfectly acceptable. Perfectly *wrong*. Every fiber of Adora's being screamed it.

This wasn't where Catra belonged.

Catra belonged in *their* house, with the maple tree Adora planted, the kitchen where she'd danced while making pancakes, the living room couch where she'd curled up purring during movie nights.

This sterile, anonymous box felt like an insult to the life they'd built.

Adora killed the engine, the sudden silence amplifying the thudding of her own heart against her ribs.

She hated this ritual. Hated the unfamiliarity, the sense of trespassing into a life Catra had deliberately carved out without her. The sheer, gut-wrenching wrongness of it was a fresh wound every time.

This was Catra's world now, a world she had built on her own terms, and Adora was just a visitor following a schedule.

She took a deep breath, the air thick with the scent of car upholstery and her own anxiety, and forced herself out of the car.

The walk to the specific door felt longer than it was.

She raised her hand, knuckles hovering for a second before she knocked—a firm, deliberate rap that echoed slightly in the quiet

entryway. A few moments of silence stretched, taut and uncomfortable. Then, the sound of a lock turning.

The door opened, revealing Catra.

She looked… tired. Deeply tired. Her tawny fur seemed slightly dull, her dark brown hair pulled back in a messy knot that did little to hide the faint smudges beneath her mismatched eyes.

Adora’s gaze immediately caught the way Catra was subtly rubbing her right hand, massaging the base of her thumb, and the slight stiffness in her shoulders as she leaned against the doorframe.

The familiar ache to offer comfort surged through Adora.

You look exhausted. Let me rub your shoulders.

The words were a ghost on her tongue. Old instincts, deeply ingrained. She crushed them ruthlessly. They weren't appropriate. They weren't welcome. They were a path paved with good intentions leading straight to more hurt.

“Hey,” Catra said, her voice neutral, her expression guarded. She stepped back, opening the door wider. “Come in. Finn’s just finishing packing their backpack. Should be ready in a sec.”

“Thanks,” Adora managed, stepping over the threshold into Catra’s apartment.

It was neat, sparsely furnished—a functional couch, a small TV, a dining table doubling as a workspace with a laptop closed on it. The walls were bare except for a few of Finn’s colorful drawings pinned up near the small kitchenette.

It smelled faintly of lemon cleaner and the underlying scent of Catra—warm spices and something uniquely feline, but muted, overlaying a sense of impermanence.

It wasn't *home*. It was a waystation.

Adora felt like an intruder.

"Have a seat," Catra gestured vaguely towards the couch before moving to lean against the kitchen counter, putting physical space between them. Adora perched awkwardly on the edge of the couch, feeling too large, too present in the compact space.

The silence descended, thick and tense, broken only by the muffled sounds of Finn rummaging through drawers in their bedroom down the short hallway.

Adora's gaze flickered around the room, landing on the closed laptop. Data entry. Eight hours a day. Catra rubbing her hand… The image fueled the suppressed urge to help.

She clenched her fists on her knees. *Don't*.

Finally, needing to shatter the silence, Adora cleared her throat. "So… how was Finn's week?" It was the safest harbor she could find.

Catra visibly relaxed a fraction, the tension in her shoulders easing minutely. Relief flickered in her eyes at the neutral topic.

"Good," she started, her voice gaining a little more animation. "Really good, actually. They aced that spelling test they were worried about. Had a blast at art club yesterday—came home covered in glitter, talking a mile a minute about clay sculptures."

She smiled faintly, a genuine warmth touching her expression when talking about their child.

"Oh, and next week, on Tuesday, they have that field trip to the planetarium. You'll need to pack a lunch for them that day, no cafeteria. The permission slip is already signed, it's in the front pocket of their backpack."

She paused, ticking off the essentials efficiently. "They finished their reading log early too. Seems like they're in a pretty good groove right now."

"That's great," Adora said, nodding, clinging to the mundane details like a lifeline. "Planetarium, got it. Lunch packed. Thanks for letting me know."

The conversation lulled again, the safe topic exhausted.

The silence crept back in, heavier than before. Adora fidgeted.

She glanced at Catra, saw the fatigue etched around her eyes, the way she subtly shifted her weight, still favoring her hand.

The question bubbled up, tentative, dangerous.

"And… how are *you* doing, Catra?"

Catra's gaze snapped to hers, sharp and assessing. Her eyes narrowed slightly, searching Adora's face, as if trying to discern the motivation behind the question. Was it polite co-parenting? Prying? Genuine concern laced with guilt?

After a long, scrutinizing moment, Catra sighed. It was a sound of weary resignation.

"I've… had better weeks," she admitted quietly, her gaze dropping to the floor for a second before meeting Adora's again. "It was nice having Finn around."

She paused again, a visible internal debate playing out on her expressive face. *How much to share? How much to let this woman, this stranger who used to know her soul, see?*

Her jaw tightened, then loosened.

"This job…" she gestured vaguely towards the laptop, "…it's taking a lot out of me. Physically." She flexed her right hand unconsciously. "Mentally. It's… frustrating. Feeling like I don't have enough left in the tank for Finn by the end of the day. Like I'm running on fumes just when they need me most."

Adora was stunned.

Catra hadn’t shared *anything* personal with her in a year. This small admission cracked the facade of polite distance, revealing the exhaustion and strain beneath.

Adora’s immediate, visceral response was a tidal wave:

Quit. Move back home. I’ll take care of everything.

She bit the inside of her cheek, hard. A desperate fantasy. She scrambled for an appropriate response.

“I… I hear that,” she said carefully, her voice softer than she intended. “I hear how frustrating it must feel, wanting to give Finn everything and feeling like work is taking too much… leaving you drained when you want to be present for them.”

As soon as the words left her mouth, the air shifted. They both froze. *‘Work is taking too much… leaving you drained…’*

It echoed a decade of Catra's own frustrations, aimed at *her*.

Adora held her breath, terrified she’d shattered the fragile moment.

Catra’s eyes widened, a flicker of surprise and old hurt flashing in their depths.

She looked away, her jaw working. A beat of charged silence. Then, a stiff, almost imperceptible nod.

“…Thanks,” she muttered to the floor.

Another pause stretched, taut and uncomfortable. Adora braced herself for the door to close, figuratively or literally. But then Catra surprised her again.

She looked back up, her expression still guarded but less hostile. “How was *your* week, Adora?”

The question caught Adora by surprise.

My week?

The truth was a vast, dark ocean: the empty house, the relentless self-loathing, the sleepless nights replaying every failure. The raw, gaping wound where her marriage used to be. All of it roiled inside her, a maelstrom of pain she kept tightly contained.

To voice it felt impossible. Yet, lying felt like another betrayal.

"It's…" Adora's voice cracked. She looked down at her hands. "… it's been… rough." The understatement of the century, delivered in a hoarse whisper.

She instantly regretted it. She looked up just in time to see a flash of genuine concern—and worse, *guilt*—flicker across Catra's face before she could mask it.

It was like a knife twisting in Adora's gut. The last thing she wanted was Catra feeling responsible for *her* pain.

Not after everything.

Catra opened her mouth, perhaps to ask for clarification, perhaps to offer some awkward, distant condolence. But before she could speak, the tension was shattered by a small, energetic hurricane.

"Mama!" Finn burst out of their bedroom, dropping their backpack by the door, and launched themselves across the small living room, their fluffy tail streaming behind them.

They collided with Adora on the couch, wrapping their small arms tightly around Adora's neck. "You're here! I packed my space pajamas! And my comic! And my…"

They trailed off, pulling back slightly, their bright blue eyes scanning Adora's face, ears swiveling forward with sudden concern. "Mama? You okay?"

Adora forced a wide smile, blinking back the sudden moisture in her eyes.

She hugged Finn fiercely, burying her face for a second in their soft, dark blonde hair.

"I'm great now, buddy!" she said, her voice thick but determinedly cheerful. "Just so happy to see you! Space pajamas? Awesome! Ready to blast off?"

Finn beamed, reassured. "Yeah! I just gotta say bye to Mom!" They scrambled off Adora's lap and ran to Catra, flinging their arms around her waist.

"Bye, Mom! Love you! See you next week!"

Catra hugged Finn back, bending down to kiss the top of their head. "Love you too, space ranger. So much. Have an amazing week with Mama. Draw me lots of pictures, okay?"

"I will!" Finn promised, pulling back. They grabbed their backpack from where they'd dropped it. "Okay, I'm ready!"

Adora stood up, smoothing her pants. The moment of intense, shared awareness between her and Catra was gone, replaced by the focus on Finn.

But as Adora reached for Finn's hand, her eyes met Catra's over Finn's head.

It was brief, a mere fraction of a second, but it held a universe of unspoken acknowledgment.

The memory of a thousand shared looks over a sleeping Finn's crib flashed between them—looks of awe, of exhaustion, of shared love—now twisted into this.

Catra's fatigue, her rare admission. Adora's raw honesty. The devastating echo of their past failures in the present struggles.

The shared love for the child between them.

It wasn't reconciliation. It wasn't forgiveness. But it was a crack in the ice, a fleeting moment of seeing each other, truly seeing, through the fog of pain and separation.

"Alright, Finn, let's…" Adora began, turning towards the door.

But Finn didn't move.

Their small hand tightened in Adora's. They looked from Adora to Catra, then back again, their lower lip starting to tremble. Their ears flattened against their head, tail drooped low, almost brushing the floor.

"Do… we *really* have to go?" Finn's voice was small, wobbling. "Why can't we stay with Mom? I… I like it better when we're all together."

Tears welled in their big blue eyes, spilling over and tracing paths down their furry cheeks. "I want to stay with both of you."

The words hung in the air, a brutal, innocent indictment. Adora felt her heart shatter all over again. Catra looked utterly gutted, the color draining from her face, her own eyes glistening.

Both women moved instinctively, crouching down simultaneously to envelop Finn in a tight, desperate group hug.

"Oh, Finn, sweetheart…" Catra murmured, her voice thick with tears she was fighting back. She stroked Finn's hair, fingers tracing the familiar contours of their ears.

"You know Mama and I don't live together anymore." She pulled back slightly, cupping Finn's tear-streaked face in her hands, forcing herself to meet their gaze.

"Finn… I don't think your mama and I are *ever* going to live together again."

She swallowed hard, the words clearly costing her. "The way we feel about each other… it changed. We can't be like we used to

be."

She emphasized the next words fiercely, needing Finn to understand this immutable truth.

"But we are *never* going to stop loving you. Never, ever, Finny. You know that, right? You are the most important thing in the whole world to both of us."

Adora flinched internally at Catra's framing—"the way *we* feel," "*we* can't be." It felt like a mutual decision, a shared failing, when Adora knew, with every fiber of her being, that the failure was overwhelmingly hers, and the choice has been entirely Catra's.

The urge to protest, to cry out *'I still love her! I want her back*!' was almost overwhelming.

But she squashed it. Now was not the time. Fighting Catra in front of their devastated child would be unforgivable.

Finn's pain was the priority.

Finn just sobbed harder, a heart-wrenching sound that tore at Adora's soul.

"But *why*?" they wailed, clinging to both of them with surprising strength, small claws pricking through their clothes.

"It's been *so long*! Why *can't* you coming back to live with Mama? I miss you! I miss having you both! I'm always with Mom *or* with Mama, and I'm *lonely*! I miss movie nights! I miss pancakes together! I miss… being a family!"

The raw, unfiltered pain in their voice was devastating.

Adora felt tears streaming freely down her own face now. She tightened her arm around Finn, rubbing their back, feeling the tremors running through their small frame.

“Oh, Finn… buddy…” She looked across Finn’s head at Catra, whose expression was a mask of anguish.

Adora took a shaky breath, an idea forming, desperate and born purely of the need to soothe her child.

“I hear you, Finny. I hear how much you miss spending time together. All three of us.”

She locked eyes with Catra, her own gaze pleading, cautious. “Would… would you feel a little better if maybe… the three of us could have a movie night? Or do something together? Like… once a week? Just for you?”

Finn’s sobs hitched. They pulled back slightly, looking up at Adora with wide, tear-filled, hopeful eyes, ears twitching forward.

“…Can we?” they whispered, voice trembling. “Is…that allowed?”

Both adults looked at each other. Adora held her breath. She saw the immediate resistance flare in Catra’s eyes—the instinctive recoil from spending *more* time with Adora, the fear of blurred lines, the pain of pretending.

But then Adora saw the resistance war with the profound distress etched on Finn’s face, the raw need in their tearful question.

Catra’s gaze dropped to Finn, taking in their trembling lip, their desperate hope. Her shoulders slumped almost imperceptibly, a silent surrender.

The fight drained out of her, replaced by a weary, heartbreaking resignation.

Love for Finn won out. Over pride, over self-protection, over the chasm between her and Adora.

Catra reached out, smoothing Finn’s hair back from their forehead, her thumb brushing the base of one ear. Her voice was soft, thick with unshed tears, but firm.

“Hey buddy… it’s okay. We can try that. We can try having a family night.”

She managed a small, shaky smile for Finn. “Your mama and I love you so much. Thank you for telling us you were hurting. That was really brave.”

She looked up, meeting Adora’s eyes again, her expression unreadable but no longer hostile. Just… exhausted.

“Tomorrow night? At… your place?” The concession was clear.

Finn nodded vigorously, sniffling, a fragile hope replacing some of the despair, their tail uncurling and lifting slightly off the floor. “Tomorrow? At Mama’s house?”

“Tomorrow,” Adora confirmed, her voice thick. “We’ll figure it out. Pick a movie, okay?”

It took another ten minutes of soothing words, reassurances, and practicalities (Finn wanting to bring their favorite blanket, confirming the time) before Finn was finally calmed down enough to leave, though their small hand still clutched Adora’s tightly, their eyes still red-rimmed, their fur damp where tears had fallen.

The drive back to the house was quiet.

Finn leaned their head against the window, emotionally spent, staring out at the passing streetlights, their tail lying limp beside them.

Adora glanced in the rearview mirror, her heart aching for the small, subdued figure.

“Mama?” Finn’s voice was small in the quiet car.

“Yeah, buddy?”

“Is Mom really coming over tomorrow?”

"Yeah, buddy," Adora said, forcing warmth into her tone. "She's gonna come over so we can all spend some time together. Just the three of us."

A long pause. Then, quietly, almost a whisper: "I don't like not being together."

Adora's grip tightened on the steering wheel.

"I know, sweetheart," she whispered back, the truth spilling out. "I don't like it either."

She took a shaky breath. "Your mom… she wasn't getting what she needed from me. Things she needed to be happy. And she decided she needed to live on her own, not be my wife anymore."

She chose her words carefully, trying to validate Catra's choice without villainizing her or placing blame Finn could internalize.

"I wish… I wish I could get your mom to come home, too. More than anything. But we have to accept that this is what she needs right now. To live on her own."

Finn was quiet for a long moment, processing. Adora watched their reflection in the mirror, seeing the gears turning. Their ears flicked back thoughtfully.

Then, the question came, innocent and utterly devastating: "Does that mean… Mom's going to find another wife?"

Adora felt the question like a physical blow. The air rushed out of her lungs. She'd been trying desperately *not* to let her mind wander down that dark path.

The image of Catra with someone else—laughing, relaxed, *loved* in the way Adora had failed to love her—was pure agony.

She gripped the wheel harder, her knuckles white.

"I…" she stammered, her voice strangled. "It's… possible, buddy. People sometimes do that."

Finn absorbed this. Another pause. Their tail twitched nervously.

Then, quieter, even more terrifying: "Are *you* going to find another wife?"

The world seemed to tilt. Adora's vision blurred for a second.

The thought was inconceivable. Catra wasn't just her wife; she was her heart, her history, her other half. The idea of replacing her… of even *trying*…

Adora swallowed hard against the lump in her throat, tears threatening again. "Finny, I… don't know. I still love your mom. I don't know… if I *can* find someone else."

The raw honesty felt like peeling her skin off. "You and your mom… you're my whole world."

Finn didn't respond. Adora glanced back. Their eyes were closed, their breathing deepening. The emotional storm had finally exhausted them into sleep.

Adora drove the rest of the way in numb silence, the weight of Finn's questions pressing down on her like a physical force.

Back at the house, she carried the sleeping Finn upstairs, cradling their warm, furry weight, tucking them gently into bed, brushing a stray strand of hair from their forehead.

"Sleep well, space ranger," she whispered, her voice cracking.

Finn murmured incoherently, already deep in dreamland, mercifully free of the day's pain for a few hours, their tail curling loosely around their hip.

Adora stood in the doorway for a long moment, watching Finn sleep, the quiet of the house descending like a shroud.

The events of the evening replayed in her mind on a loop: the awkwardness of the apartment, Catra's unexpected vulnerability and visible pain, the shared moment of understanding, Finn's devastating meltdown, Catra's reluctant agreement to family night, Finn's innocent, world-shattering questions.

Too much. Far too much.

The silence of the house, always an oppressive weight, now felt like a vacuum, screaming for something to fill it and somehow managing to feel even emptier than before.

She couldn't face it. Not the thoughts, not the memories, not the yawning chasm of the future.

She walked downstairs, her footsteps echoing in the stillness. She bypassed the kitchen where she'd collapsed after the last exchange.

Tonight demanded something stronger than silent grief.

She went to the rarely used liquor cabinet in the dining room–a holdover from hosting dinners they no longer had. She pulled out a bottle of amber whiskey, the label unfamiliar. She didn't care what it was.

In the dark kitchen, illuminated only by the dim glow of the stove hood light, she grabbed a heavy-bottomed glass. She poured. The liquid splashed, a generous measure.

She didn't hesitate. She lifted the glass and took a long, burning swallow.

It seared a path down her throat, a welcome fire meant to cauterize the searing pain in her chest.

She leaned against the counter, staring into the dark living room. The image of Catra rubbing her hand, her exhausted face, superimposed itself over the memory of Finn's tear-streaked plea.

The tentative connection, the horrifying questions, the sheer emotional whiplash of the evening. Hope warred with despair, guilt with a desperate, futile longing.

She poured another glass.

The bite of the alcohol was a blunt instrument against the razor-sharp edges of her feelings. It didn't solve anything.

It wouldn't bring Catra back. It wouldn't erase Finn's pain or her own failings.

But for tonight, in the suffocating silence of the house that echoed with ghosts and the terrifying uncertainty of tomorrow's family night, it was the only anchor she could grasp.

She lifted the glass again, the liquid catching the faint light.

Too many ups. Too many downs. Too many feelings.

The whiskey promised numbness, however temporary.

And for tonight, that was all she could handle.

Chapter 5: The Space Between Weekends

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The silence that greeted Catra upon waking was profound.

Not the gentle, companionable quiet of a shared space where another presence hummed just beneath the surface, but a thick, hollow vacuum.

Sunlight streamed through the thin blinds of her apartment, striping the bare walls and utilitarian furniture.

Saturday. Finn's week with Adora.

The transition from the structured chaos of Finn's presence to this absolute stillness was always jarring. When she lived in the house—*their* house—weekends were vibrant, messy tapestries woven with togetherness.

Even the lazy days were full: Finn sprawled on the living room floor with crayons, Adora reading nearby, Catra maybe sketching or napping nearby, the low murmur of conversation or the shared silence of contentment.

Adventures were common—the zoo echoing with Finn's shrieks of delight, the aquarium's cool blue glow on their faces, picnics in the park or in the back yard beneath the maple tree Adora planted.

The space had resonated with life, connection, *belonging*.

Now, the apartment echoed only with absence.

Five days hunched over a laptop had left her body feeling like a rusted hinge—stiff, achy, protesting every movement. Her

shoulders were knots of tension, her lower back a dull throb, her wrists tight and complaining.

The thought of spending another day sedentary, confined to these four walls with their faint smell of lemon cleaner and isolation, was suffocating.

Yet, the bone-deep fatigue from the relentless data entry grind made grand plans unthinkable. Hiking? Museum? Even a movie?

All required energy she didn't possess and money she couldn't justify spending.

She lay in bed, staring at the ceiling. The choice was a stark internal war:

Stay. Rest. Save money. Versus *Get out. Move. Breathe different air*.

The cooped-up feeling won. She needed a rebellion against the grind, however small.

Coffee. A simple treat. A destination. A reason to move her body outside the apartment-to-school-to-apartment circuit.

It felt extravagant in its mundanity, a necessary indulgence.

She pushed herself up, wincing as her muscles protested. A quick shower did little to ease the stiffness, just made her aware of the new, unfamiliar softness settling around her middle, her thighs.

Her reflection in the steamy mirror showed tired eyes and fur that lacked its usual luster.

The physical changes were subtle but undeniable, a consequence of eight hours a day chained to her small dining table and a hard chair wholly unfit for the task, fueled by budget meals and stress.

Her body, once lithe and strong, felt… different. Shaped by circumstance without her consent.

She didn’t hate it, not exactly, but she hated the feeling of powerlessness, the erosion of the physical self she’d known.

Dressing in comfortable jeans and a soft sweater, she grabbed her keys and wallet.

Stepping outside into the cool morning air was its own small relief. She chose a coffee shop a fifteen-minute walk away, one she’d passed but never entered.

The walk itself was medicine. Her muscles initially protested, but as she moved, the stiffness began to loosen. The simple act of placing one foot in front of the other, feeling the pavement beneath her sneakers, the air moving past her face, the subtle stretch in her hips and back—it was grounding.

It reminded her body it was meant for more than data entry.

Yet, beneath the physical relief, a quiet worry hummed.

What will I feel like in five years? Ten? The image of chronic pain, worsened posture, a body permanently molded by that wretched chair, flickered unpleasantly.

This wasn’t sustainable.

The coffee shop was cozy, bustling but not overwhelming. The rich aroma of beans was a welcome assault. She joined the short queue.

The barista taking orders was young, maybe early twenties, with bright eyes and an easy smile. Effortlessly attractive. Catra watched her interact with a customer, a pang of something complex twisting in her chest.

I used to be that.

Young. Vibrant. Unburdened by the weight of a failed marriage, shared custody, financial strain, and the relentless erosion of a dead-end job.

Being single and adrift at twenty had felt like freedom, possibility. At forty, it felt like… driftwood. Aimless, battered, slowly sinking. The terrifying heaviness of it settled on her shoulders again.

In her lowest moments, when the loneliness felt like a physical pressure in her chest and her self-worth plummeted, she wondered if anyone would ever look at her again with genuine desire, with the kind of heat Adora used to radiate.

Was that chapter truly closed, sealed with the finality of divorce papers yet to be filed? The thought was bleak.

She ordered a simple black coffee, the cheapest option, adding a splash of milk herself at the counter.

Holding the warm cup, she walked towards a small park she remembered passing on her way. It wasn't the beautiful, sprawling park near their old house, the one with the duck pond Finn loved, but it had benches and trees and patches of grass.

Finding an unoccupied bench tucked slightly away, she sat, cradling the coffee.

The sunlight, weak but persistent, felt glorious on her tawny fur, a physical comfort she hadn't realized she craved so deeply.

She closed her eyes for a moment, letting the sounds wash over her—distant traffic, the chatter of other park-goers, birdsong, the rustle of leaves.

It was *alive*. Grounding. Calming. A counterpoint to the sterile silence of her apartment.

Her thoughts inevitably drifted towards the evening. Family Night. The first one in over a year.

A knot of pure dread tightened in her stomach.

The awkwardness, the forced proximity, the sheer *pain* of being near Adora in the ghost-filled space of their former home… It felt

like willingly walking into an emotional minefield.

She could picture Adora's earnest, hopeful eyes, Finn's desperate need for them to just *be* together, the suffocating weight of everything unsaid hanging between them.

The potential for disaster felt immense.

Yet… beneath the dread, if she was ruthlessly honest with herself, flickered a treacherous spark of… anticipation. A tiny, dangerous ember of excitement.

The thought of seeing Finn in their shared space, of perhaps catching a glimpse of the easy rhythm they'd once had, even for just a few hours…

It was a siren song, promising warmth while threatening shipwreck.

Catra took a slow sip of coffee, the bitterness sharp on her tongue.

She had known leaving would be hard. She'd braced for the emotional fallout, the loneliness, the logistical nightmare.

But she hadn't truly grasped the sheer, unglamorous *grind* of it.

The relentless sacrifice: financial security for independence, time for money, energy for survival. The physical toll of the job, made exponentially worse by her inability to afford the basic comforts that could mitigate it—a proper ergonomic chair, a decent desk, fewer working hours, the simple luxury of *recreation*.

The constant calculation: *Can I afford this coffee? Should I walk instead of taking the bus to save $1.75? Do these shoes need replacing, or can they last another month?*

It was exhausting. Soul-crushing in its banality.

A wave of longing washed over her, sharp and sudden. She wished, fiercely and pointlessly, that she could just… go back.

Back to the house, back to Adora, back to the comfortable life. Slip back into the rhythm they'd known.

But the thought curdled instantly.

Tucking her tail and returning? Groveling at Adora's feet, admitting she couldn't hack it on her own? The sheer *gall* of it made her recoil.

Pride, a stubborn, deep-rooted thing, flared hot within her. *She* had made this choice. *She* had upended their lives—Adora's, Finn's, her own.

To crawl back now would be an admission of catastrophic failure, a humiliation she couldn't stomach.

She couldn't face Adora's potential pity, or worse, her justified *"I told you so"* (even if Adora would be too kind to voice it).

Looking back, through the lens of a year's worth of lonely nights and aching muscles, Catra understood the blinding pain that had driven her. It had been a survival instinct, pure and simple.

Staying felt like slow suffocation, a death by a thousand broken promises. She *had* needed to protect herself.

But hindsight also brought a sharp clarity she hadn't possessed in the raw immediacy of her hurt.

She wished, desperately, she'd communicated more effectively, *earlier*. Not just the surface frustrations, but the deep, existential wound of feeling perpetually unimportant. She wished she'd found the words to make Adora understand the magnitude of the hurt before the well of trust ran completely dry.

Before the chasm had become uncrossable.

And Adora *had* offered. Immediately. Therapy. Cutting back work. Fixing things. Catra remembered the desperate promises whispered through the door, poured into texts and emails.

At the time, steeped in betrayal and exhaustion, she hadn't believed a single word. She couldn't. The well was poisoned.

But now… now she found herself wishing, with a sharp pang of regret, that she'd possessed the strength to be *focused on repair* back then.

That she'd been able to set aside the burning need for retribution, for Adora to *feel* the depth of the pain she'd caused.

Because, Catra admitted to herself on the sun-dappled bench, a part of her *had* reveled in refusing Adora. In being the one with the power to say "no," to shut the door, to inflict a fraction of the helplessness she'd felt for years.

Watching Adora's desperate attempts to fix things crumble against her wall of indifference had felt… good. Vindicating. For once, Catra held the cards.

But that vindication had been a poison pill. It had hurt her too, cementing the rift, solidifying the separation even as it soothed her pride.

It had been the final nail in the coffin of "us."

Leaving had felt like liberation. An escape. And she *had* needed the space, the brutal perspective of this last, miserable year.

She'd needed to see herself survive. She'd needed to see Adora's genuine misery—glimpsed yesterday—confirming that her pain hadn't been imagined, that her departure had forced a reckoning Adora had avoided for years. That validation had been crucial.

But the cost was etched in Finn's tear-streaked face last night. Catra's breath hitched.

She'd thought Finn was adapting. Had she just seen what she wanted to see? Just as Adora had expected her to just "understand" the broken promises, had Catra expected Finn to just "understand" the seismic shift in their family structure?

The guilt was a physical weight.

Finn hadn't chosen this. One day, they had a secure world with two parents who lived together. The next, it shattered into a year of fragmented time, divided loyalties, and fleeting, awkward hand-offs.

No wonder the dam broke.

Catra had been lonely, yes, achingly so. But it had been her choice. Finn had had no say. Their loneliness, their plea for wholeness… that was Catra's doing. They hadn't abandoned the family—*she* had.

The old question resurfaced: Would it have been better to stay? To endure the slow death of her spirit for Finn's sake? She knew the answer intellectually. An unhappy marriage wasn't healthy for a child.

But seeing Finn's raw misery made that answer feel hollow, cruel. It made her want to undo everything.

She felt trapped in an un-winnable situation, where every choice inflicted pain.

And Adora… Yesterday. Catra closed her eyes, the sunlight suddenly too bright. Asking Adora how she was… it had slipped out, an unexpected crack in her own armor.

And Adora's response… "Rough." The sheer understatement of it. The weariness etched into every line of Adora's face, the slump of her shoulders, the utter lack of her usual vibrant energy…

Catra hadn't let herself truly *see* it before. She'd been too wrapped in her own hurt, her own survival. Seeing it yesterday… it

had ignited guilt. Hot, immediate guilt.

She hadn’t been happy, so she left. And now? She was still struggling, still profoundly unhappy. And Adora was clearly devastated. Finn was heartbroken.

Had she ruined everything for everyone, herself included, for no reason? Had her escape merely traded one kind of misery for another, while dragging everyone else down with her?

The thought was paralyzing. The coffee in her cup had gone cold.

She stood abruptly, the movement stiff.

The peaceful park scene now felt mocking. She strode to a nearby trash bin and tossed the cup in with more force than necessary.

The walk back to her apartment felt longer, heavier. The temporary relief of movement was gone, replaced by the familiar ache in her body and the crushing weight of guilt and doubt settling back into her bones.

The empty apartment awaited, a silent testament to the life she’d chosen, the wreckage she’d created.

Across town, the atmosphere in Adora Gray’s house was a volatile mix of nervous energy and forced cheer.

Adora moved around the familiar kitchen, a whirlwind of focused activity that couldn't quite mask the tremor in her hands.

The scent of garlic and tomatoes simmering in a pot filled the air—spaghetti, Finn’s favorite, a safe choice. She stirred the sauce with perhaps a little too much vigor.

Finn sat perched on a tall stool at the kitchen island, legs swinging, their fluffy tail swishing rhythmically against the stool leg.

They chattered excitedly, ears perked forward with enthusiasm. "…and Mom said she liked the purple spaceship best, Mama! And then Kyle brought his new BlipBase expansion pack to art club, and it has a *black hole generator!* It was SO cool! Do you think Mom will think it's cool too tonight? Will she play BlipBase with me?"

"Of course she'll think it's cool, Finny," Adora said, forcing a bright smile, her voice slightly higher than usual. "And I'm sure she'd love to see your colony."

She wiped her hands on a dish towel, her gaze darting to the clock on the microwave. 5:45 PM. Catra was due at 6:00. Every minute felt like an hour stretched thin. "Did you set up the living room like we planned? Blankets? Pillow fort materials?"

"Yep! The extra fluffy blanket for Mom 'cause she gets cold! And the big pillows!" Finn beamed, radiating pure, uncomplicated anticipation.

To them, this wasn't a fraught experiment; it was a miraculous return to normalcy, however temporary.

Adora's heart clenched. Finn's excitement was palpable, a stark contrast to the storm of anxiety churning inside her.

She was terrified. Terrified of the awkwardness, the painful distance that would stretch between her and Catra in the very space where they'd once been closest.

Terrified of saying the wrong thing, of seeing the guardedness in Catra's eyes, of feeling the cold reality of their separation solidify even further in this attempt at togetherness.

She was terrified of how much it would hurt to be so close yet so irrevocably far.

But more than anything, she was terrified of disappointing Finn.

This fragile hope, this tentative bridge they were building over the chasm of their broken family… it felt incredibly precarious. One wrong step, one spark of tension, and it could collapse, taking Finn's newfound hope with it.

Adora felt the weight of that responsibility like a physical yoke.

She *had* to make this work. For Finn.

She checked the sauce again, adjusted the heat. She smoothed her shirt—she'd changed three times, settling on comfortable jeans and a soft blue sweater, something approachable, non-threatening.

She'd even tidied the living room beyond its usual state, fluffing pillows Finn had already arranged, straightening picture frames.

Her reflection in the dark window over the sink showed a face tense with worry, eyes shadowed. She took a deep, steadying breath.

Just breathe. For Finn. Just get through this for Finn.

The doorbell rang.

A sharp, clear chime that severed the nervous chatter and echoed through the suddenly silent kitchen.

Finn gasped, their ears snapping upright, scrambling off the stool and landing lightly on the balls of their feet.

"She's here! Mom's here!" They dashed towards the front hall, their tail streaming straight out behind them.

Adora froze, the wooden spoon hovering over the pot. Her heart hammered against her ribs, a frantic drumbeat against the sudden stillness.

All the rehearsed words, the forced calm, evaporated. The moment was here. Catra was on the other side of the door.

The past year, the loneliness, the guilt, Finn’s tears, the tentative conversation yesterday, the terrifying uncertainty of the future—it all condensed into this single, breathless instant.

She lowered the spoon slowly, her hand trembling slightly. She wiped her palms on her jeans again. Forced her feet to move.

One step. Then another. Towards the front hall, towards the door, towards Catra.

The sound of Finn fumbling with the lock, their small claws clicking lightly on the metal knob, was loud in the quiet house.

Adora reached the entrance just as Finn pulled the heavy door open.

There, silhouetted against the fading twilight, stood Catra.

Chapter End Notes

gasp! how do we think family night is going to go, friends?

Chapter 6: Ghosts and Purrs

Chapter Notes

aaaaaaaaaaahhhhhhhhh it's happening!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stood frozen behind Finn, the cheerful clatter of the kitchen fading into a muffled roar in her ears.

The door swung open, revealing Catra silhouetted against the twilight, a figure both achingly familiar and painfully distant.

The air crackled with unspoken history, a year’s worth of hurt and awkwardness condensed into this single threshold.

"Hey, sweetheart," Catra’s voice, softer than Adora expected, broke the spell.

She stepped inside, instantly kneeling to envelop Finn in a tight hug. Finn burrowed into her, their fluffy tail wrapping instinctively around Catra's wrist, a small, happy sound escaping them.

Catra buried her face for a second in Finn’s hair, inhaling the familiar scent of warm fur, a grounding anchor in this emotionally precarious space.

She pulled back, forcing a smile.

"It smells good! Are you cooking dinner tonight, Finny?" she teased, her voice light but her eyes scanning the entryway behind Finn, inevitably landing on Adora.

Finn giggled, their ears perking forward happily, the sound dissolving some of the tension. "No, Mom! Mama's cooking tonight!"

Catra straightened, her gaze meeting Adora’s fully.

The warmth she'd shown Finn evaporated, replaced by a carefully constructed neutrality.

"Hey, Adora," she said, her tone stiff, polite. "Thanks for having me over."

The words were innocuous, a necessary social script. Yet, before Adora's brain could engage the filter installed after a year of painful distance, her heart spoke:

"Of course. You know you're always welcome here."

The silence that followed was suffocating. Adora watched the words find their mark, a tremor of raw pain flashing across Catra's face before defensiveness slammed down.

Catra's ears pinned back, her tail giving a single, sharp lash.

Adora's own stomach plummeted.

Idiot. Stupid, clumsy idiot.

She'd overstepped. The fragile peace of the evening, the tentative agreement to be here *for Finn*, felt instantly fragile.

She saw Catra's instinct to withdraw, to snap, to rebuild the wall Adora had just accidentally chipped.

But then, Adora also saw the conscious effort Catra made.

A deep breath, a subtle straightening of her shoulders. For Finn. For this fragile experiment.

And beneath the defensiveness, Adora thought she saw it—a tiny spark of warmth, quickly smothered, at the sentiment: *Always welcome here*.

"Right," Catra murmured, looking away, breaking the charged eye contact. "Well. Smells great. Lead the way?"

Adora nodded, feeling like a marionette with tangled strings. "This way. Dinner's just about ready."

She gestured towards the dining room, her movements stiff. As she turned to lead them, her mind raced.

Always welcome here.

Did she mean it? With every fiber of her being, yes. But seeing the complex storm it had triggered in Catra… it terrified her.

What if Catra *did* swallow her pride? What if she admitted she wanted to come back, wanted to try?

Adora would take her back without hesitation. But the fear that followed was paralyzing. Could she be trusted to truly change, to be the partner Catra needed, not the one she thought she should be?

Could *they* be trusted not to fall back into the same patterns? The hope was intoxicating and terrifying in equal measure.

In the dining room, the table was set simply but nicely. The aroma of garlic and tomatoes was stronger here, comforting and familiar.

Adora busied herself with serving, focusing on the practical task. "Can I get you something to drink? Water? Juice? Or…"

She hesitated, then pushed forward, needing some liquid courage herself, or perhaps offering Catra the same. "I opened a bottle of red. It should pair okay with the pasta?"

Catra paused, her hand hovering near a chair back. For a fraction of a second, Adora saw a flicker of something like shame cross her face.

"Wine… yeah. Wine would be good. Thanks." She pulled out the chair and sat, avoiding Adora’s eyes.

The unspoken message was a scream in Catra's mind:

You wanted to bring a bottle. You couldn't afford to. Your life is harder, poorer, less comfortable without Adora. You can't provide.

The internal voice was cruel, reinforcing the narrative of inadequacy that had gnawed at her since she'd signed the lease on her apartment.

She accepted the glass Adora poured, taking a larger-than-intended sip, the rich flavor a stark contrast to the bitterness in her mouth.

Dinner was… surprisingly manageable.

Awkwardness hummed beneath the surface, but Finn became their savior. They chattered non-stop about their week, their tail swishing energetically as they talked, about art club, about the movie, about BlipBase strategy.

Catra and Adora focused their attention on responding, asking questions, laughing at the right moments. It created a buffer, a shared purpose that allowed them to avoid the minefield of direct conversation between them.

The meal itself was simple but good. Adora had tossed a salad—crisp greens, cherry tomatoes, a light vinaigrette.

Catra realized, with a pang of self-consciousness, how much her own diet had narrowed. Pasta, rice, budget-friendly carbs that filled but didn't necessarily nourish.

The fresh vegetables were a revelation, a taste of a life where grocery choices weren't dictated solely by price-per-ounce.

Her body felt a quiet gratitude she hadn't anticipated.

As plates were cleared (Adora's efficient movements a familiar, if painful, echo of countless meals she'd cleaned up after before), Adora suggested moving to the couch.

"Movie time? Finn, you ready?"

"Yeah!" Finn dashed ahead, their tail held high, eager to claim their spot in the pillow fort they'd constructed earlier.

Catra followed more slowly, entering the living room. The sight hit her like a physical wave: the big, fluffed pillows, the soft, fuzzy blanket she *knew* was the one Adora always brought out for her because she ran colder.

It was laid out on "her" end of the couch.

The care in the gesture, the ghost of a thousand cozy movie nights, squeezed her heart painfully.

In the past, she'd be curled into Adora's side, head on her shoulder, or stretched out with her feet in Adora's lap, Adora's warm hands absently massaging her ankles.

Tonight, the space between them on the couch felt vast, an uncrossable chasm. They sat stiffly, carefully not touching, each angled slightly towards Finn on the floor.

Finn had chosen a vibrant animated film, its core message hammering home with unintentional cruelty: family sticks together, no matter what.

Catra winced internally but kept her expression neutral for Finn's sake.

As the movie started, the awkwardness was palpable. Adora sat ramrod straight, hyper-aware of every breath Catra took. Catra focused intently on the screen, her tail wrapped tightly around her waist.

But slowly, almost imperceptibly, the tension began to ease. The rest of the bottle of wine, shared in silence during the first act, helped. Finn's uninhibited laughter at the slapstick antics on screen was infectious.

A particularly absurd gag involving a sentient cheese puff elicited a genuine, surprised chuckle from Catra. Adora heard it, a sound she hadn't heard directed at anything *she* was part of in over a year.

She risked a glance.

Catra was smiling, a real, if small, smile. Their eyes met briefly over Finn's head as Finn dissolved into giggles again.

It wasn't a smile for each other, not exactly, but a shared moment of amusement *about* Finn.

It was the closest thing to warmth they'd exchanged since the separation.

Adora felt a spark of hope ignite, fragile as a soap bubble.

The familiar sounds of the house—the hum of the refrigerator, the soft rustle of Finn shifting in their pillow nest, the soundtrack of the movie—combined with the warmth of the blanket, the lingering effects of the wine, and the sheer emotional exhaustion of the week and the evening itself, began to work on Catra.

The stiffness in her shoulders started to melt. The constant vigilance, the effort of maintaining the wall, became too much.

Her eyelids grew heavy. The vibrant colors on the screen blurred.

Just for a moment, she thought, *I'll just close my eyes for a moment*…

Adora glanced over during a quieter moment in the film, intending to share another amused look at Finn's engrossed expression.

Her breath caught. Catra was asleep.

Utterly still, breathing softly and evenly, her face relaxed in a way Adora hadn't seen in… she couldn't remember how long.

The faint lines of tension around her eyes and mouth were smoothed away. She was burrowed into the pile of pillows, the fuzzy blanket pulled up to her chin, one hand tucked loosely beneath her cheek.

She looked… peaceful. Vulnerable. Exhausted, but safe.

The sight sent a sharp pang of longing through Adora's chest, so intense it was a physical ache.

She felt safe enough here to let go.

The thought was a balm and a torment. Adora's fingers twitched with the overwhelming urge to reach across the space.

To gently tuck a stray strand of dark brown hair behind Catra's ear, her touch feather-light. To smooth the blanket more securely around her shoulders.

To pull her close, to feel the familiar weight and warmth of her against Adora's side, to press a tender kiss to the top of her head, breathing in the scent of her fur.

To protect this moment of peace for her.

But she couldn't. The boundary was invisible but ironclad. Any touch would shatter the fragile trust that had allowed Catra to fall asleep here at all.

Adora clenched her hands in her lap, forcing the yearning down.

Finn let out another giggle and turned to point out something to Catra.

Their eyes widened slightly seeing their mom asleep.

They looked up at Adora. Adora met Finn's gaze and raised a finger to her lips in the universal '*shhh*' gesture.

A slow, understanding smile spread across Finn's face. They nodded conspiratorially, a silent agreement formed.

Let Mom sleep.

It was a familiar script from countless past movie nights. Catra, despite her sharp energy, had always been prone to dozing off during evening movies, lulled by warmth and comfort.

The shared memory, the silent coordination with Finn, felt like stepping into a warm bath. Adora's eyes stung.

As the movie neared its inevitably heartwarming conclusion, Finn lost interest in the predictable resolution.

They crawled up from their pillow nest and onto the couch, wriggling instinctively into the space between Adora and the sleeping Catra.

They nestled down, a small, warm weight seeking comfort. The movement caused Catra, still deeply asleep, to shift unconsciously.

She turned slightly towards the warmth, her arm draping loosely over Finn, her face nestling closer to the top of their head. Her hand rested near Finn's shoulder.

Adora automatically placed her own hand on Finn's other side, her fingers gently stroking the soft dark blonde fur on their arm.

Finn let out a soft sigh, a deep, contented purr rumbling to life in their small chest.

It was a sound Adora cherished, the ultimate sign of Finn feeling safe and loved.

Then, almost inaudibly at first, another sound joined it. A low, resonant vibration, softer and deeper than Finn's. Adora froze, her breath catching.

It was coming from Catra.

A quiet, steady purr, emanating from her chest as she slept, curled protectively around Finn.

It was a sound Adora hadn't heard in over a year, a sound intrinsically tied to her deepest sense of home and love.

Tears welled up in Adora's eyes, blurring the end credits rolling silently on the screen. She blinked rapidly, trying to hold them back.

This was what she wanted back. This impossible, beautiful, heartbreaking tableau: Finn safe and purring between them, Catra relaxed and trusting enough to purr in her sleep, the shared warmth, the profound sense of *family*.

The life she had taken for granted, the life she had broken through her neglect.

The ache of wanting it back, of knowing how close it felt yet how impossibly far it truly was, was a physical weight on her chest.

She watched them, Catra and Finn intertwined in sleep, bathed in the flickering light of the television, and felt a love so fierce it threatened to consume her, mixed with a grief so profound it felt like dying.

The movie ended, the screen fading to black, plunging the room into near-darkness lit only by the dim glow of a nightlight in the hallway.

The quiet purrs—Finn's higher pitch and Catra's deeper resonance—were the only sounds.

Adora closed her eyes, leaning her head back against the couch. The urge to let sleep take her too, to sink into this fragile, stolen moment of pseudo-wholeness, was almost overwhelming.

To pretend, just for a little longer.

But reality was a cold splash. She couldn’t. This intimacy was borrowed, accidental.

Catra hadn’t chosen to fall asleep near her, hadn’t chosen to purr. It was a vulnerability granted by exhaustion and Finn’s presence, not by trust in Adora.

To stay, to let Catra wake up finding Adora asleep beside her… it might feel like a violation, a boundary crossed. The fragile peace of the evening could shatter in an instant.

Reluctantly, heart heavy, Adora opened her eyes. She gently touched Catra’s shoulder.

"Catra?" she whispered. "Catra, wake up. Movie's over."

Catra stirred, a soft murmur escaping her lips. Her eyes fluttered open, confusion clouding them.

For a blissful second, she snuggled closer to Finn, her purr deepening slightly. Then, recognition dawned.

Adora saw the sequence of emotions: comfort, confusion, realization, disappointment, panic, grief.

Her purr cut off abruptly.

Adora quickly raised her finger to her lips again, her eyes wide with a plea.

"Shhh," she whispered urgently, nodding down at Finn, still peacefully asleep and purring against Catra.

Catra followed her gaze.

Seeing Finn, feeling the warmth and the soft vibration against her, her expression softened instantly, the panic and grief replaced by pure, unguarded tenderness.

The defensiveness melted away, leaving only the deep, abiding love for their child. She gently smoothed Finn’s hair, her touch infinitely gentle.

Adora watched, her own heart overflowing with shared adoration.

The moment hung, suspended in the quiet darkness, filled only by Finn’s purr. It was a glimpse of what could have been, what *should* have been.

Then Catra sighed, the soft sound heavy with resignation.

"We should get Finn to bed," she whispered, her voice thick with sleep and unshed tears. "And I should…get going."

The spell shattered. The distance rushed back in, cold and absolute.

Adora nodded, swallowing hard.

"Yeah. Okay." Carefully, she slid her arms under Finn, lifting the sleeping child.

Finn murmured but didn’t wake, instinctively curling into Adora’s hold.

Catra stood, smoothing her clothes, avoiding Adora’s eyes again.

Together, moving with the quiet coordination of long practice, they carried Finn upstairs to their room.

Tucking Finn in was a silent ritual, both women brushing stray hairs from their forehead, adjusting blankets, sharing one last look of pure love over the sleeping form.

Finn stirred slightly, eyes fluttering open just a slit. "Mama? Mom?" they mumbled sleepily.

"We're here, sweetheart," Adora whispered.

"Go back to sleep, space ranger," Catra added softly, her hand stroking the fur behind Finn's ear.

"I liked family night," Finn murmured, already drifting off again. "Can we do it again?"

Catra’s breath hitched. She leaned down, pressing a lingering kiss to Finn’s forehead.

"Yeah, Finny," she whispered, the words thick with emotion she couldn’t hide. "We can do this again."

Adora echoed the kiss, her own eyes burning. "Sleep well, buddy."

They left the room, pulling the door almost closed. The walk downstairs felt longer than the ascent, the comfortable silence replaced by a suffocating awareness of what came next.

Catra gathered her purse and light jacket from the hook by the door. She lingered, fiddling with the strap, not quite meeting Adora’s eyes.

Adora broke the silence, her voice low and sincere.

"Thank you. For agreeing to this. For coming. I know… it was hard."

Catra nodded, still looking down. "It meant so much to Finn."

She paused, then added, the words seeming to surprise even her as they came out, "It *was* hard. But it wasn't… bad."

She finally looked up, her mismatched eyes meeting Adora’s in the dim entryway light.

They held a complex mix of exhaustion, sadness, and a flicker of something else. Relief?

"I missed… laughing together as a family."

The admission, small as it was, struck Adora deep. She nodded rapidly, fighting the tears that threatened again.

"I did too," she whispered, the words rough.

The air between them felt charged, fragile.

Adora hesitated, the words bubbling up, propelled by the evening's fleeting closeness, the sight of Catra asleep, the shared purr, the raw honesty Catra had just offered.

"Catra…" she began, her voice tentative. "I have to ask. Is this… working for you? This separation? Is this… what you needed? Are you… happy?"

She braced herself.

Catra's reaction was immediate and visceral.

Her ears pinned flat back against her skull, her tail lashed once, sharply, against her leg. Her posture stiffened, walls slamming back up.

For a terrifying second, Adora thought she'd destroyed everything, that Catra would bolt without another word.

But Catra didn't leave.

She took a shuddering breath, her gaze dropping back to the floor. When she spoke, her voice was quiet, strained, but it wasn't anger.

It was a profound weariness, laced with confusion.

"I don't know, Adora." The words were barely audible. "I feel… confused."

She looked up again, her eyes bright with unshed tears that mirrored Adora's own.

"I *needed* the space. The distance. You hurt me…" Her voice cracked. "You hurt me so badly. For so long."

She swallowed hard, forcing the next words out. "And by the time you were ready to fix things… I couldn't trust you. I couldn't…let myself get hurt again. I…"

She trailed off, shaking her head slightly, a gesture of defeat.

She'd reached her limit. The vulnerability she'd shown was monumental, and it had drained her.

"I can't… talk about this right now. Not tonight."

Adora's hand twitched at her side, an instinctive urge to reach out, to offer comfort, to bridge the gap with touch.

She clenched her fist, reining it in.

"Okay," she breathed, her own voice thick. "Okay."

Catra looked at her, searching her face. "If…I decide I want to talk? Later?" she started, hesitant. "I'll text you?"

The spark of hope flared again, brighter this time, though Adora tried to temper it.

"Catra," she said, her voice earnest, "of course. Anytime. I want to be in your life. As much as you'll let me."

The words hung there–a plea, an offer, a promise she desperately hoped she could keep this time.

Catra nodded, a single, jerky movement.

She wiped at her eyes with the back of her hand, frustrated, exhausted. "I ought to go. It's getting late."

She pulled her jacket on, not meeting Adora's eyes again. "Good night, Adora."

"Good night, Catra," Adora whispered, the words catching in her throat.

Catra opened the door and stepped out into the cool night air, never looking back.

The door clicked shut softly behind her, the sound final.

Adora stood alone in the silent entryway, the lingering scent of Catra’s shampoo and the ghost of Finn’s purr the only remnants of the evening.

The emptiness of the house rushed in, heavier than ever.

Catra walked to her car, the tears she’d held back finally spilling over, tracing hot paths down her cheeks.

The drive home was a blur of streetlights and conflicting emotions churning like a storm inside her.

Pain—sharp and familiar, the ache of loss and betrayal.

Joy—fleeting but real, from laughing with Finn, from seeing Adora’s care in the blanket, the salad, the wine.

Sadness—deep and abiding, for Finn’s confusion, for the life shattered.

Relief—that the night was over, that it hadn’t been a disaster, that Finn was happy.

Hope—terrifying and fragile, sparked by Adora’s words, by the shared moment over Finn.

Fear—of what that hope meant, of getting hurt again, of the unknown future.

It had been unimaginably hard.

It had also been, undeniably, one of the best nights she’d had in recent memory.

She needed to think. To unravel the tangled knot of feelings. To understand what, if anything, had shifted within her tonight.

But her body and mind were utterly spent, drained by the emotional marathon. The thoughts would have to wait.

First, she needed the oblivion of sleep.

She pulled into her parking space outside the anonymous apartment building, cut the engine, and sat for a moment in the silent car, the echoes of Finn’s laughter and Adora’s whispered "always welcome" ringing in her ears before she finally gathered the strength to go inside.

To her empty apartment.

Alone.

Chapter End Notes

hey that... could have gone worse, right???

Chapter 7: Tentative Threads

The Saturday afternoon sun dappled through the vibrant green leaves of the sprawling oak tree in Bright Moon Park.

Adora sat on a worn wooden bench, phone pressed to her ear, her gaze fixed on the small, agile figure scaling the thick branches above.

Finn, their dark blonde fur catching the sunlight like spun gold, fluffy tail held out for balance, moved with an instinctive grace only a magicat child possessed, claws lightly scoring the bark for grip as they chattered happily to an imaginary co-pilot about navigating asteroid fields.

"…and then she just *fell asleep*, Glimmer," Adora breathed into the phone, her voice a mixture of awe and lingering heartache.

"Right there on the couch. Finn was purring, and then… *she* started purring too. It was like… nothing had changed. For a moment."

On the other end of the line, Adora could picture Glimmer's expressive face, likely contorted in a mix of sympathy and lingering frustration. Bow's calmer presence would be there too, a grounding counterpoint.

"It sounds… intense, Adora," Bow's gentle voice came through, layered with concern. "Vulnerability from Catra? That's huge. And asking how *you* were doing? That's progress, right?"

"It felt huge," Adora admitted, watching Finn execute a daring leap to a higher branch, landing silently and effortlessly, her heart skipping a beat despite knowing their capabilities.

"And the whole night was this weird push-pull. Awkward one minute, then weirdly comfortable the next. Her falling asleep… it killed me, Bow. It was everything I want back, right there, and I couldn't touch her. Couldn't even let myself fall asleep beside her."

"Okay, hold up," Glimmer's voice cut in, sharper. "Let's not romanticize the catnap, Adora. She was exhausted, probably emotionally wrung out, and maybe a little wine-drunk. It doesn't mean she's ready to move back in!"

"I know that, Glimmer!" Adora snapped, then immediately softened.

"I *know*. But… after Finn was in bed… we talked. Actually talked. More than logistics. She admitted she felt… confused. She didn't shut me down immediately. She even said she missed laughing together as a family."

Adora squeezed her eyes shut. "I'm so terrified to hope. What if I'm reading it all wrong? What if I push too hard and scare her away completely? But… what if this is a chance? A real chance to start mending things? I don't want to let it slip away because I'm too afraid to be brave."

Silence stretched on the line, filled only by the distant sounds of the park and Finn's cheerful monologue overhead.

"Adora," Bow began, his tone measured and kind. "Your feelings are completely valid. The confusion, the hope, the fear… it's a lot to hold. It sounds like Catra *is* opening a door, just a crack. But it's a door *she* controls. Trying to kick it down…"

"Would be classic Adora," Glimmer finished, not unkindly, but bluntly. "Look, I love you. And I love Finn. And… okay, fine, I have a soft spot for that prickly furball, even if I want to shake her sometimes."

She sighed.

"But Bow's right. She's confused. She's hurt. She's proud. You hurt her, badly, for a long time. Showing up now with grand gestures and desperate pleas? That might feel like pressure, not sincerity. It might feel like you only want her back because *you're* miserable now, not because you truly understand what went wrong."

Adora flinched. Glimmer's words, though harsh, echoed her own deepest fears. "So… what do I do? Just… wait? Hope she texts me like she said she might? What if she doesn't?"

"Be patient," Bow urged. "Show her, consistently, that you respect the space she needs, but also that you're *present* for the opportunities she offers, like the family nights. Be reliable for *Finn*. Show her through your actions, not just big promises, that you're changing. That you're prioritizing differently."

"And stars," Glimmer added, "if she *does* reach out to talk? Don't immediately launch into 'I love you, please come home!' Listen. Actually *listen*. Hear her confusion, her hurt, her fears. Validate them. Don't just wait for your turn to talk."

Adora absorbed their words, watching Finn now perched high in the oak, ears perked forward alertly as they surveyed their leafy kingdom.

"It's so hard," she whispered, her voice cracking on the words. She swiped hastily at a tear that escaped before it could fall. "Seeing her so unhappy… knowing I caused it… knowing Finn's hurting too… I just want to fix it."

"You can't fix it overnight, Adora," Bow said softly. "You broke trust over *years*. Rebuilding that takes time and consistent effort. Focus on being the person she *can* learn to trust again, one small step at a time. Even if 'trust' just means reliable co-parenting and maybe, eventually, friendship."

"What he said," Glimmer chimed in. "Just… be careful with your heart, Adora. And Finn's."

"Mama! Look how high I am!" Finn's voice rang out, pulling Adora's attention fully back.

"Wow, space ranger! Be careful!" Adora called back, her voice automatically shifting to its warm, maternal tone. "Hey, buddy, want to say hi to Auntie Glimmer and Uncle Bow?"

Finn’s eyes lit up. "Yeah!" They scrambled down the tree with impressive speed, claws providing sure purchase on the bark, landing lightly on the grass with a soft thump and bounding over to Adora. She held out the phone.

"Hi Auntie Sparkles! Hi Uncle Bow!" Finn chirped, grabbing the phone.

"I climbed super high! Higher than the spaceship in BlipBase! And I saw a bird’s nest! And I pretended the branches were laser beams I had to dodge! And Mama made spaghetti last night and Mom came over and we watched a movie and Mom FELL ASLEEP!"

Finn delivered the last part with dramatic relish, their ears twitching with excitement.

Adora smiled, listening to Glimmer and Bow’s enthusiastic responses–Glimmer’s exaggerated gasps, Bow’s warm praise and questions about the bird’s nest and laser beams.

They adored Finn, their roles as "Auntie Sparkles" and "Uncle Bow" worn with genuine love and delight.

They listened, enraptured, as Finn launched into a detailed description of their latest BlipBase colony expansion, their tail swishing animatedly as they talked.

After a few minutes of Finn’s happy chatter, Adora gently intervened. "Okay, space explorer, time to let Auntie Glimmer and Uncle Bow go. Say goodbye!"

"Bye! Love you!" Finn called, handing the phone back.

"We love you too, Finn!" Glimmer and Bow chorused.

"Thanks, guys," Adora said, her voice thick with gratitude. "Really. I needed that."

"Anytime, Adora," Bow said warmly. "We’re always here."

"Just… remember the listening part," Glimmer added, her tone softer now.

"I will. Bye." She ended the call, the glass of the phone's screen warm against her ear. She let her hands fall into her lap, the tension in her shoulders easing a fraction as she took a deep breath of the park air, scented with grass and damp earth.

Finn was already eyeing another particularly interesting-looking tree.

"Did you have fun up there, Finny?" Adora asked, ruffling their hair.

"It was AWESOME!" Finn beamed. "I'm the best tree climber in the whole galaxy!"

"You sure are, buddy," Adora smiled, her heart lighter after talking to her friends, even if the path ahead remained terrifyingly uncertain.

The quiet of Catra's apartment felt different that afternoon.

Not just empty, but charged with the residual energy of the week's emotional earthquakes. She paced the small living area, tail twitching, before finally grabbing her phone.

She needed voices other than the accusing ones in her head. She video-called Scorpia and Perfuma.

Scorpia's cheerful face filled the screen instantly, her large frame seeming to take up the whole display. "Wildcat! Hey! How's it— Whoa." Her smile vanished, replaced by open concern, her dark eyes softening. "You look tired. Rough week?"

Perfuma appeared beside her, serene but concerned, a potted peace lily visible behind her. She leaned closer to the screen, her warm hazel eyes studying Catra's face with gentle intensity.

Catra managed a weak smile. "Understatement, Scorp." She collapsed onto her couch, pulling her knees up. "It's been… a lot."

She launched into the story, her words tumbling out: Adora's palpable misery at the exchange, the startling vulnerability when Catra asked how she was, Finn's devastating meltdown and the raw guilt it unleashed, the excruciating tension and unexpected warmth of the family night.

She described the careful dinner, the shared glances over Finn's antics during the movie, the dangerous comfort of the familiar couch and blanket.

"And then… I fell asleep," she confessed, her cheeks warming slightly. "Just… completely conked out. Finn was purring… and I think… I was too."

Scorpia's pincers flew to her cheeks, her eyes wider than Catra thought possible. "Oh! Oh, Catra! That's… huge! That's like, ultimate comfort! See? Your subconscious knows where home is!" She turned to Perfuma, practically shaking her by the shoulder. "Isn't that huge?!"

Perfuma placed a steadying, calming hand on Scorpia's arm, but her own small smile was genuine. "It sounds like it was a deeply emotional experience for everyone, Catra. Exhausting, overwhelming, but also… perhaps containing moments of genuine connection?"

"Yeah," Catra admitted quietly. "It was. It did. Then… after tucking Finn in…"

She recounted the conversation in the hallway. Adora's gratitude, her own admission that it wasn't bad and that she missed the laughter. Adora's direct, painful question:

Is this working? Are you happy?

"And I… I told her I didn’t know. That I felt confused." Saying it aloud to them made it feel more real, more terrifying.

"And then… she said she wanted to be in my life. As much as I’d let her."

Catra’s voice dropped to a whisper. "She looked… wrecked, Scorp. But sincere."

Scorpia was practically vibrating, her pincers clasped together under her chin. "This is it! The grand reunion! We should plan—"

"Catra," Perfuma interjected gently, her voice like cool water on Scorpia’s enthusiasm. She gave Scorpia’s arm a final pat before turning her full attention back to the screen. "Confusion is understandable. You’ve been through immense pain and made a huge life change. It’s okay not to have all the answers yet. What’s coming up for you now?"

Catra hugged her knees tighter. "I’m scared," she admitted, the words feeling alien but necessary. "I thought… when I left, I thought it would be like pulling off a bandaid."

She paused, frowning at the strange human metaphor she’d picked up from Adora ages ago. That sticky little strip they put on their skin. “You know, that human thing? Sharp pain, then it’s over. I thought I’d be on the other side, building my new life.”

She looked around her sparse apartment, the makeshift workspace visible in the background.

"But this ‘new life’… it’s miserable. Quiet. Lonely. Desperate. I feel like I’m aging faster. My body hurts all the time from that stupid job. I feel…"

She gestured vaguely at herself. "…softer. Sharper. Less… desirable. Stuck in a dead end. Does that… make me shallow?"

The question burst out, laced with shame. "For wanting the comfort back? The security? The *life* I had, even with all its

problems? Am I just weak?"

"Oh, Catra, no!" Scorpia exclaimed, her face crumpling with compassion. She reached a claw out as if she could physically touch the screen. "You are the strongest person I know!"

"Absolutely not," Perfuma affirmed firmly, shaking her head with conviction.

"Acknowledging the reality of your current struggles isn't shallow. Desiring comfort, security, and freedom from chronic stress are fundamental needs. Wanting to return to a life where those needs were met, especially when your current situation feels unsustainable and harmful to your well-being, is deeply understandable. It doesn't negate the reasons you left."

Catra let out a shaky breath she hadn't realized she was holding. Perfuma's validation eased a knot of self-loathing she hadn't fully acknowledged.

"Perfuma's right, Wildcat," Scorpia said, calmer now, though her pincers were still clasped tightly. "It's okay to want the good stuff back. Especially if maybe… the *other* stuff could be fixed?"

Perfuma leaned forward slightly, her expression one of gentle conviction, her fingers steepled. "Catra, perhaps it would help to clarify *why* you want to return, beyond the material comfort? And also, why you *don't*?"

Catra closed her eyes, thinking. "Why… Finn's happiness. Seeing them whole. Not split. And…"

She swallowed. "The hope. The stupid, terrifying hope that maybe… *maybe* things *could* be repaired. That Adora really has changed. That we could have… something good again. Why I *don't*…"

Her pride flared. "My independence. Not wanting to admit I 'failed' on my own. And… fear. Bone-deep fear of being hurt again. Of

giving Finn hope just to crush it worse if it doesn't work. Of… trusting her and being let down."

Perfuma nodded slowly, a thoughtful hum escaping her. "Those are powerful feelings and needs on both sides. Finn's need for wholeness. Your need for security, hope, and safety from hurt. Adora's need for connection and a chance to rebuild trust. The fear… it's protecting a very vulnerable part of you that's been deeply wounded."

"What do I *do*, Perfuma?" Catra asked, her voice small. "How do I even *start* to figure this out?"

Perfuma considered for a long moment, her fingers gently tracing the rim of a ceramic mug.

"Trust was broken. Adora's broken promises caused immense pain. Rebuilding requires small, consistent actions. Could you think of a clear, reasonable request you could make of Adora? Something specific, related to reliability, that would be a first step in demonstrating change? A trial run, perhaps, where you explicitly state your need for impeccability with her word? If she can meet that, consistently, it might begin to rebuild a foundation of trust. If she can't… it provides clarity."

Catra mulled it over. A trial run. Not reconciliation. Not moving back in. Just… testing the waters of Adora's claimed transformation.

"So… like… agreeing to be… friends? With the explicit condition that she *has* to be reliable? That if she flakes, or breaks a promise, even a small one, it's over? And I tell her that?"

"Exactly," Perfuma said softly. "It sets a clear boundary and a clear expectation. It allows you to observe her actions without the pressure of immediate commitment beyond that friendship."

"Start small!" Scorpia burst out, unable to contain herself any longer, her enthusiasm bubbling over again. "Coffee! A walk in the park! Low stakes!"

Catra sighed, the weight of the decision pressing down. It felt terrifying. But Perfuma's framework offered a path through the confusion, a way to protect herself while still exploring the possibility.

"Okay," she said slowly. "Okay. I… I can try that. Maybe. Thanks."

"Anytime, Catra," Perfuma said warmly. "Remember to breathe. We're here to listen, always."

"You've got this, Wildcat!" Scorpia cheered, giving a determined, encouraging pump of her claw. "First step! You're braver than you think!"

Catra managed a genuine, if weary, smile. They said their goodbyes, and the screen went dark.

Silence descended again, but it felt different. Less oppressive, more… focused.

Catra picked up her phone, her thumb hovering over Adora's contact. Her heart hammered against her ribs, a frantic drum solo in the quiet apartment.

Her stomach churned with nerves.

This was it. Jumping off the cliff.

She took a deep, steadying breath, then another.

She started typing, deleting, rephrasing, her ears flat with concentration. Finally, she hit send before she could overthink it anymore.

> Catra: adora. i've been thinking. i'm willing to… try being friends. but i -need- you to be reliable and consistent. i need you to keep your promises. i don't want to say it's a test, but… this is a test. if you can make me feel like i matter, like i'm important, if i can see you working to change, then we'll see what happens. if not, then we'll file the divorce papers. are you willing to try this?

She put the phone down on the coffee table like it was radioactive, then immediately snatched it back up, staring at the screen.

No immediate reply. Of course not. Adora was probably with Finn.

The wait was agony. Every second stretched into an eternity.

Had she been too harsh? Too demanding? Had she just scared Adora off? Or worse, given herself false hope?

She paced, tail lashing, the knot in her stomach tightening. She'd either just taken the first trembling step towards reclaiming some semblance of happiness, or she'd made a catastrophic mistake that would wound everyone, especially Finn, even deeper.

Nearly an hour later, the phone finally buzzed. Catra pounced on it.

> Adora: Sorry, was cooking dinner for Finn. Catra, I'm 100% willing to try. Thank you for telling me what you need. I'm going to do my absolute best to be reliable and consistent. To show you that you're important. Would you be willing to agree to tell me if I start to let you down, if you start to feel unimportant… tell me early, so I can correct?

Catra read it twice.

The immediate acceptance. The gratitude. The acknowledgment of her need. The request for communication… a shared responsibility.

It was… good. Better than she'd dared hope for in that fraught hour of waiting. She typed back, her fingers slightly less shaky this time.

> Catra: i'm willing to do that. how does coffee next weekend sound? we can ask scorp and fuma or sparkles and arrow to babysit.

The reply came faster this time.

> Adora: 👍 That sounds perfect. I'll see you then. And Catra… thanks for reaching out to talk. I can't tell you what it means that you're even giving me a chance to prove that you matter to me.

Catra put the phone down again, this time leaving it on the table. She leaned back against the couch cushions, closing her eyes.

Her heart was still pounding, but the frantic rhythm had eased.

The knot in her stomach hadn't vanished, but it had loosened, replaced by a strange, fluttering mix of trepidation and… something else. Something perilously close to hope.

She took a long, slow breath, then another.

The path ahead was still shrouded in fog. Trust was a fragile seedling, easily crushed. Adora's "absolute best" remained untested. The fear of more hurt was a constant companion.

But she'd done it. She'd taken the step. She'd named her terms. Adora had agreed.

Now, there was nothing to do but wait. Wait, and see if Adora Gray could finally, truly, keep her word.

The silence of the apartment now held the faint, terrifying echo of possibility.

Chapter 8: The Weight of Words, The Lightness of Being

Saturday, 9:00 AM.

Catra sat in her aging sedan, parked a block down from Bright Moon Coffee.

The engine was off, the only sound the rapid thump of her own heart against her ribs and the faint hum of the city waking up.

She stared at the cheerful, slightly kitschy sign through the windshield, hands tightly gripping the steering wheel.

How do I do this? The question looped in her mind.

Walls. Her defenses against Adora were thick, reinforced concrete built over years of disappointment and cemented by a year of enforced distance.

Lowering them felt like stripping naked in a snowstorm—terrifying, exposing, potentially disastrous. Yet, she'd agreed to try.

For Finn. For the fragile, terrifying possibility of… something less painful than this limbo. For herself, maybe.

The "trial basis" felt like walking a tightrope over a chasm.

Scorpia and Perfuma had Finn for a sleepover. The relief of not juggling pick-up logistics was immense, but it also left her feeling untethered.

Finn's excited chatter last night echoed—"*You're getting coffee with Mama?! And I get to have Auntie Scorpia's pancakes?! Best weekend EVER!*"

Catra had stressed, firmly, that coffee didn't mean moving back in or magical fixes, just grown-ups trying to be better friends to take better care of *them*.

Finn had nodded, wide-eyed, but the hope radiating from them was almost tangible. Another weight on Catra’s shoulders.

She checked the time on her phone. 9:07. If she didn’t move now, she’d be late. Late felt like failure before she’d even begun.

Taking a deep, shuddering breath that did nothing to calm the butterflies dive-bombing her stomach, she shoved the car door open and stepped into the crisp morning air.

The scent of roasting beans hit her as she pushed open the coffee shop door.

Her eyes scanned the small space, finding Adora immediately. She was already seated at a small table near the window, two steaming mugs in front of her.

Adora looked up as the bell jingled, her expression shifting from nervous anticipation to… something warm and hopeful that made Catra’s chest tighten.

Adora half-rose, her body telegraphing the instinct to hug before she visibly checked herself, settling for an awkward, overly enthusiastic wave. "Catra! Hey!"

"Hey," Catra managed, her voice sounding rough to her own ears. She walked over, feeling hyper-aware of every step, every glance from other patrons.

She slid into the chair opposite Adora, the worn wood creaking slightly. "You didn't have to get my drink already."

"I know," Adora said quickly, pushing one mug towards her. "Just… plain latte? That’s still…?"

"Yeah," Catra confirmed, wrapping her hands around the warm ceramic. "Thanks." The simple act felt loaded. Acceptance of a small kindness. A crack in the wall.

"Did you want anything to eat?" Adora offered, gesturing towards the pastry case. "Muffin? Croissant?"

Catra shook her head, perhaps a little too sharply. "No. Just… the coffee is fine. Thanks."

Letting Adora buy her drink felt like one thing. A pastry felt like leaning into dependency, a step too far on this fragile new ground.

She needed to maintain some semblance of control, of self-sufficiency, even in the face of Adora's earnest, nervous generosity.

The silence that descended was thick, charged with everything unsaid. Catra focused on the steam rising from her latte, tracing the pattern in the foam with her gaze. Adora fidgeted, tapping her fingers lightly on the table, then folding her hands tightly in her lap.

The air practically vibrated with Adora's desperate need to "do this right," her palpable fear of saying the wrong thing, of scaring Catra back behind her walls.

Catra could feel her own tension coiling, the instinct to deflect, to retreat, to armor up rising.

Finally, Adora cleared her throat. "So… Finn was *so* excited about the sleepover. Apparently, Scorpia promised them pancakes shaped like spaceships?"

The lifeline. Finn. Catra grabbed it with both hands. "Spaceship pancakes are Scorpia's specialty," she said, a flicker of a real smile touching her lips.

"Finn was vibrating when I dropped them off. Talking a mile a minute about showing Auntie Perfuma their new BlipBase strategy."

Adora’s face lit up, the nervousness momentarily eclipsed by genuine amusement. "Oh, I heard about that! They spent an hour explaining it to me yesterday. Very… intricate. Involved a lot of tactical cheese puff placement as decoys."

Catra snorted, a surprised, genuine laugh escaping her. "Cheese puff decoys? That’s new. Last week it was strategically placed raisins representing ‘space mines’."

The shared laughter, born purely of their child’s adorable eccentricity, acted like a pressure valve. The awkwardness didn’t vanish, but it softened, became more manageable.

They fell into a rhythm, trading anecdotes from their respective weeks with Finn—the hilarious misinterpretation of a history lesson, the dramatic meltdown over a lost (and subsequently found) favorite rock, the surprisingly insightful question about constellations asked during a bedtime story.

Talking about Finn was safe territory. It was common ground, a shared language they both spoke fluently and with deep, uncomplicated love. It allowed them to look at each other, to smile, to relax fractionally into their chairs without the constant thrum of underlying pain dominating the space.

The coffee dwindled. The initial wave of Finn-related stories subsided. A comfortable lull settled, less charged than before but still holding potential. Adora took a deep breath, her expression shifting, becoming more serious, more tentative.

"Catra?" she asked softly. "Can I… can I ask you something? A bit more personal?"

Catra’s defenses snapped partially back up. Her ears twitched, her tail stilled against the leg of her chair. She met Adora’s gaze, seeing the earnest worry there, the carefulness.

"You can ask," she said cautiously. "I might not answer."

Adora nodded, accepting the boundary. "How are you… really doing? With… everything? The apartment, the job, the custody split… being on your own?"

Her voice was gentle, devoid of judgment, filled only with a hesitant concern that felt painfully genuine.

Catra looked down at her near-empty mug. The question hung in the air, demanding honesty.

Could she give it? Perfuma's words echoed: *Vulnerability is a risk, but it can also be an invitation*.

She'd agreed to *try*. That meant lowering the wall, brick by terrifying brick. She took a slow breath, gathering her courage.

"I'm…" she started, her voice barely above a whisper.

She forced herself to look up, meeting Adora's worried blue eyes. "I'm not doing very well."

The admission felt like pulling a shard of glass from her chest.

"I was unhappy… I felt alone for so long before I left. And after I left…"

She swallowed hard. "I'm still alone. And my life is harder in a lot of ways. The job…"

She flexed her right hand unconsciously. "It's hell on my body. My eyes ache constantly. My back feels like it's made of stone knots by Friday. And I'm… constantly struggling. Constantly calculating, worrying about every dollar."

She looked away, her cheeks burning slightly with shame. "I feel like I'm drowning some days. Barely keeping my head above water. I'm holding it together for Finn, but…"

She trailed off, the unspoken *'it's exhausting'* hanging heavy in the air.

Adora’s face was a picture of shock and dawning, profound sadness. Catra could see the immediate response forming—the urge to fix, to rescue, to offer solutions, probably starting with *‘Move back in, let me take care of it!’*

Adora visibly wrestled with it, her jaw tightening, her hands clenching briefly on the table before relaxing. She remembered. *Listen. Don’t solve.*

She took a slow breath of her own.

"Catra…" Adora’s voice was thick with emotion. "Thank you. For trusting me with all of that."

She leaned forward slightly, her gaze intense and sincere. "I… I hate to hear that you’re still hurting. That things are so hard. You deserve…" She paused, searching for the right words.

"You deserve an easier, more fulfilling life. Especially after everything you’ve been through. You deserve peace. Security. Comfort."

The words weren’t pity. They were an acknowledgment, a validation of Catra’s struggle that resonated deep within her wounded pride.

Catra blinked rapidly, fighting the sudden, unexpected sting of tears. She hadn’t realized how much she’d needed someone, especially Adora, to simply *hear* her pain without judgment or immediate solutions.

"Thanks," she managed, her voice rough. "For… listening."

She took a shaky sip of the dregs of her coffee, using the moment to compose herself.

The wall felt lower now, the space between them less guarded. "What about you, Adora?" she asked, the question feeling less like an obligation and more like a genuine reciprocation.

"How are *you* really doing? I know me leaving… came as a surprise. It can't… have been easy."

She braced herself, knowing Adora's pain was inextricably linked to her own choices.

Adora took a deep, steadying breath, her gaze fixed on her own hands. Honesty. She owed Catra that much.

"I've been struggling, Catra," she admitted, her voice low and heavy. "You leaving *was* a shock. A massive one. I honestly thought… everything was perfect. Which," she added with a bitter twist of her lips, "was obviously a huge part of the problem."

She looked up, meeting Catra's gaze directly, her blue eyes filled with raw regret.

"Sometimes… I wish you could've told me how bad things were while there was still time to repair. But I understand," she said quickly, seeing Catra tense, "I *understand* that you *had* been trying. The sharpness, the sarcasm, the cold shoulders… that was you trying. And I didn't hear it. I understand that leaving felt like the only way to make me *finally* wake up and understand you weren't happy. That things *needed* to change."

She paused, the weight of her own realizations pressing down.

"I've had to sit with… a lot of hard truths. When I had Finn at home alone, I *couldn't* have those late nights anymore. I couldn't justify it. So I talked to Hope."

A flicker of something painful crossed her face.

"She was so understanding. Just… immediately. *'Family comes first, Adora. We'll make it work.'* It was *so easy*. And it hit me… it would have been that easy *any* time. For *years*. But I didn't do it."

Her voice cracked. "I didn't do it until it was for Finn's needs. Of course we both prioritize Finn! But…"

She shook her head, her expression one of utter self-loathing. "… why weren't your needs? Your hurt? Your loneliness? Why weren't they reason enough for me to change? Why wasn't your *happiness* reason enough?"

Tears welled in her eyes, spilling over despite her efforts to blink them back. "I… I hate myself some days, Catra. I really do. I'll never be able to forgive myself for the ways I failed you. Your love…"

Her voice broke completely. "…your love was the most precious thing in my universe. My anchor. My home. And I… I absolutely failed to value it. Failed to protect it. I took it for granted until it was gone."

She swiped angrily at her tears.

"Every day, I have this urge… this desperate need… to make some grand gesture, some huge, heartfelt promise, to try and repair the trust I shattered. To beg you to come home. But I know…"

She took a shuddering breath, forcing herself to meet Catra's stunned gaze again. "…I *know* that's not what you need from me right now. That's not how trust gets rebuilt. And living in that house…"

She gestured vaguely, helplessly. "…it's full of ghosts, Catra. Every room, every corner. Memories of the life we built… the life *I* destroyed with my neglect. I'm holding it together for Finn, just like you said. But inside…I feel like I'm falling apart."

Hearing the raw, unfiltered truth pour out of Adora was like standing in the center of an emotional earthquake.

Vindication surged first—sharp and fierce.

Yes. You finally understand the depth of the hurt. You finally feel the consequence.

It was the validation she'd craved but hadn't dared hope for in such magnitude.

Then came relief, profound and dizzying. Relief that Adora *had* sat with the pain, had truly reflected, had seen the failures not just intellectually but *felt* them in her soul.

She'd grasped the core wound: that Catra's needs hadn't been reason enough.

But then, cutting through the vindication and relief, came a wave of pure grief.

Seeing the woman she had loved so fiercely, the strong, vibrant Adora, reduced to this raw, self-loathing wreck, confessing she hated herself… it was agonizing.

The image of Adora alone in their echoing house, surrounded by the ghosts of their happiness and her own perceived failure, was heartbreaking.

The urge to comfort, to absolve, was almost overwhelming.

Slowly, hesitantly, moving as if through deep water, Catra reached her hand across the small table. Her fingers brushed the back of Adora's clenched fist, then settled gently over it.

Adora's head snapped up, her tear-filled eyes wide with shock, searching Catra's face.

"Adora…" Catra's voice was thick with her own unshed tears. "I wish… I wish I'd been able to tell you how much I was hurting earlier, too. I *tried*. But I couldn't get you to *listen*. I couldn't get you to pay enough attention to me… to really *see* me… to see how much I was hurting."

She squeezed Adora's hand lightly, needing the physical anchor as much as offering one.

"I didn’t *want* to leave. That day…" Her gaze drifted, seeing the memory.

"…when I said I needed to talk? I wasn’t planning on leaving. I was going to tell you… finally, clearly… that I felt ignored. Unimportant. Unwanted. That unless things changed… *really* changed… I was going to have to consider getting divorced. It was my final effort. The last bit of trust I had for you."

She looked back at Adora, seeing the pain and remorse etched deep.

"…And I was too absorbed in work to give you the opportunity to tell me." Adora closed her eyes, a fresh wave of tears escaping. "I remember," she whispered hoarsely. "'*Just give me five minutes.'* Thirty minutes later…"

"…And I was so angry, so hurt, I could barely see straight," Catra finished.

"Even small promises like that… broken over and over… they eroded my trust in you, brick by brick. They eroded my belief that you *cared*. That my time, my feelings, mattered to you. The big things—like missing date nights—were glaring. But it was the small ones, the ones that felt too 'petty' to get upset about, that did the real damage."

She sighed, the old frustration mixing with new understanding.

"Each one seemed too small a thing to get so upset about. But… I *needed* to be able to believe my wife’s words. I couldn’t play 4D chess every time you told me something would happen. Was 'home by seven' optimistic? Realistic? A complete fantasy? I never knew. I couldn’t plan *anything* for myself because I was perpetually waiting, suspended, hoping you’d show up when you said you would."

Adora’s brow furrowed as the pieces clicked together with devastating clarity.

"It wasn't just the big things… It was *every* time my actions didn't match my words. No matter how small. Because I'd make the promise based on an optimistic view… because I *wanted* to make it home, I *wanted* to be there for dinner… I didn't want to disappoint you by saying *'maybe'* or *'later'.* But those optimistic promises… they just hurt you more. They eroded the foundation."

"Exactly," Catra affirmed, a weight lifting slightly from being understood on this fundamental level.

"I *was* upset about the long hours. I *did* want you to scale back, make us more of a priority. But… I would've understood. Truly. If you'd just told me upfront, *'Catra, I've got a deadline, I'll be answering emails until nine tonight,'* or *'Something came up, I won't make dinner, eat without me.'* Being strung along… *that* hurt infinitely worse. It felt disrespectful. Like my time, my presence, wasn't valuable enough for honesty."

Adora pictured it—the endless evenings waiting, the frustration mounting, the resentment festering.

Catra continued, "If I waited patiently, assuming it really *would* be five minutes… I'd just get more and more hurt as time stretched. Eventually, I might pick up a book, something I could put down easily. Or… if I assumed 'five minutes' really meant 'an hour, at least,' I might start something I could get engrossed in. And then…"

She gave a wry, humorless smile.

"…I'd feel irritated and resentful when you showed up only fifteen minutes late, all enthusiastic, having 'only' broken your promise by a little. And you'd be confused, hurt by my sharpness, my cold shoulder… thinking my reaction was disproportionate. Because you hadn't seen the buildup. You hadn't seen the erosion."

Adora's shoulders slumped, the understanding crashing over her in a cold wave.

She saw it now—the toxic cycle in perfect, painful clarity. Her optimistic promises born of love and a desire to please, morphing into weapons of neglect through their unreliability.

Catra's reactions, seeming disproportionate in isolation, were actually the inevitable explosion after sustained, low-level pressure.

The sheer weight of it pressed the air from her lungs.

She finally, truly, grasped the lived experience Catra had endured.

They sat in silence then, a profound, bittersweet quiet settling over them. The air wasn't thick with tension anymore, but with a strange, calm exhaustion.

The raw honesty hung between them, painful but purifying. There was a new, fragile lightness in Catra's chest—the lightness of finally being *heard*, truly understood, by the person whose understanding mattered most. And for Adora, a different kind of relief: the profound, painful validation that Catra *knew*. Knew that she saw what had happened, knew that she had received the message, knew that she had changed, even if it was too late.

A touch of pride, too, humbling but real. They were here. They'd navigated this minefield of pain and history with a level of honesty and vulnerability they hadn't been capable of at 25, or even 35.

They'd approached it like the weary, wounded, but determined adults they'd become.

They'd shown that they could rely on each other, in this moment, to be present, to be *trying*, to be… mature.

Catra's hand still rested comfortably on Adora's. Neither moved to pull away. The contact was warm, grounding, a tangible thread connecting them across the chasm of the past year.

They sat in their own quiet contemplations, processing the emotional avalanche they'd just survived together.

The coffee shop bustle faded to a distant hum.

Then, a moment.

Catra looked up. Adora's gaze, still red-rimmed but clearer now, met hers. A silent communication passed between them, profound and wordless. A shared awareness of the significance of *this* moment.

The first time, perhaps since before Finn, maybe even longer, that they had truly *seen* each other, listened without defensiveness, spoken without armor.

A fragile bridge, painstakingly built over the wreckage.

Finally, the moment passed. Catra gently withdrew her hand, the warmth lingering on her skin. "I… I should probably get going," she said, her voice husky but calm.

"Scorpia and Perfuma are dropping space ranger off at my place soon. Gotta prep for the invasion."

Adora nodded, wiping her eyes with the back of her hand, managing a small, genuine smile. "Right. Invasion prep is crucial."

She gathered her own things. "Catra…" She met Catra's gaze again, her expression sincere but not overblown, respecting the delicate space they'd created.

"Thank you. For… being here. For talking. For…" She gestured vaguely, encompassing the raw, difficult, necessary conversation. "…For that."

"Thank you too, Adora," Catra replied, standing. "For… listening."

They walked out of the coffee shop together, the morning sun warmer now.

A brief, awkward pause on the sidewalk, then a simple, mutual nod.

"See you tonight," Adora said.

"See you tonight," Catra echoed.

Catra got into her car, started the engine. As she pulled away from the curb, a wave of sensation washed over her.

Her body felt… light. Unburdened. The constant, grinding tension in her shoulders, her jaw, seemed to have loosened.

The oppressive weight that had sat on her chest for over a year felt… shifted.

Not gone, but lighter. Manageable. It was the closest thing to peace she'd felt since long before she walked out the door of their house.

She took a deep, clear breath, the air filling lungs that suddenly felt less constricted.

She drove home, the sunlight feeling warmer, the city seeming less grey, carrying the fragile, terrifying, exhilarating lightness of being truly heard.

Adora watched Catra's car disappear around the corner.

She stood on the sidewalk for a long moment, the sounds of the city filtering back in.

She took a deep breath, filling her lungs fully, deeply.

The sensation was startling.

The aching, caved-in feeling in her chest—the constant companion of the past year, the physical manifestation of grief, guilt, and self-loathing—was gone.

In its place was a warm, open expanse.

Not euphoria, not triumph, but a profound, quiet relief. A lightness. A sense of… spaciousness.

She hadn't fixed anything. The future was still terrifyingly uncertain. Catra hadn't promised anything beyond a coffee and a trial friendship.

But the suffocating pressure, the feeling of drowning in her own failure, had lifted. She had finally, truly, *said* it.

The depth of her remorse, the understanding of her failures, the self-hatred, the ghosts in the house. She'd laid it bare, without defensiveness, without excuses.

And Catra had listened. She'd *heard*. She'd understood. She'd even… touched her hand.

Adora felt a surge of energy, clean and bright, coursing through her. It wasn't the frantic, anxious energy of desperation. It was the pure, powerful energy of release.

She felt like she could run—not away, but *towards* something. Towards the possibility, however slim, of building something new from the ashes.

She had shown up. She had listened. She had spoken her truth. And Catra hadn't run. She'd stayed. She'd shared her own truth.

Adora turned and started walking back towards her car, her steps lighter, her posture straighter.

The ghosts were still in the house, the memories still bittersweet. But they didn't feel like accusations anymore.

They felt like lessons.

The caved-in feeling was replaced by an open space, ready to be filled with whatever came next—cautious friendship, painful

distance, or, just maybe, the slow, careful reconstruction of trust.

For the first time in a year, Adora Gray felt a flicker of something that wasn’t despair.

It felt like hope, fragile and hard-won, warming the newly open space within her.

She got into her car, the engine purring to life, mirroring the quiet hum of potential now resonating deep inside her.

Chapter 9: Shifting Foundations and Awakened Sparks

Chapter Notes

>:)

Also, there will be a special Thursday upload tomorrow of my very important short story "Glimmer Eats a Bug".

The air in Adora’s living room that evening hummed with a new, unfamiliar frequency.

Another family night, the second since their fragile truce, felt different. Gone was the performance of forced cheer; in its place was a shared, bone-deep exhaustion from the morning’s raw vulnerability and a tacit agreement: tonight was sanctuary, for Finn and for themselves. A ceasefire in the emotional war.

The familiar rituals unfolded—Finn chattering excitedly about their week, their tail swishing contentedly against the couch cushions, the comforting aroma of Adora’s simple but tasty pasta bake filling the air, the claiming of pillows and blankets on the couch.

Yet, the undercurrent of dread and awkwardness Adora braced for, the careful dance around Catra’s walls, was absent.

Throughout the meal, they passed dishes with unthinking coordination, their hands brushing once over the bread basket. Adora didn’t flinch back; Catra didn’t tense up. It was simple.

Finn, perched between them on the couch as the animated film began, vibrated with their usual infectious energy.

But tonight, Adora noticed something different in their bright blue eyes, in the relaxed way they leaned back against both her and Catra, their ears angled comfortably towards the screen.

It wasn’t just excitement; it was a quiet contentment, an unspoken *knowing*. Finn sensed the shift. The brittle tension that usually crackled between their moms was softened, replaced by a weary but genuine calm.

For once, the hope shining in Finn’s eyes didn’t trigger Adora’s fear of inevitable disappointment. Instead, it felt like a quiet affirmation.

This is better. This is right.

Laughter came easier, sparked by Finn’s antics or a silly moment in the film, not forced but genuine bubbles of shared amusement that momentarily dissolved the lingering shadows.

Catra stayed awake this time, her gaze fixed on the screen, her posture less rigid than usual but still holding a deliberate distance.

The vulnerability quota for the day had been utterly exhausted over coffee; further intimacy was off the table.

Yet, the space felt safe. Accepted.

Halfway through the movie, as a particularly heartwarming scene unfolded, Finn wriggled. They grabbed Catra’s arm, draping it over their small shoulders, then leaned back against Adora’s side, their fluffy tail curling loosely around Adora's wrist.

Instinctively, both women adjusted, their arms encircling Finn, creating a warm, protective cocoon. Adora’s hand rested lightly on Finn’s stomach, Catra’s on their arm.

The backs of their hands rested mere centimeters apart on Finn’s small frame, a whisper of proximity charged with the unspoken history and the fragile new understanding forged hours before.

Neither moved away. The contact, mediated by their child, felt grounding, not threatening.

When the credits rolled, Catra gently extricated herself. "Okay, space ranger, time to blast off home. You've got that diorama project for history to work on tomorrow; you'll need a good night's sleep for your brain to be firing on all thrusters."

Finn protested sleepily, a soft, drowsy rumble starting in their chest, but didn't fight as Catra helped them gather their things—the well-loved blanket, the half-finished comic book.

Adora rose too. "Let me help Finn to the car." She scooped the drowsy child into her arms, Finn immediately burying their face in her neck with a sleepy murmur, their warm breath puffing against her skin.

Catra gathered her purse and jacket, a flicker of something unreadable in her eyes as she watched Adora carry their child with such easy familiarity.

The walk to the car was quiet, the cool night air sharp against their faces. Adora carefully buckled Finn into the backseat of Catra's car, tucking the blanket around them.

Standing back up, she met Catra's gaze over the roof of the car. The goodbye still held a familiar sting—the parting, the return to separate lives, the echo of the empty house waiting for Adora.

But tonight, the sting was different. Sharper, perhaps, because of the fragile connection reforged, but less deep, less suffocating.

It was the ache of a healing wound, not the agony of a fresh amputation.

"Drive safe," Adora murmured.

"Thanks," Catra replied, her voice low. "See you next week."

Adora nodded, watching Catra slide into the driver's seat. The taillights disappeared down the street, leaving Adora standing alone in the driveway.

The silence of the house beckoned, still holding its ghosts, but their whispers felt less accusatory tonight. She went inside, the familiar emptiness settling around her.

Instead of collapsing onto the couch to drown in it, she busied herself. She cleaned the kitchen with focused efficiency, the rhythmic scrubbing a physical counterpoint to the emotional whirlwind of the day.

Then, she descended to the home gym.

The punishing workout wasn't driven by self-loathing tonight, but by a need to burn off the residual emotional energy, to clear her head, to honor the physicality that grounded her.

She pushed herself until her muscles burned and sweat plastered her hair to her neck, emerging feeling physically spent but mentally clearer.

The ghosts felt quieter, the open space in her chest warmed by the memory of shared laughter, Finn’s trusting weight in her arms, and the soft vibration of their drowsy purr.

Driving home, Catra navigated the familiar streets with a sense of profound relief.

The ease of the evening still resonated. It hadn’t been perfect—the undercurrent of their history was always there—but the absence of that crushing tension, the ability to simply *be* with Adora without the constant performance, was a revelation.

It felt… normal. Or as close to normal as it could be now.

She carried the sleeping Finn into her small apartment, their soft purrs vibrating against her chest.

Tucking them into the narrow bed in the second bedroom, she paused, smoothing the covers.

The sight struck her with sudden, sharp clarity: the small room, the unfamiliar walls, the faint smell of the building's generic cleaning products.

This wasn't Finn's room. This wasn't Finn's *home*.

The cozy chaos of their room in Adora's house, filled with familiar toys, drawings pinned to the walls Adora painted, the scent of their shared life… that was Finn's home.

This was a waystation. A necessary, painful pause.

Catra sat on the edge of Finn's bed for a moment, watching their peaceful face, their ears relaxed in sleep.

She still needed time. She needed Adora to prove, consistently and over the long term, that this change wasn't just a desperate reaction to losing her, but a fundamental shift.

She needed to see that reliability embedded in Adora's bones before she could even *consider* the terrifying prospect of reconciliation.

But quietly, deep within her heart, she acknowledged the truth whispering beneath her pride and fear: this apartment, this life of data entry drudgery and financial strain, wasn't her future. It wasn't Finn's future.

It had been an escape hatch, a desperately needed time-out from a relationship that was suffocating her.

But it wasn't a life she wanted to build permanently.

I just have to be patient, she thought, rising from the bed and quietly closing the door.

There's no sense getting my hopes up. Adora could start flaking out again any day. I can't get hurt again.

The old mantra was familiar, a worn shield against vulnerability.

She walked into her small living room, the silence pressing in.

The evening stretched before her, a blank canvas she didn't quite know how to fill.

Days turned into weeks.

The fragile bridge held. Adora was… different.

Attentive without being smothering. Reliable in a way that felt revolutionary. Crucially, she stopped over-promising.

She managed expectations and communicated proactively. And when a potential conflict arose, she handled it not with the old, optimistic vagueness, but with a new, bracing clarity.

The first real test of this new approach came on a Tuesday evening.

Catra had actually been looking forward to it—a simple dinner out, just the two of them, a chance to talk without Finn's constant, wonderful energy as a buffer.

Finn was already safely ensconced at Bow and Glimmer's for a slumber party. Catra was deciding what to wear (something simple, but *nice*) when her phone rang.

Adora's name flashed on the screen.

"Catra?" Adora's voice held an immediate note of apology.

"I just got a call from the city planning office. There's a problem with the Bright Moon Plaza permit—a missing signature page, apparently filed wrong months ago. It needs to be resubmitted *tonight* before the midnight deadline or the whole project timeline gets pushed back months. I still have a few hours to try to pull the documents together and get it filed, but…"

She took a breath. "Realistically, I probably won't be able to make it to dinner tonight. I'm so sorry."

Catra froze.

A familiar cold wave of disappointment, edged with the sharp sting of old betrayal, washed over her. The feeling of being sidelined, her time deemed less important.

But she stopped. Took a breath.

She called. Early. She told me the reality. She didn't say 'be ready in an hour' or 'I'll try.'

"Okay," Catra said, her voice surprisingly steady. "Obviously, I'm a little disappointed. I was looking forward to it."

She paused, making a conscious choice. "But Adora…Thank you for telling me as early as you possibly could, and for being honest. I understand that last-minute things come up with your job sometimes."

She emphasized the understanding, recalling her own words from their coffee conversation.

The relief on the other end of the line was almost audible. "Oh, Catra, thank you. Thank you for understanding and being flexible. I was *so* gutted when I realized. Truly."

Adora hesitated. "If… by some miracle I get this wrapped up super fast, do you want me to swing by and pick you up? Or should we just reschedule for another night?"

Catra considered.

The old Catra, the one starved for connection and terrified of losing any scrap of Adora's attention, might have agreed to wait indefinitely, phone clutched in hand, plans perpetually on hold.

But now… She thought about what *she* needed. A quiet evening. No waiting. No contingency plans hanging over her head.

"Let's just do another night," Catra said decisively. "Finn's already with Bow and Glimmer, so I'll just… have a quiet evening to myself. It's fine."

Saying it felt empowering. Setting a boundary based on her own needs, not Adora's schedule.

"Okay," Adora agreed readily. "We'll definitely plan on it another night. I'm really sorry about this. Especially after you went to the trouble of getting Finn settled for the night. It feels… disrespectful of your time."

Catra blinked. The validation landed softly, warmly. Adora wasn't just apologizing; she was acknowledging the specific impact, the effort Catra had made.

It felt… good. Remarkably good.

"It's not ideal," Catra conceded, finding herself able to be honest without sharpness, "but things come up."

She paused, then decided to offer explicit reassurance, a new step for her. "I'm not feeling unimportant, Adora. Good luck with the permit thing."

"Thanks," Adora breathed, the gratitude palpable. "Have a good evening, Catra."

Hanging up, Catra stood in the quiet of her apartment.

The disappointment lingered, a dull ache, but it wasn't the crushing despair or seething resentment of the past. It was manageable. Normal, even.

And beneath it… a flicker of surprise. She *had* genuinely been looking forward to dinner.

The desire for Adora's company, separate from Finn, was reawakening.

Needing air, needing movement, she grabbed a novel she'd been meaning to read and headed out.

The late afternoon sun was golden, slanting through trees ablaze with autumn fire. Reds, golds, and oranges painted the world.

The crisp air filled her lungs, carrying the rich, earthy scent of fallen leaves.

The satisfying crunch and rustle beneath her boots was a grounding rhythm.

She walked to the nearby park, smaller and less familiar than the one near their old house, but peaceful. She found an empty bench under a maple tree, its leaves raining down around her like embers, and opened her book.

But her mind kept drifting back to the phone call.

The ease of Adora's communication. Her own calm response. The lack of resentment. The simple act of rescheduling felt like reclaiming agency.

She hadn't bent herself into a pretzel trying to salvage the unsalvageable. Adora had understood and respected her pivot.

The sun dipped lower, casting long, dramatic shadows, painting the world in deepening gold.

Catra made her way back to the apartment as twilight settled, the walk a quiet meditation.

Back inside, she made a quick dinner, cleaned up, and finally sank onto the couch.

The silence felt different tonight—not oppressive, but spacious. She felt… restless. Energized in a quiet way, but unsure how to

channel it.

A glass of wine would have been perfect, but she didn’t have any.

A movie? Too much focus. Drawing? Her mind felt too scattered.

Finally, she grabbed her phone and a pair of headphones. Scrolling through her music library, she selected an album—something atmospheric, instrumental, without lyrics to demand attention.

She settled back, closed her eyes, and let the sound wash over her, a current to carry her drifting thoughts.

The music wove its spell.

Thoughts drifted, untethered: the golden leaves, the scent of earth, the taste of Adora's pasta bake, the look on Finn’s face as they drifted to sleep. Then, images flickering behind her closed eyelids shifted, unguided, unbidden. Sunlight on blonde hair. A familiar, crooked smile. The curve of a strong shoulder.

Then, sharper: a pair of stormy blue eyes, intense and unwavering, gazing at her not with polite distance, but with raw, unrestrained *want*.

The image solidified behind her eyelids, pulling a soft gasp from Catra’s lips. Her breath hitched.

The fantasy deepened, vivid and startling. A sultry whisper, Adora’s voice, thick with praise, breathed against her ear. The sensation of strong, familiar hands gripping her hips, holding her firmly.

The feeling of being spread open, vulnerable, yet utterly safe.

The soft, slick friction of a human tongue, worshipping her with single-minded devotion, chasing a pleasure only Adora had ever known how to give her so completely.

The imagined sensation was so acute, so *real*, that Catra's claws reflexively flexed, picturing them tangled in silky blonde hair, pulling Adora closer, demanding more.

Her own hand, seemingly of its own accord, drifted down her belly, fingertips brushing the waistband of her jeans. Heat pooled low and insistent within her.

A low throb echoed the rhythm of the music in her ears.

Catra's eyes snapped open.

She fumbled for her phone, pausing the music abruptly.

The sudden silence roared. Her heart hammered against her ribs, a frantic drumbeat in the quiet room.

What was that?

She stared at the ceiling, breath coming in short gasps. Her entire body felt electrified, her tawny fur slightly fluffed up along her arms and the back of her neck. Her skin felt too tight, hypersensitive. She hadn't thought of Adora like that—with raw, visceral *desire*—in… god. Not since before she'd left.

But even in the years *before* the separation, she'd largely closed that part of herself off. It had been safer. Less vulnerable. Less disappointing. To not *want* meant she couldn't be denied.

But the memory flooded back now, unstoppable. The intensity of Adora's focus when they were younger, that burning gaze that could strip her bare and make her feel like the most precious, desired creature in the universe.

Adora chasing her pleasure with relentless, joyful determination, leaving her trembling, breathless, tears of overwhelming sensation streaming down her face.

Crying Adora's name until her voice was raw. The sheer, unadulterated *worship* in those moments.

Things had changed with Finn, of course. The frantic passion of their twenties gave way to stolen moments, quieter expressions of care. But for a while, the connection remained strong.

Adora always ready to drop to her knees if they found fifteen spare minutes, her touch still conveying a deep, matter-of-fact adoration that had been more than enough.

Even without grand romance, the consistent physical affirmation had anchored Catra.

Until it dwindled.

By the time Finn was four or five, Adora's career consumed more and more. Even the stolen moments became rare. In the last few years before the split… maybe two, three times total.

And even then, it felt performative. Watching herself plummet down Adora's list of priorities had been a different kind of heartbreak, a silent erosion of her sense of desirability.

But the focused attention Adora had been giving her *recently*… It reminded her of the early days. The intensity, the presence, tempered now by age, by the hard-won wisdom of their failures.

Younger Adora had been prone to overwhelming grand gestures that sometimes made Catra feel cornered, wanting to retreat into her shell.

This Adora? She showed up in small, consistent ways. She listened—truly listened—not to formulate a response, but to *understand*. She was open about her own struggles, her own failures, not hiding behind a facade of perfection.

She was trying. *Really* trying.

Catra's heart pounded, a frantic echo in the silent room.

What did it *mean* if she let herself follow this image, this visceral, unexpected fantasy? If she let herself *want* Adora again? Not just

as a co-parent, not just as a tentative friend, but as a lover?

The vulnerability was terrifying. To open that door again was to risk a devastation far greater than before.

She swallowed hard, the sound loud in the stillness. Her body thrummed with the phantom sensations, the remembered heat.

The ache between her thighs was undeniable, a physical demand echoing the mental image.

A war waged inside her for a long moment. Then, a reckless, defiant need rose, drowning out the fear. She would not analyze it. Not tonight.

She pressed play on her phone. The atmospheric music swelled again, filling her ears, wrapping around her like a cocoon.

Closing her eyes, she surrendered to the current. The image of stormy blue eyes locked onto hers returned, blazing with that familiar, possessive hunger.

Her hand drifted lower, slipping beneath the waistband of her jeans, fingertips finding the swollen, slick heat of her own flesh through the damp fabric of her underwear.

A soft gasp escaped her lips as she touched herself, the sensation amplified a thousandfold by the fantasy unfolding behind her eyelids—the whisper of praise, the grip on her hips, the relentless, worshipful pressure of Adora’s tongue.

Her back arched slightly off the couch cushions as she let the wave of long-denied desire crash over her, her claws digging into the fabric of the sofa, chasing the phantom touch of the woman she was still, impossibly, learning how to trust again.

Chapter 10: The Unspoken Current

Chapter Summary

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Weeks flowed into a new rhythm, marked less by the harsh, painful separations of custody exchanges and more by the gentle punctuation of shared moments.

Family nights remained sacred, anchoring their weeks.

Weekend morning coffees became cherished rituals, islands of calm conversation amidst the separate storms of their lives.

The occasional dinner or lunch—sometimes just the two of them, sometimes including Bow and Glimmer or Scorpia and Perfuma—added layers of connection.

These weren't grand reconciliations, but quiet acknowledgments:

We are choosing to be in each other's orbit. We are choosing to find joy here, now.

Both Catra and Adora noticed it—the subtle shift in how they navigated their days.

The drudgery of Catra's data entry, the pressures of Adora's architecture firm, the aching loneliness of their separate dwellings... these burdens felt lighter when viewed through the lens of the next shared laugh over Finn's latest BlipBase conquest, the next quiet coffee, the next family movie night.

They found themselves looking forward to, genuinely *anticipating* the next point of connection.

It was a fragile lifeline, but a vital one.

The banter returned, tentative at first, then blooming with surprising ease. One afternoon, after a particularly soul-crushing day of copy-pasting endless strings of numbers, Catra impulsively texted Adora:

'i think my hand's going to fall off if i have to copy/paste one more thing today.'

Adora's reply came swiftly: *'But Catra, the shareholders. They need you.'*

A genuine, unexpected chuckle escaped Catra. *'you're right. i was being selfish.'*

The vulnerability, the effortless lightness of the exchange… it felt precious. Neither took it for granted.

Each shared laugh, each small moment of understanding, was a victory hard-won against the backdrop of their painful history.

Adora, however, began noticing subtle shifts in Catra beyond the easy banter. Moments of tension, a flicker of distraction that seemed deeper than work stress.

Sometimes, during a coffee, Catra's gaze would linger on Adora's face a beat too long, then dart away, her ears giving a minute twitch. Other times, she seemed almost… jumpy.

This became strikingly apparent one Sunday morning. Adora had just finished a grueling home gym session, muscles pumped, skin glistening with sweat, when her phone buzzed.

A text from Catra: *'hey, finn left their history worksheet there. any chance you could drop it by before school tomorrow?'*

Without a second thought, Adora grabbed the worksheet, threw on a clean tank top over her damp sports bra, and hopped in the car.

She arrived at Catra’s apartment building minutes later, the morning sun warm on her skin.

Catra opened the door, already holding out a hand. "Hey, thanks for running this over, Finn needs it for..."

Her words trailed off as her gaze landed fully on Adora.

The sight rooted Catra to the spot.

Adora stood haloed by the morning light, radiating heat. Sweat still beaded on her temples and collarbones. Her arms and shoulders, visible in the tank top, were swollen with exertion, veins tracing powerful lines beneath flushed skin.

But it was the smell that truly unraveled her—the potent, heady musk of Adora after a workout.

It was primal, intoxicating, a scent deeply imprinted in Catra’s memory, tied to moments of exertion, passion, and profound intimacy.

Her tail puffed instantly, a visceral reaction she couldn't control. Heat flooded her core, sudden and intense. It took every ounce of willpower not to surge forward, not to sink her teeth into the curve of Adora’s shoulder, to mark and claim.

Her ears flickered erratically, perking towards Adora then flattening against her head in a mix of desire and panic. Her pupils dilated despite the bright light.

She barely registered Adora handing over the worksheet, her fingers brushing Catra’s, sending an electric jolt up her arm.

She mumbled something—probably incoherent thanks—and closed the door quickly, leaning back against it, heart hammering.

Did she notice? Please, please don’t let her have noticed how flustered I was.

Ever since that solitary night on her couch, the floodgates of her desire had been wrenched open. The carefully constructed dam of resentment and self-protection had sprung leaks.

Now, seemingly innocuous moments became fraught: Adora laughing, sunlight catching her hair; Adora placing a comforting hand over Catra's during a vulnerable conversation; Adora simply *existing* in her space, strong and present.

Her most frequent, startlingly clear thought was a silent, internal plea: *'Please lay me down and fuck me.'*

It was exhilarating and terrifying.

Alongside the desire came a new vulnerability about her own body—the softness gained from a year of stress and sedentary work compared to Adora's sculpted, powerful physique.

Would she even want me anymore?

The doubt gnawed at her, a counterpoint to the thrumming need.

Adora had been impeccable—reliable, trustworthy, consistently showing up. Catra was starting to wonder if her own hesitation was less about Adora's potential to fail and more about her own fear of finally taking the leap.

Finn was visibly happier, thriving in the calmer, more connected atmosphere.

Catra had confessed her renewed *sexual* desire to Scorpia and Perfuma, and while their non-judgmental support was a lifeline, they had been gently nudging her towards honesty ever since.

Adora registered Catra's reaction instantly.

The puff of the tail, the erratic ear movements, the dilated pupils… it was classic flustered Catra.

But *why*?

The nervous tension seemed different. And then there were Catra's eyes—lingering on her arms, her shoulders, her chest… and that subtle, almost imperceptible *sniff*.

Adora knew that look, that reaction. It was the way Catra used to look at her after a game, or sometimes just… because.

The way she'd look when desire sparked.

A jolt of pure, unadulterated hope surged through Adora, so strong it stole her breath. *No. Don't. You're imagining it. Projecting.* She ruthlessly stamped it down.

Glimmer and Bow's warnings echoed: *Stay grounded. Be her friend. Don't get ahead of yourself. Keep expectations low.*

Catra had every reason to be wary, to keep her distance. The last thing Adora wanted was to misread a moment and shatter the fragile trust they'd rebuilt.

So she handed over the worksheet, accepted the mumbled thanks, and left quickly, the image of Catra's wide, dilated eyes and puffed tail burned into her mind, a dangerous ember she refused to fan.

The next family night arrived, the familiar comfort of shared pizza and Finn's chatter setting the stage.

As they settled onto the couch for the movie—Finn already burrowing into their pillow nest on the floor, their fluffy tail curling protectively around their favorite stuffed animal—Catra felt a new kind of nervous anticipation.

She looked at the careful distance she'd maintained between herself and Adora on the cushions.

It suddenly felt… artificial. Unnecessary. Like a relic from a colder time.

Taking a slow, silent breath, heart pounding against her ribs, Catra made a decision.

She shifted, slowly, deliberately, scooting sideways on the couch until her thigh pressed gently against Adora's.

The point of contact was electric.

Adora froze mid-sentence, her breath catching audibly. The warmth of Catra's leg against hers felt like a brand.

She turned her head slowly, eyes wide, searching Catra's face. She saw vulnerability, raw and exposed. She saw uncertainty, the fear of rejection warring with a desperate hope.

She saw Catra actively lowering a barrier, inviting closeness.

Adora's heart hammered against her ribs.

She managed a small, shaky smile, one she hoped conveyed reassurance, acceptance, and a silent promise:

Your pace. I'm here.

She didn't move closer, didn't press. She simply held Catra's gaze for a moment, then turned back to the screen, focusing on Finn's commentary, letting the warmth of Catra's thigh against hers anchor her to the present, miraculous moment.

Adora's deer-in-headlights look sent a fresh wave of nervousness through Catra.

But then came the smile—small, genuine, reassuring. Not pushing, just… accepting. The permission was implicit.

Catra relaxed infinitesimally, letting her body settle against Adora's.

The contact was grounding, comforting, and undeniably charged. As the movie progressed, the familiar warmth of the room, the drone of the film, and Adora's solid presence beside her worked their magic.

The exhaustion of the week, the emotional intensity of the day, the sheer relief of letting her guard down… it all caught up with her. Her eyelids grew heavy.

Without conscious thought, her head found its way to its old sanctuary—the curve of Adora's shoulder.

She sighed, a soft, contented sound that quickly deepened into the quiet, steady rumble of a purr.

Safe and warm, sleep claimed her.

Feeling Catra's head settle on her shoulder was almost more than Adora could bear.

The weight, the warmth, the familiar scent of her fur… and then, the purr.

A soft, resonant vibration that seemed to emanate from the very core of Catra's being, vibrating against Adora's skin.

Tears pricked fiercely at Adora's eyes. She sat perfectly still, barely daring to breathe, terrified that any movement might shatter this impossible, beautiful moment.

This was more than she'd dared hope for in her wildest dreams. Catra, choosing closeness, choosing comfort, choosing *trust* enough to fall asleep against her.

The fear of hoping warred violently with the overwhelming surge of love and protectiveness that washed over her.

Later, Finn, sensing the shift, climbed up and wriggled in between them, their small body a warm bridge.

Finn’s own purr joined Catra’s, a harmony of pure contentment. Adora rested her cheek lightly against Catra’s hair, closing her eyes, simply existing within the profound rightness of it.

This was home. This was everything.

Eventually, the movie ended. Adora knew she had to wake Catra.

She gently squeezed her shoulder.

"Catra? Hey… movie’s over."

Catra stirred, blinking sleepily.

Adora’s face was close, soft in the dim light from the end credits. Warm. Familiar. Beloved.

Her gaze flickered down to Adora’s lips.

The sleepy haze and the lingering comfort of Adora’s shoulder made her initial impulse overwhelming: to lean forward and brush her lips against Adora’s in a drowsy, affectionate kiss.

Then, awareness crashed in. She felt the small, warm weight of Finn nestled against her side. She saw the vulnerability in Adora’s eyes.

This wasn't the moment. Not yet.

She looked down at Finn, her heart swelling with love, and gently stroked the soft fur behind their ear, buying herself a moment to compose herself.

"Mmm," she murmured, her voice thick with sleep and unspoken longing, her own purr stuttering to a stop. "Should probably get going."

She carefully extricated herself, avoiding Adora's gaze, the phantom feel of Adora's lips still tantalizingly close in her mind.

Later that night, back in her apartment, the memory of Adora's shoulder, the warmth, the *potential* of that almost-kiss, flooded back.

She let her hands wander, her mind replaying the feel of Adora beside her, imagining how differently the night could have ended if Finn hadn't been there, if she'd followed that impulse.

Her climax was powerful, a release of pent-up desire and a reclamation of her own sensuality.

These private explorations felt safe, vital—a way to reconnect with her own body and desires without the terrifying vulnerability of involving Adora just yet.

When Catra woke, Adora saw it.

The sleepy softening, the way Catra's eyes focused on her face, then dipped to her lips. The almost imperceptible lean forward. Adora's breath hitched.

Is she…?

Then Catra blinked, awareness dawning, and she looked away, focusing on Finn.

The moment passed, leaving Adora reeling, her skin tingling where Catra's gaze had lingered.

After Catra and Finn left, Adora tucked Finn into bed, her mind a whirlwind. She sank onto her own bed, replaying the evening—the deliberate touch, the head on her shoulder, the purr, the *almost-kiss*.

The intensity of her own desire startled her.

She didn't crave sensation for herself, but her hands *ached* to map the curves of Catra's body, to feel the softness of her fur, the strength beneath.

Her tongue remembered the specific taste of Catra, the particular sounds she made when overwhelmed.

She longed to hear those desperate gasps, those broken cries of her name, to feel Catra unravel beneath her touch once more.

It was a hunger that had been buried under guilt and grief, now roaring back to life with terrifying force.

Her phone buzzed on the nightstand, shattering the charged silence. A new text message. From Catra.

Adora picked it up, her fingers trembling slightly.

> Catra: adora, what would you say to ordering in and splitting a bottle of wine this weekend. maybe finn can stay with their auntie and uncle? i want to have a grownups only conversation.

Adora stared at the words. *Grownups only conversation*. The implications were vast, terrifying, exhilarating. The careful scaffolding of friendship, the tentative touches, the unspoken desire hanging thick in the air… it all coalesced into this moment. This wasn't just another dinner. This was a threshold.

Her thumbs flew over the screen, the reply sent before doubt could paralyze her:

> Adora: Absolutely. Bow and Glimmer would love to have Finn.

She hit send, her heart pounding a frantic rhythm against her ribs.

She put the phone down, but the echo of the notification seemed to linger in the quiet room.

An overwhelming sense of stillness settled over her, profound and deep. It wasn't the silence of emptiness, but the charged quiet

before a storm, the breath held before a plunge.

Something seismic had shifted.

The ground beneath their fragile new foundation was moving, and Adora could only stand still, heart wide open, waiting to see what new landscape would emerge.

The path of friendship had led them here, to the precipice of something infinitely more profound, infinitely more terrifying.

The stillness was saturated with possibility, heavy with the unspoken words waiting to be poured out with the wine.

The wait until the weekend stretched before her, an eternity charged with the electric potential of a single sentence.

Chapter 11: The Blueprints of Us

Chapter Notes

!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

The walk from her car to Adora’s front door felt like traversing a canyon.

Catra stood on the familiar porch, the wood grain beneath her the toes of her simple, rarely worn black flats suddenly fascinating.

Her palms were slick against the small, slightly crumpled paper bag containing the expensive Cabernet she’d splurged on.

Her heart hammered a frantic rhythm against her ribs, a counterpoint to the nervous thrumming of her tail.

She’d changed outfits three times. The simple, dark green wrap dress she’d finally settled on felt simultaneously too revealing and not revealing enough.

Beneath it, hidden silk and lace whispered against her skin–a secret armor, a dare, a promise to herself.

The demon of anxiety hissed, ‘*Maybe I’m getting ahead of myself*.’ But a new, bolder voice answered: *'I’m going to be brave. Honest.*' And if things go well…

The image of Adora’s hands, those strong, capable hands, peeling away the delicate fabric sent a fresh wave of heat through her core.

She needed that hidden confidence tonight, a shield against the lingering self-consciousness about the softness her body had gained, a reminder that she could still feel desirable.

Taking a final, shaky breath that did little to calm the storm inside, she knocked.

The door opened almost immediately, as if Adora had been hovering just behind it. She stood bathed in the warm hallway light, wearing dark jeans and a soft, deep blue sweater that made her eyes look impossibly bright.

Her smile was genuine, wide and hopeful, but tinged with an unmistakable layer of nerves that mirrored Catra's own.

"Hey," Adora breathed, the single word thick with anticipation.

"Hey," Catra managed, stepping inside.

The familiar scent of Adora's home—wood polish, faint traces of Finn's markers, Adora's cedar and sage shampoo—washed over her, a complex blend of comfort and charged history.

It smelled different now, less sterile, more lived-in, warmer. Like Adora had started inhabiting it again.

"I brought wine." She held out the bag, her fingers brushing Adora's as she took it. The brief contact sent a jolt up Catra's arm.

"Thanks! Looks fancy," Adora said, her gaze lingering on Catra for a beat too long, taking in the dress, the slight flush high on her cheeks. "Come on in. We can get food ordered. What sounds good to you? Thai? Italian? Your call."

Catra followed her into the living room, the space feeling both intimately familiar and charged with new potential.

"Thai sounds good," she murmured, sinking onto the edge of the couch. *Pad Thai, Green Curry, Spring Rolls*... the choices blurred together.

Food was the last thing on her mind.

Her thoughts were a chaotic whirlwind of rehearsed lines, terrifying hopes, and the insistent pulse between her legs fueled by the memory of Adora's post-workout scent and the feel of her thigh just days ago.

Adora placed the wine on the coffee table and sat beside her, leaving a careful, respectful distance.

"Okay, Thai it is. Usual suspects?" She pulled out her phone, her movements efficient but Catra could see the slight tremor in her fingers as she navigated the app.

They discussed options, settled on an order, the mundane ritual a flimsy raft on a sea of unspoken tension.

As Adora placed the order, the silence stretched.

Catra's tail twitched nervously. "How… how was Finn this week?" she asked, grasping for the safest anchor.

Adora's face softened instantly. "Good! Really good. They aced that history worksheet, by the way. Teacher wrote a note about their improved focus."

She launched into a detailed account of Finn's latest BlipBase obsession, a complicated trade involving rare virtual creatures, their eyes sparkling with parental pride.

Catra listened, nodding, asking questions, letting the familiar rhythm of talking about their child soothe the jagged edges of her nerves. It was their shared language, the bedrock upon which everything else was precariously balanced.

The food arrived, a welcome distraction. They moved to the small dining table, the clatter of containers and the fragrant steam providing a temporary buffer.

They ate, sharing quieter stories from their separate weeks—Catra's mind-numbing data entry marathon, Adora navigating a tricky client meeting.

The conversation flowed easier than Catra expected, punctuated by shared smiles and moments of comfortable quiet. They were simply enjoying being in each other's presence, a quiet intimacy rebuilding brick by brick.

Catra found herself genuinely laughing at Adora’s impression of her demanding client, the sound surprising her. Adora’s responding smile, warm and relieved, made Catra’s heart stutter.

After clearing the containers, Adora opened the wine, pouring two generous glasses. The rich, dark liquid gleamed in the soft light.

"Couch?" Adora suggested, her voice slightly husky.

Catra nodded, carrying her glass. They settled back onto the couch, closer this time than before dinner, bodies angled towards each other.

The space between them hummed with unspoken electricity.

Catra took a long sip of wine, the warmth spreading through her chest, doing little to quell the tremor in her hands.

She traced the rim of her glass, the silence stretching, thick and expectant. The words she’d practiced lodged in her throat, heavy and terrifying.

Her ears flattened slightly against her head.

Adora watched her, her expression gentle but intent. She didn’t push, simply waited, giving Catra the space she needed.

Finally, when the silence looked like it was threatening to suffocate Catra, Adora spoke softly, her voice a lifeline tossed into the storm.

"So, Catra… what was it that you wanted to talk about tonight?"

Catra’s breath hitched.

Her fingers and toes felt numb. It was suddenly hard to draw air into her lungs. She looked down at her wine glass, then forced her gaze up, meeting Adora’s steady blue eyes.

They held kindness, patience, and a depth of feeling that made Catra’s chest ache.

She took a deep, shuddering breath, forcing the words out on the exhale, her voice surprisingly steady despite the internal earthquake.

"Adora." The name felt sacred on her tongue. "It's been a couple of months since we decided to try being friends."

She saw Adora’s fingers tense, gripping the couch cushion beside her thigh. Adora nodded, cautious, hopeful, bracing.

"I told you… I needed to see you being reliable. And consistent. And honest. I needed to see you treating me like I was important to you. Like I was a priority."

Another nod from Adora, slower this time, her eyes never leaving Catra’s face.

Catra forged ahead, the words tumbling out now, driven by a desperate need to be understood.

"You've done all those things. I've seen lasting change. In the way you treat me, the way you manage your time… how often you make promises, and how often you keep them."

Her voice softened, thick with emotion. "It's… helped me feel safe enough. To start lowering my walls. Letting you in. Starting to trust you again."

Adora’s breath caught audibly. Tears shimmered in her eyes, but she held Catra’s gaze, her expression one of profound vulnerability.

"I want to give you everything you need, Catra," she whispered, the words raw and fervent. "Always."

The moment hung suspended. Catra felt the precipice beneath her feet. This was it. The leap of faith. Her heart hammered so hard

she thought it might burst.

She swallowed, gathering every ounce of courage she possessed.

"Adora…" Her voice was barely above a whisper, yet it filled the quiet room. "I want to come back home. I want to be your wife again, if you'll have me."

The world stopped.

Catra watched the kaleidoscope of emotions cascade across Adora's face.

The initial flicker of shock, quickly replaced by dawning, disbelieving relief. Then, pure, unadulterated elation, so bright it was almost blinding.

Tears welled up, overflowing, tracing paths down Adora's cheeks as a choked sob escaped her.

Before Catra could process the reaction, Adora surged forward.

Strong arms wrapped around Catra, pulling her into a fierce, all-encompassing embrace.

Adora buried her face in Catra's neck, her body trembling.

"Yes," she gasped, the word muffled against Catra's skin, wet with tears. "Oh, stars, Catra, yes! Of course! You've always been welcome here. I never stopped wanting to be your wife. Never."

She pulled back just enough to cradle Catra's face in her hands, her eyes blazing with love and wonder. "If you want to come back… then I want you to come back. More than anything."

Catra felt her own tears threatening, a hot pressure behind her eyes, a lump in her throat. Adora's joy was overwhelming, infectious, but she had to hold on a little longer.

She had one more question, a need burning brighter than any other in this moment of reclaimed love. She lifted a slightly trembling hand, brushing a tear from Adora’s cheek.

Her voice, when it came, was thick with desire and vulnerability.

"Adora…" Her mismatched eyes searched Adora’s, finding only love and an answering hunger. "Would you kiss me?"

Adora didn't hesitate.

Her hands, warm and sure, still cupped Catra’s face, thumbs stroking her cheekbones with infinite tenderness. She leaned in slowly, reverently, giving Catra every chance to change her mind.

Catra met her halfway.

The press of their lips together was a revelation. It was chaste, gentle, tentative—a rediscovery of a forgotten country, its borders still familiar, its landscape achingly new.

Yet, even that soft contact sent a jolt of pure heat straight to Catra’s core, igniting a fire that had been banked for far too long.

A soft whimper escaped her. She kissed back, tentatively at first, then with growing hunger, her lips parting instinctively.

Adora responded in kind, her kiss deepening, becoming more assured. The tentative exploration blossomed into something desperate and consuming.

Catra’s hands found Adora’s shoulders, fingers digging into the firm muscle beneath the soft sweater, squeezing, kneading, relearning the strength that had always driven her wild.

She licked into Adora’s mouth, her rough magicat tongue seeking Adora’s smooth, slick warmth, tasting the faint sweetness of wine and the unique, beloved essence that was purely Adora.

Adora made a surprised, needy noise in the back of her throat, her fingers tangling instantly in the short, soft strands of Catra's hair, holding her close, kissing back with equal ferocity.

The tentative reunion vanished, replaced by a primal hunger, a reclaiming.

Catra pressed forward, driven by a year of longing, months of suppressed desire, and the overwhelming relief of Adora's 'yes'.

Adora yielded, sinking back into the couch cushions, Catra following her down, straddling her hips, never breaking the kiss.

They kissed like drowning souls finding air.

Catra's hands roamed over Adora's shoulders, down her arms, mapping the familiar terrain with desperate urgency. Adora's hands were everywhere—in Catra's hair, tracing the line of her spine through the dress, gripping her hips, pulling her closer.

The taste, the scent, the feel—it was an intoxicating flood of sensory memory and overwhelming present need.

Finally, gasping for air, Catra pulled back.

Her eyes were dilated pools of darkness, her lips swollen and glistening. Her breath came in desperate little pants, her whole body trembling with the force of her desire.

She looked down at Adora, flushed and beautiful beneath her, her own breathing ragged.

"Adora," Catra rasped, her voice husky and thick with emotion and pure, unadulterated lust. "Would you please take me to bed and fuck me?"

Adora moved with startling speed and strength.

Adora moved with startling speed and strength. Her hands shifted, one arm hooking under Catra's knees, the other bracing her back.

With a powerful surge, she stood, lifting Catra straight up from where she straddled her lap.

Catra gasped, then wrapped her arms tightly around Adora’s neck, burying her face in the warm skin beneath her jaw. She nuzzled into the spot, her sharp teeth finding a familiar, claiming purchase on Adora's neck.

She inhaled deeply, the scent of Adora’s skin, sweat, and the faint, clean detergent from her sweater filling her senses.

She couldn't resist; she pressed hot, open-mouthed kisses along Adora’s neck, tasting salt, her teeth nipping lightly, leaving a trail of sharp little marks.

She felt Adora’s sharp intake of breath, heard the low, guttural groan that vibrated against her lips.

"Fuck, Catra," Adora breathed, her voice strained, carrying Catra swiftly down the hallway towards their bedroom—their bedroom again.

Adora’s steps were sure, her grip firm, but Catra could feel the slight tremor in her arms, the rapid thud of her heart against Catra’s body.

Catra continued her assault, sinking her teeth into the meat of Adora’s trapezius, sucking a mark high on Adora’s neck, relishing the way Adora’s pace stuttered.

She was completely lost in her desire, all walls demolished, all control surrendered to this desperate, needy hunger.

It was a state Adora had always loved seeing her in, and the knowledge that she could still unravel Catra like this, that Catra still *wanted* to be unraveled by her, sent a fresh wave of possessive heat through Adora.

Adora shouldered the bedroom door open and carried Catra straight to the bed, lowering her gently onto the familiar

comforter.

Catra immediately reached for her, pulling Adora down on top of her, their mouths crashing together again in a frenzy of tongues and teeth.

Adora shifted, settling her weight, her thigh instinctively slotting between Catra’s legs, applying delicious pressure right where Catra needed it most.

The contact was electric. Catra arched off the bed with a desperate cry, her claws pricking through the fabric of Adora’s sweater, clinging to her.

"Fuck, Adora!" she gasped, grinding down against Adora’s thigh, seeking friction, release, connection.

Time dissolved. They rocked against each other, a frantic rhythm fueled by pent-up need and the sheer, overwhelming joy of being allowed to touch again.

Kisses were deep and hungry, punctuated by sharp nips and bites—Catra marking Adora’s jaw, shoulder, anywhere her mouth could reach.

Hands roamed with possessive urgency, relearning curves and planes, rediscovering sensitive spots that elicited gasps and moans.

Clothes became frustrating barriers. Catra tugged at Adora’s sweater, needing skin. Adora’s hands slid under Catra’s dress, finding the soft fur and heated skin of her back, the edge of the lace waistband.

Eventually, Catra pulled back from the kiss, panting, her chest heaving. Her eyes were wild, dark with lust. Adora hovered above her, equally breathless, her gaze burning.

"What do you need, Catra?" Adora asked, her voice rough with desire. "Tell me."

Catra hesitated for only a heartbeat, her mind a whirlwind of wants.

She wanted everything. She wanted to erase the years of distance, to feel Adora everywhere, all at once.

"I want…" she breathed, her voice catching. "I want your mouth. I want you inside of me. Fingers first…"

She met Adora's eyes, seeing the answering flare of heat. "Then the strap. I want you to hold me when you make me come."

Adora didn't need telling twice. She pushed herself up, her movements fluid and purposeful.

"Can I undress you?" she asked, already pulling her sweater off over her head, revealing the sports bra beneath, then shimmying out of her jeans.

Catra watched, mesmerized by the flex of Adora's muscles, the familiar strength of her body.

But as Adora turned her attention back to her, reaching for the tie of her wrap dress, a familiar wave of self-consciousness washed over Catra. Her ears pinned back slightly, a flicker of anxiety crossing her face as Adora's gaze traveled down her body.

Adora paused instantly, her hand hovering. She sat on the edge of the bed, her expression softening. She reached out, cupping Catra's cheek, forcing her to meet her eyes. "Catra? What is it?"

Catra looked away, focusing on a point on the comforter. "It's just…" she mumbled, the words sticking in her throat.

"I told you… I've gained some weight. Over the last year. I feel…" She swallowed hard. "Anxious. That you won't…be attracted to me like this."

Admitting it felt excruciatingly vulnerable.

Adora’s expression shifted, not to pity, but to fierce tenderness. She leaned in, capturing Catra’s gaze again, her thumb stroking Catra’s cheekbone.

"Oh, Catra," she breathed, her voice thick with emotion. "Look at me." She waited until Catra’s wary eyes met hers. "There isn't a way your body could change that would make me less attracted to you. Not one."

Her gaze was unwavering, sincere. "I'm attracted to you because you're *you*. Your spirit, your fire, your laugh, your stubbornness, your courage… all of you. The number on a scale, the shape of your curves… that’s just the beautiful vessel holding the woman I love. And I love *every* version of you."

The raw honesty, the absolute conviction in Adora’s voice, pierced through Catra’s insecurity.

Tears welled in her eyes, not of sadness, but of profound relief. She nodded, a small, tremulous smile touching her lips.

"Okay, dummy," she whispered, her voice thick. "Go ahead. Show me how attracted you are to me."

Adora’s eyes darkened instantly, a predatory gleam replacing the tenderness.

She leaned in, capturing Catra’s lips in a searing kiss that stole her breath.

Then, her hands went to the tie of Catra’s wrap dress, undoing it with deliberate slowness. She pushed the fabric aside, revealing the lace bra beneath.

Adora made a low, appreciative sound in her throat, her gaze raking over the exposed curve of Catra's body.

"Beautiful," she breathed, leaning down to kiss the swell of Catra’s breast above the lace.

Her hands slid down Catra’s sides, pushing the dress further open, then helping her wriggle out of it completely.

Adora took her time.

She kissed a trail along Catra’s collarbone, down her sternum. Her thumbs traced the lace edges of the bra, sending shivers through Catra.

She unhooked it with practiced ease, letting it fall away, and immediately captured a peaked nipple in her mouth, sucking gently, then harder, flicking her tongue.

Catra cried out, her claws sinking into the comforter.

Adora worshipped her breasts, alternating between them, lavishing attention with her mouth and hands, relearning their sensitivity, murmuring words of adoration against her skin.

Her hands slid lower, over the plush fur of Catra’s ribs, then her waist, coming to rest on the soft curve of her stomach.

Catra tensed instinctively.

Adora felt it. She lifted her head, meeting Catra’s anxious gaze. Without breaking eye contact, she leaned down and placed a series of soft, reverent kisses across Catra’s lower belly, right over the softness she’d been self-conscious about.

"I love this," Adora murmured against her skin, her breath warm. "I love how soft you feel here."

She kissed her way lower, towards the waistband of the lace panties. "I love you."

The simple declaration, combined with the tactile proof of Adora’s desire, shattered the last remnants of Catra’s doubt.

She melted back into the pillows, a soft moan escaping her lips. Adora hooked her thumbs into the sides of the panties, slowly

drawing them down Catra’s legs.

When they were off, Adora paused, kneeling between Catra’s spread thighs, simply looking.

Catra lay bare before her, flushed and trembling, her chest rising and falling rapidly. Adora’s gaze traveled over her, a look of pure, unadulterated hunger on her face.

"Fuck," Adora breathed, the word thick with awe. "You're so gorgeous, Catra. Unbelievably beautiful."

Her eyes darkened further. "I want to make you feel so good."

She didn't rush. She leaned forward, gently spreading Catra’s folds with her thumbs, exposing her glistening, swollen flesh to the cool air and her intense gaze.

Catra whimpered at the exposure, but Adora’s expression held only reverence.

She leaned in, placing a single, lingering kiss on Catra’s throbbing clit. Catra jolted, a gasp tearing from her throat.

Adora collected the slickness glistening on Catra’s entrance with her fingers, her eyes locked with Catra’s as she slowly, deliberately, pressed one finger inside.

Catra’s body clamped down instantly, her velvet heat a vise around Adora’s finger. Her claws shot out, fisting in Adora’s hair, not pulling, just holding on.

"Relax," Adora murmured against her inner thigh, placing soothing kisses there. "I've got you. Just breathe."

She began to move her finger slowly, in and out, a gentle exploration.

The sensation was overwhelming—the stretch, the glide, the intimate connection after so long.

Adora’s mouth returned to her clit, her tongue circling, flicking, applying perfect pressure.

She added a second finger, stretching Catra carefully, curling them expertly against that spongy spot inside her.

Catra’s world narrowed to the points of contact: Adora’s mouth, devastatingly skilled; Adora’s fingers, filling her, stroking her; Adora’s hair clutched in her fist.

Whimpers turned to moans, then to broken cries as Adora built the pressure relentlessly. Her hips lifted off the bed, seeking more, her tail thrashing against the sheets.

"Adora, please," she begged, her voice ragged. "Please, *please* fuck me, I can't wait any longer!"

Adora lifted her head, her lips glistening, her eyes burning with need.

She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand, never breaking eye contact. "Okay, baby. Okay."

She grabbed the harness and the strap-on from the nightstand drawer, along with the lube. Her movements were quick, efficient. She secured the harness around her hips with practiced ease, coated the silicone generously.

The sight of Adora like that, strong and focused, the harness emphasizing the powerful lines of her hips and thighs, sent another surge of desperate heat through Catra.

Adora moved back between Catra’s legs. Her hands, strong and sure, gripped Catra’s thighs firmly.

"Look at me," she commanded softly. Catra’s eyes, wide and dark, snapped to hers. Adora gently lifted Catra’s legs, folding her almost in half, bringing her hips up—the mating press.

The tip of the strap rested against Catra’s slick entrance. One of Adora’s hands released Catra’s thigh and came up, her fingers gently rubbing the base of one of Catra’s sensitive ears.

Catra instinctively leaned her head into the touch, a deep purr rumbling in her chest, her eyes staying locked on Adora’s.

Adora held her gaze, the connection profound, charged with the weight of their history, their pain, their forgiveness, and this moment of raw reconnection.

"Ready?" Adora asked, her voice low and husky, though they both knew the answer.

Catra’s lips curved in a slightly feral smile, her eyes blazing. "If you don't start fucking me," she panted, "I'm going to scream."

Adora’s answering grin was fierce. She pushed forward slowly, steadily, breaching Catra’s entrance. There was a moment of intense pressure, a gasp from Catra, then a slick, deep slide as Adora sheathed herself fully.

Catra’s head fell back, a guttural cry tearing from her throat.

Adora paused for a heartbeat, buried deep, letting them both adjust, savoring the incredible feeling of being joined again. Then she pulled back, almost all the way out, before thrusting home again.

She started slow, establishing a rhythm, relearning the angle, the depth that made Catra gasp. She was a little rusty, but muscle memory kicked in swiftly.

Soon, she found her stride—deep, powerful thrusts that drove the breath from Catra’s lungs with every impact.

The wet, rhythmic slap of their bodies meeting filled the room, punctuated by Catra’s increasingly desperate cries and Adora’s own guttural groans.

Adora watched, mesmerized, as Catra bounced and jostled beneath her with each powerful thrust.

The sight of her small breasts, the soft curve of her stomach—which Adora found unbearably, adorably sexy—jiggling, Catra's face a mask of ecstatic agony… it was intoxicating.

Catra's eyes were screwed shut, her claws gripping Adora's shoulders tightly enough to leave marks, her legs wrapped like a vise around Adora's waist, heels digging into her lower back.

The sounds, the sensations, the sight of Catra coming apart beneath her drove Adora harder, faster, deeper.

She focused everything on the woman beneath her, on the building tension in Catra's body, on the desperate pitch of her cries.

She wanted to shatter her, to rebuild her in the aftershocks of pleasure.

"I'm close, Adora!" Catra gasped, her voice high and tight, her body arching, tensing, trembling. "I'm so close, don't stop, please don't stop!"

"You're doing so good, baby," Adora ground out, her own control fraying at the edges, her thrusts becoming punishing. "You can do it. Come for me, Catra. Let go. *Come for me!*"

The command, the raw need in Adora's voice, tipped Catra over the edge.

Her body went rigid as a bowstring, every muscle locking. Her legs clamped around Adora's waist with shocking force. Her claws dug deep into Adora's shoulders, drawing a sharp gasp of mingled pain and pleasure.

Her mouth opened in a silent, breathless scream. Her head thrashed side to side, teeth seeking purchase, finally sinking hard

into Adora’s shoulder with a muffled cry as the supernova detonated.

Her eyes squeezed shut against the blinding, overwhelming wave. It felt infinite, a supernova detonating in her core, scattering the last fragments of her doubt into stardust, radiating outwards until her very fingertips tingled.

She felt herself clenching rhythmically, violently around Adora’s strap, milking it as the convulsions wracked her.

Adora held her through it, driving into her through the pulsing contractions, prolonging the peak, murmuring choked encouragements against her neck. It seemed to last an eternity, Catra suspended in pure, mindless ecstasy.

Gradually, the violent tremors subsided. Her body went utterly boneless, limbs flopping to the sides as if unstrung. Her breath came in ragged, shuddering gasps, jaw finally relaxing, leaving deep, perfect teeth marks in Adora’s shoulder.

She felt liquefied, utterly spent, adrift on a sea of pure sensation.

Adora slowed, then stilled, buried deep.

She pressed soft, reverent kisses to Catra’s neck, her ears, her cheeks, kissing the salt of tears Catra hadn't realized she’d shed. She whispered words Catra couldn't quite process, a litany of love and awe, as Catra floated, mindless and sated, in the profound afterglow.

Minutes passed.

Catra drifted, aware only of the heavy warmth of Adora still partially covering her, the lingering tremors in her limbs, the incredible sense of peace.

Slowly, awareness seeped back.

She blinked her eyes open, finding Adora’s face hovering above hers, watching her with an expression of such tender wonder it made Catra’s heart ache.

She managed a weak, loopy smile.

"Hey," she croaked, her voice wrecked. "Come here."

She lifted a heavy hand, guiding Adora’s face down to hers. She kissed her, soft and slow, a kiss saturated with exhaustion, profound satisfaction, and overwhelming love.

"How was it?" Adora asked softly, pulling back just enough to speak, her hand coming up to cradle Catra’s arm, pressing kisses to her wrist, the pads of her palm, each fingertip and claw.

Catra managed a weak chuckle, the sound raspy. "It was passable," she joked, her voice sounding completely demolished. "Guess you’re out of practice."

Adora laughed, a warm, rumbling sound against Catra’s skin. "Okay, fine," she conceded, pressing another kiss to Catra’s palm. "I’ll try harder next time."

"If you try any harder," she groaned, "I'm going to need a pussy transplant or something. Stars, Adora."

She reached up, tracing Adora’s jawline with a trembling finger. "You get an A+. Top marks. Valedictorian of fucking."

Adora’s laughter deepened. She’d forgotten how silly, how utterly loopy and unreserved Catra got when she’d come that hard.

It was a precious, intimate glimpse of the unguarded woman beneath the defenses.

Carefully, Adora pulled out, unbuckled the harness, and tossed the strap aside.

She slid off the bed just long enough to grab a warm washcloth from the adjoining bathroom, gently cleaning Catra, who purred drowsily at the tender care.

Then Adora climbed back into bed, gathering Catra into her arms, pulling the covers over them both.

She tucked Catra’s head under her chin, her arms wrapped tightly around her, holding her as if she might vanish.

The silence was warm and deep, filled only by their slowing breaths and the soft rumble starting in Catra’s chest.

Then, Adora’s body began to shake. Silent sobs wracked her frame, tears soaking into Catra’s hair. The relief, the joy, the sheer overwhelming magnitude of having Catra back in her arms, in their bed, as her wife… it crashed over her in an unstoppable wave.

"I'm so glad you're here," Adora whispered, her voice choked and thick with tears.

Catra shifted, wrapping her own arms around Adora, holding her close.

She nuzzled into Adora’s neck, purring louder, a soothing vibration against Adora’s skin. "Me too," she murmured, her voice thick with sleep and love.

She felt Adora’s arms tighten around her, heard the shuddering breath as the tears slowly subsided.

The profound stillness returned, deeper now, infused with a bone-deep contentment and the unshakeable certainty of belonging.

The frantic energy of the evening, the desperate passion, the flood of emotion—it all settled into a profound peace.

The fractures weren't just healing; they were being reforged, stronger in the broken places.

Laying together in the dark, wrapped in each other and the soft blankets, the only sound the syncopated rhythm of their breathing and Catra’s contented purr, they finally drifted into a deep, restful sleep.

The blueprints of 'us' were being redrawn, not from scratch, but over the solid, enduring foundation of a love that had weathered the storm. They were choosing, fiercely, to rebuild.

Together.

Chapter 12: The Shape of Coming Home

Chapter Notes

just one chapter left, friends <3

Catra stirred, consciousness returning in warm, slow waves.

The first sensation wasn't sight, but *presence*. A familiar weight beside her, radiating warmth.

The scent—clean cotton, faint citrus, and uniquely *Adora*—filled her lungs.

Then, the light, filtering through eyelids still heavy with deep, contented sleep.

She blinked, the world swimming into focus: the familiar cream ceiling of Adora’s bedroom, the slant of morning sun painting stripes across the rumpled duvet.

And Adora. Already awake. Propped up on one elbow, head resting on her hand, simply *looking* at her.

The intensity in those blue eyes wasn't scrutiny; it was pure, unadulterated wonder. Like she was witnessing a miracle she still couldn’t quite believe was real.

A familiar sharpness, honed by years of defense, flickered instinctively in Catra’s chest. But it dissolved before it could form words, melted by the sheer, open softness on her own face, the profound peace settling deep in her bones.

She met Adora’s gaze, a sleepy smile curving her lips.

"Creep," she croaked, her voice rough with sleep, the accusation utterly devoid of bite.

Adora’s answering smile was luminous, chasing away the last shadows of disbelief in her eyes.

"Good morning, Catra," she whispered, the awe in her voice palpable, like a prayer.

Slowly, reverently, Adora reached out. Her fingers brushed a stray strand of dark hair from Catra’s forehead, then traced the curve of her cheekbone.

The touch was feather-light, exploratory, rediscovering territory long forbidden. Her thumb stroked the soft fur at the base of Catra’s ear, a gesture so intrinsically linked to comfort and intimacy that Catra’s breath hitched.

A low, rumbling purr started deep in Catra’s chest, a sound Adora hadn't realized was a fundamental part of her world's soundtrack until its year-long absence. It vibrated through her entire frame, a physical manifestation of the safety and contentment flooding her.

Adora’s eyes widened slightly at the sound, a soft gasp of recognition and sheer joy escaping her lips. She luxuriated in the feel—the warmth of Catra’s skin, the softness of her fur under her fingertips, the tangible, breathing *realness* of her after so long in the echoing emptiness of this room.

Catra leaned into the touch, then shifted, closing the small distance between them.

She pressed her lips to Adora’s in a soft, unhurried kiss.

It wasn't fueled by the desperate hunger of the night before, but by a profound, sleepy tenderness.

A simple affirmation: *I’m here. This is real*.

When she pulled back, she saw Adora’s eyes were shimmering again, reflecting Catra’s own breathtaking openness and vulnerability.

"Good morning," Catra said, quietly, sincerely, her purr softening the words.

Adora swallowed hard, her voice thick. "Catra... I still can't believe last night was real. I keep thinking I'll wake up again alone in this bed. That this... is just another cruel dream."

A flicker of sadness, an echo of their shared loneliness, crossed Catra's features. But it was swiftly replaced by a gentle, knowing smile.

She shifted slightly, a deliberate wince playing on her lips.

"I'm sore enough this morning that it better have been real, princess. Stars, Adora," she teased, her voice still husky, "you really know how to put a woman through her paces. Valedictorian of sex indeed."

Adora snorted, a genuine laugh bursting free, the tension dissolving like mist in the morning sun.

"Well, I have to live up to my title, don't I? There are expectations now. A reputation to uphold." She nudged Catra playfully with her shoulder.

They lapsed into comfortable silence then, wrapped in the warmth of the bed and each other. The world outside, with its schedules and demands, felt distant, unimportant.

There was nowhere else they needed to be, nothing more pressing than this: the shared breath, the gentle stroking of Adora's fingers through Catra's hair, the steady rumble of the purr. It was a luxury they hadn't allowed themselves in years, this unhurried intimacy, this simple *being* together.

Eventually, the peaceful quiet was shattered by a loud, protesting gurgle from Adora's stomach. Catra chuckled, the sound vibrating against Adora's side.

"Alright, dummy," she announced, stretching languidly. "Starving athletes need fuel. I'll make us breakfast."

She slipped out of the warm cocoon of the bed, the cool air hitting her skin.

Standing by the dresser, the reality struck her. Her clothes—her own comfortable, familiar things—weren't here. They were still packed in boxes or hanging in the sterile closet of her apartment.

A small pang of displacement flickered, but it was quickly replaced by a different feeling.

She turned, catching Adora watching her with that same soft awe. With a deliberate, almost playful defiance, Catra opened Adora's drawer.

She pulled out a well-worn, soft grey t-shirt that hung loosely off of her frame and a pair of Adora's sleep shorts, drawstrings cinched tightly at her waist, her tail escaping from one of the leg openings.

Dressed in Adora's clothes, she felt small, enveloped, and utterly, adorably out of place in the best possible way.

Adora's gaze was pure, unadulterated affection. "You look…" she began, then just shook her head, a helpless smile spreading across her face. "Perfect."

"Shut up," Catra muttered, but her ears twitched with pleasure, a faint blush warming her cheeks. "Come on, slowpoke. Coffee won't make itself."

Downstairs, the kitchen felt different. Not just familiar, but *reclaimed*. Adora busied herself with the coffee maker, the ritual grounding. Catra moved with a fluidity she hadn't felt in that space for over a year.

She knew exactly where the good non-stick pan was, the whisk she preferred for eggs, the specific heat setting on the stove.

Cracking eggs into a bowl, whisking them with a sprinkle of salt and pepper, melting butter in the pan–it wasn't just making breakfast; it was reasserting her place in the rhythm of this home.

She'd missed this. The cool, solid granite countertop under her hands, the specific clatter of these utensils, the shared silence punctuated by the sizzle of eggs and the gurgle of the coffee pot.

It was a mundane symphony of belonging.

They ate at the kitchen island, shoulders brushing companionably. The omelettes were simple, fluffy, perfect. The coffee was strong and hot. Conversation was light, comfortable, punctuated by comfortable silences.

It felt effortless, a stark contrast to the strained meals of the past year, even the recent, hopeful family nights.

As they sat nursing the last of their coffee, Catra groaned dramatically, burying her face in her hands. "Our friends," she announced, "are going to be absolutely *unbearable* about this, aren't they?"

Adora grinned, warmth spreading through her chest. "They care about us, Catra! But... yes. One hundred percent. Glimmer might actually combust."

She paused, feigning seriousness. "We could just... never tell them? Might be easier."

Catra laughed, a bright, genuine sound that echoed pleasantly in the kitchen. Then, her expression softened into something warm and sincere, her gaze meeting Adora's.

"No," she said firmly. "I'm too proud to keep this a secret. Proud of *us*. What we did... navigating that mess, finding our way back... it wasn't easy. We did it. We figured it out."

She lifted her chin slightly. "We'll just have to be *more* insufferable than them. Show them how it's done."

"Deal," Adora agreed, her voice thick with emotion. Hearing Catra say she was *proud* of them, of their hard-won reconciliation, felt like sunlight breaking through storm clouds, warming her from the inside out.

It solidified everything. It wasn't just relief or desire; it was mutual respect, slowly-earned trust, and genuine pride in the work they'd done.

Catra was right. They *had* navigated it.

Adora had reflected, truly seen the damage she'd caused, learned to listen without rushing to fix, learned the devastating weight of broken promises and the vital importance of keeping her word, however small.

She'd given Catra the space she demanded, even when it felt like dying. And Catra… Catra had protected herself by leaving, a necessary act of self-preservation Adora now understood wasn't rejection, but survival.

And she hadn't let stubborn pride keep her away once she felt the undeniable pull back towards Adora, once she saw the genuine change.

They'd both laid bare their hurt, truly listened to the other's perspective, acknowledged the pain they'd caused each other. And through it all, Finn's well-being had been their shared, unwavering compass.

Adora had once thought turning forty meant stagnation, a slow decline.

Sitting here, bathed in the morning sun and Catra's presence, feeling the profound shift within herself, she realized it felt more like a beginning. She had hard-won wisdom now, the tools to navigate life's complexities.

And she had her partner back—a real, complex woman who had fought her way back to her, scars and all. Someone she could truly count on.

She was pulled from her reverie by Catra standing beside her, holding out her phone.

"Say cheese, princess," Catra commanded, a playful glint in her eyes. Before Adora could fully process it, Catra pressed a firm kiss to her cheek.

The shutter clicked.

Adora blinked, momentarily disoriented by unexpected affection. Catra turned the screen towards her. "What do you think? Will this make Sparkles and Arrow's heads explode from excitement?"

Adora looked at the photo. Catra, bathed in morning light filtering through the kitchen window, her expression soft and affectionate, pressing a kiss to Adora's cheek.

And Adora… her face wore the same awestruck, slightly dazed expression of pure, unguarded happiness she suspected hadn't left her since the moment Catra asked to come back. Her eyes were wide, her smile tremulous and radiant.

A laugh bubbled up in Adora's chest. "I think that sums it up pretty well," she agreed, shaking her head. "Scorpia's probably going to kick our door down for a hug."

Catra paused, her thumb hovering over the screen, struck by the casual, effortless truth in Adora's "our door." It wasn't a question or a test; it was a simple statement of fact. A warm wave of rightness washed over her.

Our home.

It was going to take conscious adjustment, shedding the solitary identity of the apartment dweller, but the relief, the *rightness* of it, was overwhelming.

She was home. Not just physically, but in every sense that mattered.

She quickly added Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Perfuma to a group chat. She selected the photo, hesitated for only a second, then typed: *dont make a big deal out of it, but adora and i got back together.* She hit send.

Predictably, their phones erupted within seconds.

> Scorpia: WILDCAT!!!!!!!!! THAT'S HUGE! I'M SO HAPPY FOR YOU GUYS!!! 🥹🎉💥🤯❤️🔥❤️🔥❤️🔥 CALL ME LATER OKAY I WANT TO HEAR EVERYTHING!!

> Perfuma: I always held faith that your love would find its way back to harmony. This brings such peace to my heart. Deepest congratulations. 🌱

> Bow: YOU GUYS!!!!!! I'm SO HAPPY FOR YOU!!!!! Like, genuinely, tears-of-joy happy! 😭😭😭 Fill us in over brunch soon pls? 🙏❤️ (Trying SO hard to be chill right now because we don't want to accidentally ruin the surprise for Finn!)

> Glimmer: IT'S ABOUT **FUCKING** TIME!!!!! 🔥💥🚀💣🎊🎉❤️

Catra and Adora leaned together, shoulders shaking with laughter as they read the cascading messages, the sheer volume of emojis, the palpable, overwhelming love and excitement radiating from their screens.

It was ridiculous and over-the-top and utterly, perfectly *them*.

As their laughter subsided, Adora wiped a tear from the corner of her eye.

"Seriously," she said, her voice still thick with amusement and deeper emotion. "I wouldn't have made it through the last year without Bow and Glimmer. Not even close. They put me back

together every single time I fell apart. Listened to me cry, talked me off ledges, reminded me to eat…"

Catra nodded somberly, the gratitude warming her own chest. "Same with Scorpia and Perfuma. They let me camp on their couch for *six months*. Six months of my moping and existential crises and eating all their snacks. That's real friendship. And they never once told me to stop complaining, even when I was just repeating the same sad things."

She nudged Adora. "We owe them a fruit basket or something."

They lingered over the dregs of their coffee, basking in the quiet joy and the absurdity of their friends' reactions. Eventually, Catra shifted, adjusting her tail uncomfortably.

"Okay, as much as I enjoy the 'drowned kitten in your clothes' look, I need my own stuff. Feel like helping me raid the sad apartment? I've only got a few months left on the lease, but honestly? I don't want to spend one more night in that place if I don't have to."

The thought of returning, even briefly, sent a faint shiver down her spine.

Adora was already moving, coffee mug abandoned. "Keys!" she declared, snatching them off the hook near the door and shoving her feet into sneakers.

The eagerness radiating from her was almost comical. She practically vibrated with the desire to get Catra's things *out* of that apartment and back *here*, where they belonged.

The resentment she'd harbored for that place was now overlaid with a fierce determination to erase its hold.

The drive to Catra's apartment building was quiet, filled with a different kind of anticipation. Adora parked, and they walked up the familiar, slightly dingy hallway.

Catra unlocked the door, pushing it open onto the small, dim space that had never felt like home. The air was stale, carrying the faint, lingering scent of takeout and loneliness.

They worked efficiently. Catra packed clothes into suitcases–her favorite soft sweaters, comfortable jeans, the pajamas Finn had picked out for her last birthday.

Adora carefully packed Catra’s laptop, charger, and a box of toiletries from the bathroom. They didn't speak much, the silence heavy with the weight of the place.

Standing amidst the half-packed suitcases in the small living area, Catra hugged herself, looking around. "I hated it here," she confessed, her voice low.

"I thought… getting my own place, it would feel like freedom. Like starting fresh. But it just felt… wrong. From the first night. Empty and cold and… quiet in all the worst ways." She shivered.

"I guess it forced me to see that just taking myself further away from you didn’t fix the hurt. It just made me lonelier. I still needed the time, Adora. I needed to figure things out for myself. But this place?"

She gestured around. "It let me know what I was missing. All the little things you did, the ways you made life smoother… suddenly it was all on me. Fending for myself."

She met Adora’s eyes. "Being here… it helped me start to miss you."

Adora stepped closer, wrapping a solid arm around Catra’s shoulders, pulling her against her side. They stood together in the doorway, taking in the small, impersonal space.

Adora took a deep breath, the old resentment tempered by a new understanding.

"Thank you," she said, the words sincere despite the half-joking tone, "shitty apartment. For being here for Catra when she needed space. For giving her shelter while she figured things out. And…" she squeezed Catra tighter, "for helping her realize what she truly wanted."

The apartment had been a necessary purgatory, a crucible that ultimately led Catra back to her. She could finally see its purpose, and with that, the last vestiges of her anger towards it dissolved.

By the time they hauled the last suitcase and box into the trunk of Adora's car and drove back to their house—*their* house—the afternoon sun was slanting low.

They quickly unpacked Catra's essentials, hanging clothes in the closet beside Adora's, placing toiletries in the bathroom cabinet, setting her laptop on the desk in the corner of their bedroom.

Each item placed felt like a reclaiming, a stitch mending the fabric of their shared life.

As they finished putting the last few things away, Adora glanced at the clock. Butterflies, large and fluttering, took up residence in her stomach.

"It's almost time," she said, her voice tight with sudden nerves. She turned to Catra, searching her face. "This... really is real? It's safe to tell Finn? It's fine," she added quickly, "if you need more time to be sure. I just... I couldn't bear it if we got their hopes up and then..."

She couldn't finish the sentence, the fear of hurting Finn paramount.

Catra crossed the space between them in two strides. She took Adora's face in her hands, her mismatched eyes holding Adora's gaze with unwavering certainty.

"Adora," she said, her voice firm and clear. "This is real. I am not going anywhere. Not ever again. If we hit bumps in the road—and

we will—we'll work them out. *Together*. Like we proved we can."

She stroked Adora's cheek with her thumb. "Now, let's go give our kiddo the best news they've heard in over a year."

They walked hand-in-hand to the front door, stepping out onto the porch just as Bow and Glimmer's familiar car pulled up to the curb. Adora squeezed Catra's hand, a silent exchange of courage.

Finn tumbled out of the back seat almost before the car stopped, backpack bouncing, a whirlwind of dark blonde fur heading straight for them.

"Hey, space ranger!" Adora called, her voice thick with emotion even as she smiled.

Finn skidded to a stop in front of them, beaming, their ears perked high with excitement. "Mama! Mom!"

They launched themselves forward, expecting the usual separate hugs. But as they wrapped their small arms around both women at once, they froze.

Finn pulled back slightly, their bright blue eyes darting down, widening in shock as they registered their mothers' joined hands.

They looked up, first at Catra, then at Adora, their ears flattening momentarily against their head in confusion before perking forward again with dawning, impossible hope.

Adora and Catra knelt simultaneously, pulling Finn into a tight, three-way hug.

Finn clung to them, burying their furry face between them for a moment, a soft, questioning chirp escaping them.

When they pulled back, Finn's eyes were huge. "Mama!" they exclaimed, pointing at Catra. "Mom is still here!"

Catra gently placed her hands on Finn’s shoulders, holding their gaze.

Her heart hammered against her ribs, but her voice was steady, warm. "Finny, your mama and I have some big news." She saw Bow and Glimmer hovering by their car, trying to look casual and failing miserably.

Finn held their breath, eyes like saucers, their tail held perfectly still in anticipation. "Big news?"

"We were thinking," Catra continued, a wide smile spreading across her face, "that I could move back in. Permanently. And we could be your mom and mama together, all the time. And your mama and I could be each other’s wives again."

She paused, taking a breath. "Does that sound—"

Before she could even finish asking, Finn erupted.

"MOM'S MOVING BACK IN?!" they shrieked, pure, unadulterated joy radiating from every pore.

They whirled to face Adora, bouncing on the balls of their feet. "Mama! Did you hear that???? Mom's moving back in! For real?!"

Adora laughed, the sound bright and free, tears welling in her eyes again.

She ruffled Finn’s hair. "Yeah, buddy, I heard. Pretty cool, huh? Your mom and I talked about a lot of things, and we decided it was finally time for us all to live together again. As a family."

"This is the BEST DAY EVER!!!" Finn yelled, launching themselves at Catra and Adora for another crushing hug.

They wriggled free almost instantly, vibrating with excitement, their tail lashing wildly behind them. "We should order pizza! To celebrate! Can we? Please? With the spicy peppers Mama likes?"

Catra laughed, scooping Finn up in a hug. "Pizza sounds perfect."

Finn grabbed one of Catra's hands and one of Adora's, their claws pricking gently in their excitement, tugging them towards the open front door, already chattering a mile a minute about the best pizza toppings and how they could finally show Mom their newly organized BlipBase *right now*.

As Adora turned to follow Finn and Catra inside, she caught sight of Bow and Glimmer still standing by their car.

Bow was openly weeping, tears streaming down his face, a huge, tremulous smile breaking through. Glimmer was furiously wiping at her own eyes, trying to look stern but failing spectacularly, a wobbly smile tugging at her lips.

Adora met their gaze. She didn't need words. She simply nodded, hoping the depth of her gratitude—*thank you, for everything*—shone in her eyes.

Glimmer gave a sharp, tearful nod back. Bow waved, still beaming through his tears.

Adora stepped across the threshold.

The door closed softly behind her, sealing out the world. Inside, the hallway was filled with Finn's excited chatter and Catra's warm laughter as she tried to keep up with their rapid-fire pizza topping suggestions.

The scent of home—their home—wrapped around Adora: wood polish, faint traces of Finn's markers, Adora's cedar and sage shampoo, and now, undeniably, Catra's unique spice-and-fur scent woven back into the fabric of it.

She walked towards the sound of her family. Together. Safe. Healing. And profoundly, fiercely happy.

The shape of coming home, she realized, wasn't just a place.

It was this: the intertwined melody of their voices, the warmth of shared space, the unshakeable certainty that whatever came next, they would face it.

Together.

Chapter 13: New Foundations

Chapter Notes

Well, here we are friends, the last chapter <3

Thanks for going on this journey with me. Reading everyone's comments is something I look forward to every week.

'Seahaven', a Truman Show AU, begins uploading next Wednesday. Hope to see you there!

A physical ache was lodged deep in Catra's bones, authored by the rhythmic, soul-crushing *click-type-verify* of her data entry job. Her body had become a catalogue of grievances—throbbing wrists, concrete-knotted shoulders, a back that complained with every shift in her chair.

The world itself had taken on a persistent, low-grade fuzziness, her sight swimming with the ghostly afterimages of cells and grids long after she'd closed her eyes. Behind it all, the dull throb of an oncoming headache was a near-constant companion.

The apartment was gone, her place beside Adora reclaimed, Finn's world whole again, but this anchor of her self-imposed exile remained, dragging her down.

One evening, watching Adora effortlessly lift Finn into a spinning hug, Catra winced, massaging her own stiff wrist. The contrast was stark: Adora's sculpted strength, honed by disciplined workouts, versus her own body, shaped by stress, sedentary confinement, and the slow erosion of repetitive motion.

The fear, whispered by late-night internet searches and the persistent pain, solidified: *If I keep this up, I'll damage my hands permanently*.

Later, curled against Adora on the couch, Finn asleep upstairs, Catra voiced the thought that had been circling for weeks. "I think

I need to quit the data entry job, Adora."

Adora's arm tightened around her instantly. "Good," she said, the word firm and immediate. "That job was killing you, Catra. Literally draining the life out of you. I hate seeing you in pain."

Catra sighed, nestling closer. "I know. I was thinking maybe I could just scale back… Part-time, like before? But…" Even as she said it, a wave of exhaustion washed over her. The thought of logging even *half* as many hours felt like climbing a mountain.

Adora shifted, turning to face her more fully, her expression earnest in the soft lamplight.

"Catra," she said, her voice gentle but unwavering. "Listen to me. You don't *have* to have a job at all. Not if you don't want to. Being my wife? Being Finn's mom? That is *more* than enough. It's everything. You do such an amazing job taking care of this family, creating this home, loving us. You don't need to do any more than you already do. I can provide. We're secure. Let me take care of that."

The offer was pure Adora: generous, protective, born of love and a desire to shield Catra from any hardship. Warmth bloomed in Catra's chest, chased by a familiar flicker of resistance.

She reached up, tracing the line of Adora's jaw. "I know you can, dummy. And I love that you want to. I love how much you provide for us. But…"

She took a breath, searching for the right words. "I need something for *me*. Just a little bit. Part-time. Not because I have to, but because I *want* to. I want to feel like… like I'm contributing something tangible beyond just being here, wonderful as that is. I want to hang onto a bit of independence. Have my own money to spend without feeling like I have to ask you for an allowance."

Adora's brow furrowed slightly. "I wouldn't mind giving you an allowance, Catra. Seriously. It wouldn't feel like that to me."

Catra smiled, a small, understanding curve of her lips. "I know you wouldn't *mind*. But it would feel like that to *me*. Right now, anyway. Maybe that will change. But for now… having my own little income, knowing I earned it, feels important. It helps me feel like… I haven't lost myself completely in being 'Adora's wife' or 'Finn's mom', even though I love being both of those things." She met Adora's gaze. "Does that make sense?"

Adora studied her face for a long moment, the earnest blue eyes seeing past the words to the underlying need. She saw the pride, the lingering ghost of the fiercely independent woman who'd survived foster care by relying on no one. She saw the vulnerability of someone reclaiming a sense of self after profound upheaval.

Slowly, Adora nodded. "Yeah, Catra," she murmured, pulling her close again, pressing a kiss to her temple. "It makes perfect sense. Okay. Part-time. Something you actually *like*, that doesn't wreck your body. Deal?"

Relief, sweet and tangible, washed over Catra. She hadn't realized how much tension she'd held anticipating resistance.

"Deal," she breathed, snuggling into Adora's embrace. The path forward felt lighter already.

A few nights later, Catra sat on the edge of their bed, a small velvet box open in her palm.

The platinum band inside caught the lamplight, a cool, familiar gleam. She hadn't worn it since the day she'd slid it off her finger and left it on the dresser in this very room, a silent, devastating farewell.

Now, she traced the smooth metal with a claw tip, the familiar sensation sending a ghost of a memory across her skin—the weight of it on her finger, the cool slide of it as Adora had first placed it there.

Adora emerged from the ensuite bathroom, steam curling around her, towel-drying her hair. She paused in the doorway, her gaze instantly drawn to the box in Catra’s hand and the distant look on her face.

Catra’s tail was still, her ears angled slightly back in contemplation, not distress.

Adora approached quietly, sitting beside her on the bed. She didn’t touch the box, didn’t assume. Instead, she placed a hand gently on Catra’s back, her thumb making slow, soothing circles through the thin fabric of Catra’s sleep shirt.

"I'm seeing contemplation," Adora said softly, her voice warm and open. "What's coming up for you?"

Catra didn’t look up immediately. She kept her gaze on the ring, soaking in the quiet patience of Adora’s touch.

It was so different from how she would have charged in before, armed with solutions. The change was palpable, a testament to the well-worn copy of *Nonviolent Communication* that lived on her nightstand.

"I was just thinking," she began, her voice husky, "about how it felt to wear this for the first time." A small, bittersweet smile touched her lips. "I never thought I was 'marriage material,' Adora. After everything… trusting someone that much? Letting them that close? It felt impossible."

She finally lifted her eyes to Adora’s. "But after a few years with you… I had softened. Opened up so much. You… taught me how to trust. Slowly. Painfully sometimes. But you did." She touched the ring again. "Wearing this… it felt like proof. Proof of how far I’d come. Proof that I’d grown enough, healed enough, to let someone in so close they’d *want* to marry me. And for me to be brave enough to say yes!"

The memory brought a genuine warmth to her expression, momentarily eclipsing the sadness.

Adora’s hand moved from her back to her shoulder, squeezing gently, her other hand coming up to stroke the fur at the base of Catra’s ear in that calming way that always worked.

"You *did* work so hard, Catra," Adora murmured, her voice thick with remembered pride and present tenderness. "You fought through so much… so much trauma, so many walls. To be able to let yourself be soft. To have this with me. To be my wife."

Her thumb brushed the sensitive spot behind Catra’s ear. "I was in awe of your courage. Every single day."

Catra nodded, a sudden tightness in her throat. She tried to discreetly wipe at the corner of her eye. "And when I took it off…" Her voice cracked. She cleared her throat, forcing the words out. "When I took it off and left it here… it broke my heart, Adora. It felt like… like all that softness, all that opening up, had been a huge mistake. That I was always destined to be lonely, hurt, miserable. That I’d been a fool to believe in the dream we were living."

Her fingers closed over the box, not touching the ring. "Taking this off, leaving it… it felt like slamming the door shut on that softness. On that openness. On happiness."

A single tear escaped, tracing a path down her tawny fur.

Adora made a soft, pained sound. She wrapped both arms around Catra, pulling her close, pressing fervent kisses to the top of her head.

"Oh, Catra," she breathed, her own voice trembling with suppressed emotion. "It must have hurt you so terribly to do that. It broke *me* when I saw it sitting there. I watched you… I watched you come out of your shell, slowly, bravely, year after year. And on our wedding day…"

Adora swallowed hard, fighting her own tears. "Seeing you radiant, *happy*, letting yourself believe you deserved it… I was so

proud. So proud to be part of your journey. To be someone you finally felt safe enough to trust with your whole heart."

She held Catra tighter. "When I saw that ring… it was like the ground fell out from under me. Proof of how profoundly I'd failed you. I told you it was safe to drop your guard, and you trusted me. You let yourself be soft and vulnerable… and I hurt you so deeply that you stopped believing it was safe to trust *anyone*. That loneliness was all you could expect. Stars, Catra. I am so sorry."

Catra nodded against Adora's shoulder, the silent tears flowing freely now. Adora's understanding, her acknowledgment of the depth of the betrayal Catra had felt, was a balm even as it reopened the wound. They sat like that for long moments, Adora rocking her gently, the silence heavy with shared grief and the fragile beginnings of renewed understanding.

Finally, Catra pulled back slightly, sniffling. She wiped her eyes more thoroughly this time, then picked up the ring box. She didn't look at the ring. Instead, she turned it over in her hands, her expression thoughtful.

"And so… I was sitting here, looking at it," she continued, her voice steadier now, "and thinking… 'How is it going to feel to put it on *again*?'"

She looked up at Adora. "I know I could just… slide it back on right now. Pretend the last year and a half never happened. But I don't want to pretend, Adora. And I think…"

She held the box out, pressing it firmly into Adora's hand. "I want *you* to hold onto this. Keep it safe. Hold onto it until… until you find a moment that feels truly special to you. Some time when I'm joyful, unguarded… when our hearts are just bursting with love. I want to have a special memory, a *new* memory, to associate with finally putting this ring back on. A moment that feels like a new beginning, not just going back."

She searched Adora’s eyes. "Can you do that for me?"

Adora stared down at the small box in her palm, then back up at Catra. Her blue eyes shimmered, tears finally spilling over, tracing silent paths down her cheeks. The trust inherent in the request, the symbolism… it overwhelmed her.

She curled her fingers tightly around the box, bringing it to her chest for a moment before meeting Catra’s gaze again.

Her voice was a husky whisper, thick with emotion. "It would be my honor, Catra."

The ring box became a constant, subtle weight in Adora’s pocket or her bedside drawer.

She carried it with her, a quiet secret, waiting for the perfect moment. She envisioned grand gestures–a romantic dinner, a walk under the stars, maybe recreating their first date.

But nothing felt quite right. The pressure of finding *the* moment was immense.

Life settled into a new, sweeter rhythm. Catra quit her job, the relief almost tangible in the way her shoulders seemed to permanently unclench.

She started browsing job listings for part-time work—library assistant, receptionist at a small art studio, even helping out a few afternoons a week at a local cat rescue (which made Adora grin).

The search itself seemed to energize her, a reclaiming of agency.

Finn thrived in the reunited household. Their laughter was louder, their energy brighter. But the deep hurt and confusion of the separation hadn’t magically vanished.

It was a riptide lurking beneath the surface of their newfound calm, and it pulled Finn under without warning.

One evening, Catra was getting ready for a long-overdue girls' night with Scorpia and Perfuma. She was excited, humming as she applied a touch of eyeliner, looking forward to laughter and gossip.

Finn was playing quietly on the living room floor with their tablet, ears relaxed, tail flicking idly. As Catra grabbed her purse and called out, "Okay, Finny, Mom’s heading out! Be good for Mama!" Finn looked up.

The change was instantaneous. Their face crumpled, ears snapped flat against their head. The tablet tumbled from their hands as they scrambled up, tears already welling. "NO!" they wailed, the sound raw and terrified. "DON'T GO, MOM! PLEASE DON'T GO!"

Catra froze, startled. "Finn? Sweetheart, what’s wrong? I’m just going to see Auntie Scorpia and Auntie Perfuma. I’ll be back before bedtime!"

But Finn wasn't hearing logic. They launched themselves at Catra, clinging to her legs with desperate strength, sobbing uncontrollably.

Small claws pricking through the fabric of her pants.

“YOU SAID YOU WEREN'T LEAVING! YOU SAID YOU WERE STAYING! BUT YOU'RE GOING AWAY! LIKE BEFORE!"

"YOU'RE GOING TO LEAVE AND NOT COME BACK AND I'LL NEVER SEE YOU AGAIN!"

The words tumbled out, choked with hysteria, carrying the weight of a year’s worth of unspoken fear and abandonment.

Catra’s heart shattered. She sank to her knees, wrapping her arms tightly around the trembling child. Adora rushed in from the kitchen, her face pale with concern. "Finn, baby, what—"

"I MISSED YOU SO MUCH!" Finn cried into Catra's shoulder, their whole body shuddering. "WHEN YOU LIVED AT THE APARTMENT! IT WAS SO SAD AND QUIET WITHOUT YOU! I WAS SO SCARED YOU WOULD JUST DISAPPEAR! AND NOW YOU'RE GOING AGAIN!"

Catra held Finn close, rocking them gently, her own tears falling silently onto Finn's blonde hair.

She knew, intellectually, that leaving had been necessary. But sitting here, feeling the raw terror and grief radiating from her child, the guilt was a physical pain.

"Oh, Finny," she whispered, her voice thick. "I am so, so sorry. I'm sorry I hurt you. I'm sorry I made you feel scared and alone. I never, ever wanted that."

She stroked their hair, letting them cry, absorbing the storm of their emotions. "I missed you too. Every single day. It was awful being away from you."

Adora knelt beside them, placing a reassuring hand on Finn's back. "Mom's not leaving like that, sweetheart," Adora said, her voice calm and steady. "She's just going out for a few hours with her friends. Like Mama goes to work, or like you go to Kyle's house to play. She's coming back. She promised to live here with us, remember?"

Finn's sobs began to subside into hiccupping breaths, but they clung tighter.

"But… but you *promised* before… and then you left…" they mumbled against Catra's neck, the accusation small and devastating.

Catra pulled back slightly, cupping Finn's tear-streaked face. She looked into their watery blue eyes, seeing the lingering fear.

"I know, baby. I know I broke that promise before. And that must make it really, really hard to trust me now when I say I'm

staying." She brushed a tear away with her thumb. "I can’t undo the hurt I caused. I wish I could. But I’m going to keep trying, every single day, to show you that I mean it. That I’m here. That this is my home. That you are my most important person, along with Mama."

She glanced at Adora, finding unwavering support in her eyes. "And if Mama and I ever have a big fight again—which, grown-ups sometimes do—we promise we’ll work it out together, with our words. We won’t just leave. We’ll figure it out, together, right here. Because this is our family. All three of us. Okay?"

Finn sniffled, searching Catra’s face, then Adora’s. Their ears, still low but no longer pinned flat, twitched slightly. The absolute conviction they saw seemed to finally penetrate the fear.

They nodded slowly, burrowing back into Catra’s embrace. "Okay," they whispered, small and exhausted.

Catra held them, murmuring reassurances until Finn’s breathing evened out, their grip loosening, claws retracting, the storm passing.

She exchanged a look with Adora over Finn’s head—a look of shared pain, understanding, and fierce determination. The healing wasn't just for them; it was a family project.

Catra quietly texted Scorpia and Perfuma, cancelling her night out.

Some things were more important.

Adora kept the ring box close, the search for the right moment now layered with a deeper understanding of the fragility and resilience of their family bond.

Finn’s ninth birthday arrived—a stark contrast to the tense, subdued affair of the year before. It was a day filled with shrieks

of laughter, friends, cake, and Finn beaming with uncomplicated joy.

It felt like a triumph, a celebration of the light returning to their lives.

As Catra laughed, helping Finn unwrap a box containing the exact BlipBase expansion pack they'd been begging for, Adora's hand drifted to her pocket.

Is this it?

The joy was palpable. But something held her back.

Finn deserved this day to be entirely theirs. Catra deserved to bask in her child's happiness without the weight of a profound, personal moment. It felt like sharing the spotlight unnecessarily.

Another opportunity arose during a boisterous weekend brunch with Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Perfuma.

Catra was relaxed, leaning back in her chair, teasing Scorpia about her latest disastrous baking attempt, her laughter bright and genuine. Surrounded by their closest friends, radiating ease and affection, she looked utterly at peace.

Adora's fingers closed around the box.

Here? Now?

But again, she hesitated. The moment felt wonderful, but… shared.

Adora realized, with sudden clarity, that she wanted this to be just for them. A private covenant reaffirmed, witnessed only by the love flowing between them.

She wanted Catra's undivided reaction, a moment suspended solely in their shared universe.

Later, tangled in the sheets, bodies humming with the aftershocks of intense intimacy, Catra purring contentedly against Adora's chest, the thought surfaced again.

Now? The connection was deep, primal, euphoric.

But Adora looked down at Catra, her face softened by pleasure and exhaustion, and knew it wasn't right.

Their marriage was built on so much more than physical passion—on shared history, hard-won trust, co-parenting, mutual respect, the quiet comfort of daily life. To tie the symbol of that complex, beautiful tapestry solely to the afterglow of sex felt… reductive. It felt like cheapening the depth of what they were rebuilding.

She wanted a moment that encompassed *all* of it.

The perfect moment arrived not with fanfare, but in the ordinary, golden light of a Tuesday morning.

Chaos reigned in the kitchen. Adora was scrambling eggs for their breakfast, the sizzle a familiar morning soundtrack. Catra was slicing strawberries beside her, humming off-key, adding them to a bowl of yogurt and granola.

Finn, however, was frantically searching for a misplaced permission slip, their fluffy tail lashing in agitation, their backpack gaping open on a chair, the morning routine suddenly derailed.

"Mom! Have you seen my field trip form? The one for the planetarium? It was *right here!*" Finn wailed, dumping the contents of their lunchbox onto the table in desperation, their ears flattened against their head in distress.

The search had begun *after* breakfast prep was underway, throwing their carefully timed schedule into disarray.

Catra paused, knife hovering over a strawberry. "Field trip form? Finn, sweetie, didn't you put it on your desk last night? After Mama signed it?"

Finn froze. Comprehension dawned, followed by sheepish relief, their ears perking straight up. "Oh! Right!" They dropped their backpack and bolted out of the kitchen, a blur of dark blonde fur.

Catra laughed, the sound warm and full of affectionate exasperation. "Just try to remember next time, space ranger!" Catra called out, fondly.

Adora stood by the stove, spatula forgotten.

She watched Catra. Sunlight streamed through the window, catching the gold flecks in her mismatched eyes, illuminating the soft laugh lines around them.

She was bathed in the warm, ordinary glow of morning, effortlessly managing the minor crisis, her focus entirely on Finn, her posture relaxed and strong.

She was *here*. Fully present. In *their* home. Laughing. Taking care of their family.

The simple, beautiful reality of it hit Adora with a force that stilled the air in her lungs. This wasn't a grand occasion or a moment of heightened passion. This was the bedrock. The daily choosing. The messy, loving, ordinary miracle of their life rebuilt.

A feeling of terrifying lightness—an expansion in her chest—flooded Adora.

It felt like joy, but deeper. Like coming home to her own soul. Without conscious thought, she turned off the stove. She wiped her hands on a towel, her heart hammering against her ribs.

She crossed the few steps to where Catra stood by the counter.

"Catra?"

Catra turned, a smile still playing on her lips from Finn’s antics. "Hmm? Did the eggs—" The smile faltered, replaced by a look of genuine fondness as she saw Adora’s expression.

Then, her eyes widened in pure surprise as Adora gently took her left hand.

Adora gazed into her beautiful, beloved face, the morning light making her fur seem to glow. She saw the confusion, the dawning realization.

Holding Catra’s gaze, Adora sank slowly, deliberately, to one knee on their kitchen floor.

She reached into her pocket, pulling out the small, worn velvet box she’d carried every day. She opened it, the platinum ring gleaming against the dark velvet.

Catra’s free hand flew to her mouth, her eyes instantly bright with unshed tears.

"Adora…?" she whispered, disbelief and hope warring in her voice.

"Catra," Adora began, her voice trembling slightly but filled with absolute conviction. "I want this life with you. Forever. Raising our amazing kid. Laughing together, even at seven in the morning over misplaced permission slips. Solving problems as a team, big and small. Building our days, exactly like this."

She took a steadying breath, her eyes locked with Catra’s.

"I’ve never met anyone as strong as you. As fiercely protective and loyal. As sweet beneath the sharp edges. As sensitive and brave. You fight for what you love, and you taught me how to fight smarter, how to listen, how to truly *see* the people I love. You challenge me and ground me and make me want to be better, every single day."

She swallowed, the words pouring from her heart.

"Catra D’riluth, would you marry me? Again? Would you be my wife?"

Tears spilled freely down Catra’s cheeks now, tracing paths through her fine cheek fur. The hand over her mouth lowered, trembling slightly.

She looked from the ring to Adora’s face, radiant with love and nervous hope. A smile, brilliant and tremulous, broke through the tears.

"Adora Gray," she breathed, her voice thick with emotion but clear as a bell. "I would love to be your wife. Again. Always." She sniffed, wiping her cheek with the back of her hand.

"I've never met anyone who cares as deeply about other people as you do. You’re so earnest, so determined to do the right thing, to fix what’s broken. You take such incredible care of me and Finn, building a world where we feel safe and loved…"

Her voice caught, then strengthened.

"And I want to take care of you just as much. Be your safe place too. Your rock. Your home." She squeezed Adora’s hand tightly. "Now," she added, a watery chuckle escaping her, "would you please put that ring on my finger and kiss me before our kid comes back?"

A wet laugh burst from Adora, relief and joy mingling. Her hands shook only slightly as she carefully lifted the cool platinum band from its velvet nest. She slid it onto Catra’s left ring finger, over the finely furred skin.

It settled into place, a familiar, perfect weight.

For a heartbeat, Catra was utterly still, overwhelmed by the physical proof of a promise kept. A sharp gasp escaped her lips, followed by a full-body shudder of release that ruffled the fur along her arms. It was the feeling of a door she'd slammed shut finally swinging open—the cool metal an anchor pulling her back to the woman she had fought to become, the one who believed she was worthy of this.

Her eyes closed, searing the feeling into memory, before opening to meet Adora’s, brimming with tears and shining with love.

Adora surged to her feet, pulling Catra into a tight embrace, one hand still clasping Catra’s left hand between them. She kissed her fiercely, pouring all the love, the commitment, the gratitude, the fierce determination to cherish and protect this second chance into the contact, the cool metal of the ring pressed between their palms a tangible seal on their renewed vow.

The sound of small feet pounding back into the room broke them apart. Finn skidded to a halt, permission slip clutched in hand. They took in the scene—Mom and Mama clinging to each other, faces tear-streaked but glowing—with typical nine-year-old impatience.

"Mom! Mama!" they exclaimed, bouncing on their toes. "There's no time for kissing! Mom has to take me to school *now*! I'm gonna be late!"

Catra and Adora pulled back, laughing, hastily wiping their eyes.

They shared a look—a look of profound understanding, shared joy, and the crystal-clear knowledge that this utterly ordinary, extraordinary moment would be etched into their memories forever.

"Alright, alright, kiddo," Catra bantered, her voice still thick with emotion but playful. "No kissing while I'm on the clock, got it." She grabbed her keys and a banana for Finn so they’d eat *something* before school, ushering Finn towards the door.

Finn waved frantically at Adora. "Bye, Mama! Have a good day at work!"

"Yeah, Mama," Catra echoed, pausing at the doorway, her eyes meeting Adora’s one more time, sparkling with unshed tears and pure happiness. "Have a good day at work."

The door closed behind them.

The sudden silence in the kitchen wasn't oppressive. It was comfortable. Warm. *Lived-in*.

Sunlight slanted across the counter where Catra had been slicing fruit, glinted off the abandoned spatula near the cooling eggs, illuminated the faint dust motes dancing in the air.

Adora stood amidst it, the echoes of her family's voices—Finn's impatient energy, Catra's tear-choked laughter, her own trembling proposal—still ringing in her ears.

Her heart pounded, a joyous, frantic rhythm against her ribs.

She took a deep, shuddering breath, trying to commit every sensory detail to memory: the smell of coffee and eggs, the warmth of the sun on her skin, the cool weight of the now-empty ring box still in her pocket, the incredible, terrifying lightness in her chest.

She looked around their kitchen—*their* kitchen, vibrant and slightly messy, filled with the evidence of their shared life. Work felt like a distant planet.

With a sense of calm certainty, Adora pulled out her phone. She navigated to her email, her fingers moving swiftly. The subject line: **Working Remotely Today**. The message to Hope Sterling was brief and professional:

> *Hope,*

> *Working from home today. I'll ensure all essential tasks for the Bright Moon Plaza deadline are completed. Anything non-essential will be prioritized for tomorrow.*

> *Best,*

> *Adora*

She hit send and pocketed her phone.

A slow smile spread across her face. She’d surprise Catra when she got back. Maybe they could walk to that new café for lunch. Or just stay in, talk, hold each other, bask in the quiet miracle of their ordinary, reclaimed life.

The details didn't matter.

There was nothing Adora wanted more than to spend the day simply *being* with her wife. Her partner. Her home.

The ring on Catra’s finger was a promise kept, a circle closed, and a beautiful, bright line drawn into their future.

Together.

End Notes

Please leave a comment, they truly make my day !

Shattered Trust, Fragile Hope updates every Wednesday <3

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